GNAMMA RESEARCH · PRIMARY TEXTS

بداية الحكمة

Bidāyat al-Ḥikma

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Reading edition

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Introduction

مقدمة

INTRODUCTION

Author's introduction: subject and end of philosophy

مقدمة في تعريف هذا الفن وموضوعه وغايته

Praise belongs to God, and to Him belongs praise in its true reality. Blessings and peace be upon His Messenger Muḥammad, the best of His creatures, and upon the pure members of his household and descendants.

Divine wisdom is a science that investigates the conditions of an existent insofar as it is existent. Its subject—the thing whose essential attributes are investigated—is the existent precisely as existent. Its aim is to know existents universally and to distinguish them from what has no true existence.

To explain: a person finds in himself that he possesses reality and actuality, and finds a reality beyond himself that he can attain. He pursues a thing only because he takes it to be what it really is, and recoils from something only because he takes it truly to be the thing from which he recoils. An infant seeking the breast, for instance, seeks what is really milk, not what mere conjecture takes to be milk; and one who flees a wild beast flees what is truly a wild beast, not an imaginary or fabulous creature.

Yet a person's judgment may err. He may regard what is not real as actually existent, as with supposed good luck or monsters; or he may dismiss something actual as mythical, as with an immaterial soul or an immaterial intellect. The need therefore arises, from the outset, to investigate the determinations proper to an existent as such, by which genuine existents can be distinguished from things that are not real. This investigation is divine wisdom.

Divine wisdom is also called first philosophy and the highest science. Its subject is the existent insofar as it is existent. Its aim is to distinguish real existents from others and to know the higher causes of existence—above all the First Cause, at which the series of existents terminates—together with His most beautiful names and exalted attributes. This is God, exalted be His name.

1. **editorial:** Independently rendered from the Arabic; the uploaded published English version is a comparison source, not copied into this edition.
2. **Source:** Supplied bilingual PDF, Arabic original · p. 11 https://lib.rafed.net/m/?b_id=1571&type=c_fbook

STAGE I

Existence: General Questions

كليات مباحث الوجود

CHAPTER 1

The self-evident concept of existence

الفصل الأول في بداهة مفهوم الوجود

The concept of existence is self-evident: it is grasped through itself, without anything else mediating our understanding. No real definition (ḥadd) or descriptive definition (rasm) can make it known, because what makes something known must be clearer and more evident than what is made known.

Accordingly, expressions offered as definitions—such as saying that existence, or an existent as existent, is “that which is established in reality,” or “that about which a statement can be made”—are explanations of a name, not genuine definitions. Moreover, as will be shown, existence has no genus, specific differentia, or proper accident in the sense of the five universals. Since a genuine defining account is composed of such elements, existence has no defining account.

1. **editorial synthesis of lecture notes:** A self-evident concept (badīhī) does not need to be inferred from a prior definition. The notes distinguish our clear conception of existence from the philosophical difficulty of explaining the reality of existence. (Krishnan, printed p. 9; attribution to the lecturer as mediated by the note-taker.)
2. **Source:** Bidayat al-Hikma, supplied bilingual PDF (Arabic original) · p. 14 https://lib.rafed.net/m/?b_id=1571&type=c_fbook

CHAPTER 2

The univocal concept of existence

الفصل الثاني في أن مفهوم الوجود مشترك معنوي

Existence is predicated of its subjects with one meaning: the term has a common intelligible signification, not merely the same verbal sound.

One indication is our division of existence into different classes. We distinguish the existence of the Necessary from that of the contingent; the contingent into substance and accident; and both substance and accident into their further kinds. Such a division can be valid only when what is divided is one and the same item of intelligible consideration, found in each division.

Another indication is that we can establish that something exists while remaining uncertain about its specific nature. We might establish that the world has a maker, yet wonder whether this maker is necessary or contingent, or whether it has a quiddity. We might establish that a human being has a soul, yet doubt whether the soul is material or immaterial, substance or accident. Our recognition of its existence remains in place. If “existence” were merely a homonym whose meaning changed with each subject, our understanding of existence would necessarily change whenever we changed our belief about that subject.

A third indication is that nonexistence contradicts existence and has one meaning, since nonexistence itself admits no distinction. Existence, its contradictory, likewise has one meaning; otherwise the two contradictories would both fail to apply, which is impossible.

Those who insist that “existence” is merely homonymous among things, or between the Necessary and the contingent, seek to avoid affirming any kinship between cause and effect, and especially between God and creatures. But their view abolishes intelligible knowledge. When we say “the Necessary exists,” either we understand “exists” in the sense understood of a contingent, in which case there is a common meaning; or we understand its contrary, thereby denying existence of the Necessary; or we understand nothing at all, thereby rendering the intellect incapable of knowledge. The last alternative conflicts with what we necessarily find in our own experience.

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1. **editorial synthesis of lecture notes:** The notes distinguish a shared meaning (ishtirāk maʿnawī) from accidental homonymy (ishtirāk lafẓī): saying God and a human exist need not make their modes of existence identical. (Krishnan, printed p. 10; attribution to the lecturer as mediated by the note-taker.)
2. **Source:** Bidayat al-Hikma, supplied bilingual PDF (Arabic original) · p. 16 https://lib.rafed.net/m/?b_id=1571&type=c_fbook

CHAPTER 3

Existence is distinct from quiddity

الفصل الثالث في أن الوجود زائد على الماهية عارض لها

Existence is additional to quiddity, in the sense that understanding the one is not the same as understanding the other. The intellect can abstract the quiddity—the answer to “What is it?”—consider it separately, and then attribute existence to it. This is what is meant here by the attribution of existence. Existence is therefore neither identical with quiddity nor one of its constituents.

The proof is, first, that existence can truly be denied of a quiddity. Were existence identical with the quiddity or part of it, such denial would be impossible: one cannot deny a thing of itself or deny one of its constitutive elements of it.

Second, asserting existence of a quiddity may require a proof. Existence is therefore neither its very essence nor one of its essential constituents; what a thing is, together with its essential constituents, belongs to it self-evidently and does not require a separate demonstration.

Third, a quiddity considered in itself stands equally toward existence and nonexistence. Were existence the quiddity itself or part of it, its standing toward nonexistence, the contradictory of existence, would be impossible.

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1. **editorial synthesis of lecture notes:** The notes distinguish the concept of a quiddity from an existential assertion. The ability to deny that a quiddity is instantiated helps show that existence is not a constituent of its essential definition. (Krishnan, printed p. 12; attribution to the lecturer as mediated by the note-taker.)
2. **Source:** Bidayat al-Hikma, supplied bilingual PDF (Arabic original) · p. 18 https://lib.rafed.net/m/?b_id=1571&type=c_fbook

CHAPTER 4

The primacy of existence and the derivative status of quiddity

الفصل الرابع في أصالة الوجود واعتبارية الماهية

There is no doubt that actual things possess actual effects and are not mere products of someone's fancy. Yet from each such thing, which is one in external reality, we abstract two concepts: existence and quiddity. They differ as concepts while having one external instance. Thus, of a human being outside the mind, we can understand both that it is human and that it exists.

Philosophers differ about which of these is primary. The Peripatetics are said to affirm the primacy of existence; the Illuminationists are associated with the primacy of quiddity. No philosopher holds that both are independently primary, for that would make every one thing into two things. The correct position is that existence is primary.

Here is one demonstration. Quiddity considered simply as quiddity is indifferent to existence and nonexistence. If its emergence from that indifference into actuality, with the consequent real effects, occurred by quiddity alone rather than through existence, quiddity would turn into what it was not, an impossibility. Existence therefore brings it beyond indifference and is primary.

It might be said that quiddity acquires a relation to its producer and thereby becomes actual. But if the relation really changes its condition, what differentiates the two conditions is precisely primary existence, whatever we call it. If the condition is not different and effects nevertheless follow, the same impossible transformation returns.

A further demonstration is that quiddities, considered in themselves, are sources of plurality and difference. Unless existence were primary, there could be no real unity between diverse quiddities and hence no genuine predication, whose basis is unity in existence. But predication plainly

occurs; existence must therefore be primary, existent in itself, while quiddity exists through it.

A third demonstration begins from external and mental existence. A quiddity present externally produces its appropriate effects; the very same quiddity, present in the mind, produces none of those external effects. Were quiddity primary rather than existence, there could be no difference between the two modes, since the quiddity remains the same. But there is a difference; thus the primary reality belongs to existence.

A fourth demonstration appeals to priority and posteriority, strength and weakness, potentiality and actuality. Quiddity by itself is indifferent to these determinations, yet external things differ in them: a cause may be prior and stronger, an effect posterior and weaker; one thing is potential, another actual. Their differences cannot arise from quiddity considered as indifferent to every such determination. They therefore belong primarily to existence. Other arguments are treated in longer works.

Defenders of the primacy of quiddity object that if existence itself were actual, existence would possess an existence, and that existence another, generating an infinite regress. The answer is that existence is indeed existent, but through its own reality—not through some additional existence. No regress follows.

This also shows the weakness of a position attributed to Jalāl al-Dīn al-Dawwānī: that existence is primary in the Necessary and quiddity primary in contingents. On that account “existent” means existence itself when said of the Necessary, but means something related to existence when said of contingent quiddities, much as “milkman” or “date-seller” designates someone related to milk or dates. According to the position adopted here, existence is actual through itself, whereas quiddity is actual through it, by attribution.

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1. **editorial synthesis of lecture notes:** The lecture explains the primacy of existence (aṣālat al-wujūd) through concrete effects, unity of predication, and external versus mental existence. Use the author’s own four arguments as controlling evidence. (Krishnan, printed p. 13; attribution to the lecturer as mediated by the note-taker.)
2. **Source:** Bidayat al-Hikma, supplied bilingual PDF (Arabic original) · p. 20 https://lib.rafed.net/m/?b_id=1571&type=c_fbook

CHAPTER 5

Existence as one graded reality

الفصل الخامس في أن الوجود حقيقة واحدة مشككة

Those who affirm the primacy of existence have disagreed about the nature of its reality. Some maintain that existence is one reality admitting degrees (ḥaqīqa wāḥida mushakkika), a view attributed to the ancient Persian sages. Since existence is manifest in itself and manifests quiddities

other than itself, they compare it with sensible light: light appears by itself and makes opaque objects visible.

Light, considered precisely as light, is one kind of reality present across its stronger and weaker degrees. A stronger light is stronger in the very luminosity it shares with a weaker light; the weaker is weaker in that same luminosity. The greater intensity is not an additional essential constituent that would exclude weaker light from the kind, nor is it an accident external to luminosity. Similarly, a weak light is not a compound of light and darkness, since darkness is privative. Intensity and weakness belong to luminosity itself. Light therefore has a range of degrees, each further diversified by the differing bodies that receive it.

Likewise, existence is a single reality with different ranks distinguished by intensity and weakness, priority and posteriority, and other such respects. The very respect in which its degrees differ is the respect in which they are united. A degree's distinguishing character is neither an essential component superadded to existence, since existence is simple, nor something extraneous to existence, since the doctrine of primacy denies that another independently real principle stands outside it. Each degree has its own intrinsic determination.

There is thus a vertical multiplicity of degrees, extending from the lowest degree—prime matter, whose actuality is scarcely more than potentiality and which stands at the horizon of non-being—towards the rank necessary through itself, limited by nothing save the absence of limitation. There is also a horizontal multiplicity in the diverse quiddities through which determinate existents are distinguished.

Certain Peripatetics, however, have understood existences as realities wholly different in their very essences. They infer their difference from the variety of their effects, and infer their complete essential difference from the simplicity of each. On this account, the common concept of existence would be an accidental predicate external to these realities, though inseparably accompanying them.

The sound view, the author argues, is that existence is one reality admitting degrees. For if it were a collection of wholly disparate realities, the single concept of existence would have to be abstracted from them *precisely as disparate*. But concept and instance correspond in what they signify, differing in the mode of being—mental or external. A concept one in its signification cannot derive its common significance from multiplicity *as multiplicity*. If the intension of this one concept included only the particularity of one instance, it would not apply to another; if it included both particularities, it would apply to neither. If it excludes those particularities and expresses what they share, then it was abstracted from them in respect of unity, not sheer disparity.

Finally, existence admits degrees because there are real perfections—intensity and weakness, priority and posteriority, potentiality and actuality—that differ without falling outside the one reality. Existence is therefore one yet manifold within itself: what distinguishes its degrees returns to the very reality in which they agree. This is *gradation* (tashkīk).

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1. **editorial synthesis of lecture notes:** The light comparison teaches graded existence (tashkīk); the lecture's illustration is pedagogical, not a demonstration that creatures are numerically identical with God. (Krishnan, printed p. 18; attribution to the lecturer as mediated by the note-taker.)
2. **Translator's note:** 'The point of distinction returns to the point of agreement' (يرجع ما به الامتياز إلى ما به الاشتراك) is the formal thesis of existential gradation. It does not say that individual quiddities are all definitionally identical.
3. **Terminology:** The analogy with light concerns intensity within one reality. It does not make sensible light the material substrate of being, nor does it identify prime matter with absolute non-being.
4. **Source:** Bidayat al-Hikma, supplied bilingual PDF (Arabic original) · p. 24 https://lib.rafed.net/m/?b_id=1571&type=c_fbook

CHAPTER 6

How existence is particularised

الفصل السادس في ما يتخصص به الوجود

Existence is particularised in three ways. First, its one original reality is determined by its own self-subsistent nature. Second, it is particularised through the distinctive characters of its degrees, which are not external to those degrees. Third, it is particularised through its relation to the different quiddities of which existence is predicated. In this third respect, existence varies with quiddities only accidentally—that is, by consideration of its association with them.

The 'accruing' (ʿurūḍ) of existence to a quiddity, and its being established for that quiddity, is not an instance of categorial inherence in which an accident requires its subject to be already actual. Rather, for existence to obtain for a quiddity is precisely for that quiddity to obtain *through existence*. This is what follows from the primacy of existence and the derivative status of quiddity. The intellect, accustomed to speaking in terms of quiddities, takes the quiddity as the grammatical subject and predicates existence of it, whereas the underlying ontological dependence runs in the opposite direction.

This resolves the famous difficulty about predicating existence of quiddity. According to the rule of subsidiarity (qāʿidat al-farʿiyya), the establishment of something for a subject presupposes that subject's establishment. If existence is to be established for a quiddity, must not the quiddity already be established? If its prior establishment is identical with the existence about to be predicated, the same thing would precede itself. If different, a further establishment would be required, and the regress would continue indefinitely.

This difficulty has led some thinkers to exempt predications of existence from the rule. Others replace its language of dependence with entailment: the establishment of something for a subject entails the subject's establishment, possibly by that very predicate. Still others deny that existence itself has an independent obtaining either mentally or externally, or distinguish only a universal meaning of existence and its qualified ‘shares’ rather than concrete individuals. The author judges these responses inadequate.

His answer is that the rule governs *the establishment of one thing for another*, not the *establishment of the thing itself*. In other terms, it applies to a composite existential proposition —‘this subject is such-and-such’—and not to a simple existential proposition—‘this exists’. It is a logical error to require a quiddity to exist already in order for the existence that actualises it to obtain.

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1. **editorial synthesis of lecture notes:** Especially helpful: the notes distinguish simple existential predication (halliyya basīṭa) from attributing an additional quality (halliyya murakkaba). The rule that establishing a property requires a subject does not generate a regress for ‘X exists’. (Krishnan, printed p. 23; attribution to the lecturer as mediated by the note-taker.)
2. **Terminology:** Hal hādhihi basīṭa (‘simple whether-it-is’) affirms existence; hal murakkaba (‘composite whether-it-is’) attributes a further predicate to a subject. The subsidiarity rule concerns the latter and must not be applied to the former without qualification.
3. **Translator's note:** ‘Accruing to’ (ʿurūḍ) is a predicative expression here; it is not the inherence of existence as one more categorial accident. This distinction is central for later comparisons with Avicennian and Thomistic accounts of esse.
4. **Source:** Bidayat al-Hikma, supplied bilingual PDF (Arabic original) · p. 28 https://lib.rafed.net/m/?b_id=1571&type=c_fbook

CHAPTER 7

Negative properties of existence

الفصل السابع في أحكام الوجود السلبية

Existence has a number of negative properties. First, it has no ‘other’ wholly alien to it. Once originality belongs exclusively to the reality of existence, anything posited outside it as an independently actual reality is thereby deprived of such reality.

Second, existence has no second alongside it. Its single original reality, with every purportedly independent ‘other’ denied, contains no alien ingredient or extraneous addition. Existence considered in its purity cannot be doubled or repeated. Any alleged second would either return to the same reality or be distinguished by something other than existence, contrary to the supposition.

Third, existence is neither substance nor accident. Substance is a *quiddity* which, when it exists externally, exists not in a subject. But existence is not a quiddity. An accident depends in its existence upon a subject; existence, by contrast, obtains through its own reality, and everything else is established through it.

Fourth, existence is not a constituent part of another thing, since the proposed additional constituent would have to be an independently real other. The familiar description of a contingent thing as a composition of quiddity and existence is an intellectual consideration of the correlation between contingent existence and quiddity, not the union of two equally original parts.

Fifth, existence has no parts of its own. Parts may be intellectual, such as genus and differentia; extramental, such as matter and form; or quantitative, such as portions of a line, surface, or mathematical body. Existence admits none of these. It has no genus and differentia: if its genus were existence, the differentia would have to determine what is already determinate by its own very nature; if the genus were other than existence, we would be positing the impossible ‘other’. Matter and form, considered as constituents, correspond to genus and differentia under a different mode of consideration, so this kind of division is likewise excluded. Quantitative parts presuppose a body with magnitude, whereas existence is neither a body nor a constituent form of body.

It also follows that existence is not a species produced by individual differentiation: it is intrinsically determinate through its own reality.

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1. **Interpretive note:** The denial that *existence* is substance or accident does not entail that *existents* cannot be categorised as substances and accidents. The author is denying that the reality of wujūd is itself a genus, a species, or a categorial accident.
2. **Source:** Bidayat al-Hikma, supplied bilingual PDF (Arabic original) · p. 31 https://lib.rafed.net/m/?b_id=1571&type=c_fbook

CHAPTER 8

The meaning of nafs al-amr

الفصل الثامن في معنى نفس الأمر

We have established that the reality of existence obtains and is actual through itself—or rather, that existence just is obtaining and actuality. Quiddities, by contrast, answer the question ‘What is it?’ and obtain through existence rather than through their bare natures. They may exist externally, in which case their proper effects follow, or mentally, where those external effects do not follow. Existence and quiddity are nevertheless united in the concrete existent.

There are also intellectual concepts formed through consideration rather than abstracted as quiddities from extramental things. Such notions as existence, unity, and causality have a kind of establishment through the instances they express, although the notions themselves are not included in the essential definitions of those instances as quiddities are included in the definitions of their individuals.

The broad kind of establishment embracing existence, quiddity, and these intellectual concepts is called *nafs al-amr*—‘the fact of the matter’ or what actually obtains in the relevant order. The truth of a proposition is measured by its correspondence to this. Hence we say that something is thus-and-so *in nafs al-amr*.

Some propositions have an extramental subject and predicate, such as ‘the Necessary Existent exists’, or ‘the human being has the capacity to laugh’. They are true by correspondence to extramental reality. Other propositions concern an intellectual subject or make a judgment about something as mentally considered: ‘a universal is either essential or accidental’, or ‘human is a species’. These are true by correspondence to their appropriate intellectual order.

Both classes correspond to nafs al-amr. Consequently, establishment *in nafs al-amr* is broader than establishment in either the mind or extramental reality considered in isolation.

Some have identified nafs al-amr with a separate intellect containing the forms of all intelligibles, so that true judgments correspond to its forms. But the author objects that the question simply recurs: by virtue of what are the judgments within that intellect true? Their contents too require an obtaining reality distinct from the bare judgment, to which they correspond.

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1. **editorial synthesis of lecture notes:** The note’s treatment of nafs al-amr clarifies that objective truth need not be reduced to a separate physical instance. Keep this distinct from a mental representation arbitrarily invented by the knower. (Krishnan, printed p. 28; attribution to the lecturer as mediated by the note-taker.)
2. **Translator's note:** Nafs al-amr here denotes the objective order relative to which assertions are true; it is not straightforwardly identical with the mind, the external world alone, or an independently posited cosmic archive of propositions.
3. **Terminology:** The word iʿtibārī can describe intellectual notions grounded in real instances; it should not automatically be rendered as ‘fictitious’ or ‘conventional’ in this setting.
4. **Source:** Bidayat al-Hikma, supplied bilingual PDF (Arabic original) · p. 34 https://lib.rafed.net/m/?b_id=1571&type=c_fbook

CHAPTER 9

Thingness is coextensive with existence

الفصل التاسع الشيئية تساوق الوجود

Thingness (*shayʾiyya*) is coextensive with existence. Non-being has no thingness, for it is sheer nullity without any positive establishment. In this sense, affirmation or establishment stands with existence, negation with non-existence.

A position ascribed to the Muʿtazila makes establishment (*thubūt*) more extensive than existence: some non-existents, specifically possible non-existents, are nevertheless ‘established’. Negation would then be narrower than non-existence, applying only to what is impossible.

Others propose a middle condition between existence and non-existence called a *state* (*ḥāl*). The examples are being learned, being powerful, and being a parent—intellectually abstracted qualifications that have no separate existence of their own. According to this view, they cannot be called existing things because they possess no distinct existence, yet cannot simply be called non-existent because existing subjects are qualified by them. Establishment and its negation are nevertheless treated as contradictories without a middle.

The author rejects these views, appealing to the judgment that non-being as such is sheer nullity and has no thingness. One must not turn the absence of an independently existing accident into a third ontological status between existence and non-existence.

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1. **editorial synthesis of lecture notes:** The notes introduce the Muʿtazilī discussions of thingness, nonexistents, and aḥwāl. Their polemical simplification should not be substituted for a historically sourced comparison of Muʿtazilī positions. (Krishnan, printed p. 30; attribution to the lecturer as mediated by the note-taker.)
2. **Historical note:** This is Tabāṭabāʾī's compressed account of certain Muʿtazilī doctrines of non-existents and aḥwāl. It should not be generalised to every Muʿtazilī thinker or taken to mean that aḥwāl were necessarily posited as independently subsisting entities.
3. **Terminology:** Wujūd, thubūt, shayʾiyya, and ḥāl mean existence, establishment, thingness, and state respectively. The controversy turns precisely on whether they are coextensive.
4. **Source:** Bidayat al-Hikma, supplied bilingual PDF (Arabic original) · p. 36 https://lib.rafed.net/m/?b_id=1571&type=c_fbook

CHAPTER 10

No distinction or causality in non-existence

الفصل العاشر في أنه لا تمايز ولا علية في العدم

Non-existence admits neither distinction nor causal efficacy.

Distinction requires something established or a thing capable of being distinguished, but absolute non-being has neither. One can distinguish an absence of sight from an absence of hearing, or the absence of Zayd from that of ʿAmr, only by mentally referring those absences to their respective positive objects or capacities. Absolute non-existence, considered without reference to what it negates, has no distinctions within it.

Nor can non-being properly act as a cause, since it has no reality or thingness. The familiar expression ‘the absence of a cause causes the absence of its effect’ is therefore approximate or figurative. Saying ‘there were no clouds, so there was no rain’ really means that the causal relation between the existence of clouds and the occurrence of rain was not realised.

This resembles our use of expressions such as ‘negative categorical proposition’ or ‘negative conditional proposition’. Strictly speaking, the negation is of predication or of the conditional connection, rather than a positive entity called a ‘negative relation’.

1. **Translator's note:** Causal absence is not itself an efficient agent in the author's argument. The example depends on an underlying positive causal relation that does not obtain.
2. **Source:** Bidayat al-Hikma, supplied bilingual PDF (Arabic original) · p. 38 https://lib.rafed.net/m/?b_id=1571&type=c_fbook

CHAPTER 11

Absolute non-existence admits no predication

الفصل الحادي عشر في أن المعدوم المطلق لا خبر عنه

Absolute non-existence does not admit predication: it is sheer nullity and has no thingness whatsoever, whereas predication affirms something of something.

An objection says that the proposition ‘Absolute non-existence cannot be spoken of’ contradicts itself: the statement appears to speak *about* the very thing declared unspeakable. The answer requires the distinction between two modes of predication, taken up later under unity and multiplicity.

In *primary essential predication* (*al-ḥaml al-awwalī al-dhātī*), subject and predicate are one in meaning and differ only in consideration, as in ‘Human is human’. In *common predication* (*al-ḥaml al-shāʾiʿ al-ṣināʿī*), subject and predicate differ conceptually but coincide in an instance, as in ‘A human is capable of laughter’.

Absolute non-existence is absolute non-existence by primary predication. Yet the concept *absolute non-existence*, insofar as it is present to the intellect, is itself a mental existent under common predication. It is this mentally existing notion about which we can assert the impossibility of predicating attributes of absolute non-being. No contradiction follows.

The same distinction dissolves other apparent paradoxes. ‘A particular is particular’ is true by primary predication, whereas the concept ‘particular’ is a universal predicable of many cases by common predication. A supposed partner of the Creator is impossible as a referent, yet the concept of such a partner, as a mental occurrence, is a possible, created mental existent. Similarly, what is conceived as ‘not established in the mind’ is, as an entertained notion, established in the mind. These truths hold under differing modes of predication.

The point is not that the impossible object becomes possible, but that its intelligible description has a kind of mental existence different from what it signifies.

1. **Logical note:** The distinction between primary and common predication is indispensable. A contradiction arises only if the predicates are affirmed and denied in the same respect; mental existence of a concept is not the external existence of its impossible referent.
2. **Source:** Bidayat al-Hikma, supplied bilingual PDF (Arabic original) · p. 40 https://lib.rafed.net/m/?b_id=1571&type=c_fbook

CHAPTER 12

The impossibility of restoring the very same non-existent

الفصل الثاني عشر في امتناع إعادة المعدوم بعينه

The philosophers maintain that the numerical restoration of the very same thing after its complete annihilation is impossible. Some theologians agree; most theologians, as reported here, consider it possible. Avicenna regarded its impossibility as evident: since the non-existent has no thingness, there is no subject of restoration while it is non-existent.

Those who argue the matter discursively offer several demonstrations. First, if a thing that disappeared at one time could be restored as numerically identical at another, non-being would intervene between a thing and itself. The supposedly identical individual would occupy separated temporal positions with absolute non-existence between them.

Second, if such a restoration were possible, it would also be possible to originate anew something indistinguishable from the original in *every* respect. But two alleged individuals without any possible ground of distinction would be a plurality identical as a plurality, which is impossible. The purported restored thing would be no more identifiable as that original than the wholly indistinguishable new production.

Third, complete numerical restoration would require the restored individual to reproduce every individuating characteristic of the first, including its temporal designation. It would therefore have to be the original occurrence even in its time, collapsing the alleged distinction between the original and the return.

Fourth, there would be no determinate number of permissible returns. If one return is possible in precisely the same circumstances, so would a second and further returns without limit. Yet, the argument says, determinate number is a concomitant of the existence of an individuated thing.

Defenders of the possibility reply that an impossibility of restoration must follow either from the thing's quiddity, an inseparable concomitant, or a separable accident. It cannot follow from the first two, since that same quiddity was initially capable of existing; and a separable impediment could be removed.

The author replies that the impossibility pertains to the original thing's *individual existence and identity*, not to its abstract quiddity. Its quiddity's possibility at the outset is therefore irrelevant to the question.

He finally considers a theological motivation: the belief that bodily resurrection requires bringing back precisely the same thing from sheer annihilation. He rejects that equation, arguing that death is a form of further perfection or transformation, not absolute annihilation. Resurrection therefore

does not, merely as such, establish the possibility of restoring an absolutely non-existent individual as numerically the very same.

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1. **Translator's note:** Iʿādat al-maʿdūm means numerical re-creation after complete non-existence, not ordinary persistence through change or resurrection understood as transformation. The philosophical demonstrations reported here remain open to independent critical assessment.
2. **Historical note:** The theological positions are summarized from the author's perspective. Different kalām schools distinguish the persistence of the soul, bodily reconstruction, and the problem of numerical identity in different ways.
3. **Source:** Bidayat al-Hikma, supplied bilingual PDF (Arabic original) · p. 42 https://lib.rafed.net/m/?b_id=1571&type=c_fbook

STAGE II

Mental and External Existence

الوجود الخارجي والذهني

CHAPTER 1

External and mental existence

الفصل الأول في الوجود الخارجي والوجود الذهني

The prevailing position among philosophers is that quiddities have, in addition to their external existence—where their characteristic effects follow from them—another mode of existence in which those effects do not follow. This is called *mental existence* (al-wujūd al-dhihnī). A human being existing outside the mind is a substance, existing not in a subject; insofar as the human is a body, three dimensions can be supposed in it; and insofar as it is a living and rational being, it possesses vegetative, animal, and rational faculties. The effects associated with these genera, differentiae, and properties are manifest externally. The human being as known in the mind, however, is human in its essential character and possesses the same definition, but none of those external effects follow from it.

Some have argued that what is known, the so-called mentally existent, is only a *likeness* or image (shabah) of the quiddity, not that quiddity itself: an accidental psychic quality that differs in its essence from the external thing and merely resembles or represents it in certain respects. An image of a horse painted on a wall might depict a horse without being a horse. But this position, the author argues, leads in effect to sophistry, for it would close off the possibility of knowledge of external things as they are. Others altogether deny mental existence and say that knowledge consists solely in a special relation of the soul to its object. Knowledge of what does not exist refutes this explanation: there is no intelligible relation to a non-existent object understood as possessing no reality at all.

The philosophers offer several arguments for mental existence. **First**, we make affirmative judgments about non-existents—for example, attributing some character to a sea of mercury, or distinguishing the conjunction of contradictories from the conjunction of contraries. Affirmative predication establishes something of something, and such establishment presupposes the establishment of the subject. If the subjects of these judgments do not exist outside the mind, they must have another locus of existence, which we call the mind.

Second, we conceive universals, such as universal humanity and universal animality. Conceiving something is an intellectual indication of an object, and an indication requires something indicated. Since a universal *as universal* is not found externally, it must have existence in another domain—the mind.

Third, we conceive the pure reality of a thing stripped of what would multiply it through admixture or addition. Consider whiteness with every alien admixture removed. A pure reality, just insofar as it is pure, is not repeated or divided into a plurality; it has a unity embracing everything of its kind. This pure reality under that description does not occur externally as such, so it must obtain in the mind.

A number of objections have been raised against the thesis that the very quiddities of things occur mentally. **The first objection** is that the same thing would have to be both substance and accident. A mentally conceived substance remains a substance, it is argued, because its essential characteristics are preserved. Yet because it inheres in the soul as a quality in a subject, it is also an accident. It would thus both exist and not exist in a subject, which is impossible.

The second objection is more difficult. Learned forms are commonly regarded as psychical qualities and therefore belong to the category of *quality*. But a mentally conceived substance retains its essential definition and consequently seems to belong at once to *substance* and to *quality*. Likewise, a conceived quantity would belong to both quantity and quality; even a conceived sensible quality would fall under two distinct species of quality. Since the highest categories differ in their essential characters, a single thing cannot belong essentially to two mutually exclusive categories.

The second objection is more difficult than the first because being an ‘accident’ in the broad sense of what subsists in a subject can be treated as a common predicate rather than the distinguishing essence of one of the nine accidental categories. The definition of substance, indeed, is a quiddity which, *if it exists externally*, exists not in a subject. One might therefore allow a substance conceived mentally to subsist in a subject without forfeiting its definition. But belonging essentially and simultaneously to two disparate highest genera—substance and quality, or quantity and quality—cannot be conceded so readily.

These difficulties have led some philosophers back to the view that knowledge is only a relation to the external object, or to the theory that the soul possesses images *other than* the quiddities themselves. But the former cannot explain knowledge of non-existents, and the latter again raises the difficulty of how a mere likeness gives access to what the external thing is.

Several answers have been proposed. **One answer** distinguishes knowledge from what is known. On this view, when an external quiddity is present to the mind, there are two things: the quiddity itself, which remains as it is externally and constitutes the object known; and a state or quality belonging to the soul which dispels ignorance and constitutes knowledge. The object would then fall under its own category, while knowledge would belong to psychical quality. No one thing would fall under both. But this conflicts with our experience of knowing: the form present to the soul when we know something is precisely that by which ignorance is dispelled and through which we are qualified as knowing.

A second answer, associated here with some proponents of the primacy of quiddity, asserts that a quiddity can change its category when it moves from external to mental existence. Since its being existent precedes its quiddity in the order of consideration, and mental and external existences are taken to differ in their very realities, a substance or quantity can become a psychical quality upon entering the mind. Conversely, such a mental quality would be a substance or quantity if it existed externally. The alleged continuity between mental and external quiddity would be supplied only by an indeterminate common account, analogous to common matter in material generation and corruption.

This reply fails for two reasons. First, the proposed transformation of quiddity is unintelligible on the very principles of the primacy of quiddity and the merely considered character of existence adopted by its proponent. Second, by making the mental form essentially other than the external object, the position becomes equivalent to the likeness theory and inherits its sceptical consequence.

A third answer says that because knowledge is identical in its essence with the immediately known object, it belongs to whatever category that object belongs to: substance if the object is substance, quantity if it is quantity, and so on. Calling every such cognition a ‘quality’ would merely be a loose convention, as ordinary language calls anything characterising a subject a ‘quality’. The difficulty of being both substance and accident would then be resolved by treating ‘accident’ as a broad common predicate.

This answer also fails. The applicability of a category's *concept* to something does not in itself establish that the thing actually belongs to that category. Moreover, the philosophical assertion that acquired knowledge is a psychical quality within the category of quality is made literally, not as a loose expression.

The sound answer, adopted by Ṣadr al-Mutaʾallihīn in his writings, is to distinguish *primary essential predication* from *common predication*. Only the latter entails actual inclusion in a category. A generic or specific concept may be included in the definition of something and

predicated of it without the thing thereby belonging to that genus or species *as an actual instance*. Thus saying ‘the human is a substance, body, growing, sentient, voluntarily moving, and rational’ does not make a merely conceived human an externally existing substance or body with the corresponding effects. Similarly, that the definition of a surface includes quantity, continuity, and two-dimensional divisibility does not make the mental conception of surface an extended or divisible physical thing.

If the mere truth of primary predication established categorial membership, every universal concept would be an individual instance of itself merely because that concept is predicated of itself. Actual membership must be judged by the appropriate effects. Those effects follow upon external existence, not upon existence as mentally related to an external object.

The mental form does not, therefore, fall under the external category signified by its definition, because it does not exhibit that category's characteristic external effects. Yet the very same form can be considered in another respect: as a state or acquired disposition present in the soul, removing ignorance. In this respect it has an external existence *for the soul*, qualifies the soul, and meets the definition of psychical quality—an accident which in itself admits neither division nor relation. It thus genuinely falls under quality by common predication. When considered simply as a mental existent corresponding to something beyond the mind, it is not essentially included in the external category it signifies; if termed a quality in that respect, it is so only derivatively or accidentally. The contradiction disappears because the two predications differ in respect.

Some investigators object that the existence of the cognitive form in itself and its existence for the soul are one and the same. Its appearing to the soul adds no distinct thing to it; and if the appearance were a categorial relation, knowledge would be relation rather than quality, whereas if it were an illuminating relation it would be existence, not a quiddity at all.

The answer is that the form is indeed the form present to the soul, but we must distinguish it *as mental representation of an external thing* from it *as a condition or disposition perfecting the soul and removing a privation*. As such a perfection it is not merely the externally signified quiddity; it qualifies the soul and produces a real effect there. Since the soul is a subject that is able to exist without this particular acquired disposition, the disposition is an accident of the soul and falls under quality. The assertion that nothing distinct from the soul is present to qualify it is not conceded. Knowledge, therefore, is truly and primarily a psychical quality in the latter respect and is called a quality only derivatively in the former respect.

The third objection argues that mental existence would make the soul hot and cold, wide and long, extended, moving, triangular, square, faithful, unbelieving, and so forth whenever it conceives such things. For what else does it mean to be hot or cold than to possess heat or cold?

The response is that these external meanings occur in the mind *as quiddities*, not with the external existences in virtue of which their effects obtain. Primary predication makes the mental content what it is in meaning; it does not make the soul an instance of the external attribute under common predication. A subject is actually qualified by heat or cold when the corresponding form exists externally in the subject, not merely when the subject mentally possesses a conception of heat or cold.

The fourth objection notes that we conceive things impossible in themselves, such as a partner of the Creator, the conjunction or joint negation of contradictories, or the denial of a thing's identity with itself. If things themselves were present in the mind, intrinsic impossibilities would thereby be established. The answer is again to distinguish modes of predication. The supposed partner of the Creator is such a partner by primary predication, considered as a concept; as a mental existent by common predication it is only a possible psychical quality created by the Creator. The same distinction applies to the other impossibilities.

The fifth objection concerns size. We can mentally grasp the earth with all its mountains, plains, deserts, and seas, the sky and its distant reaches, and the great distances between celestial bodies. If this means imprinting such enormous dimensions upon a finite neural organ or cerebral faculty, the greater would be contained in the smaller—an impossibility. Invoking the infinite divisibility of the receiving organ does not help: a hand cannot contain a mountain merely because it can be divided without limit.

The answer is that particular cognitive forms are, as will be established later, not material in their existence. They are immaterial in the *imaginal* mode: they possess characteristics associated with matter, such as figure and magnitude, without themselves being material things. They are present to the soul at the level of its imaginal immateriality, not physically impressed in some neural component. The bodily changes accompanying sensation and imagination are preparatory conditions for the soul's apprehension of such forms.

The sixth objection appeals to the accounts given by investigators of nature. They explain sensation and imagination through physical alterations in the sense organs, the transmission of images or signals to the brain, and comparative processing by which we discriminate sizes, proportions, and shapes. This appears to exclude the presence of the external quiddities themselves in our minds.

The author accepts the physical changes just described insofar as they occur. But their products cannot be the *immediately known objects* in the full sense, since physical sensory impressions differ from the extramental things. They prepare the soul for the presence of the objects' quiddities in a non-material imaginal mode. Otherwise, he maintains, knowledge would collapse into mere

awareness of different images, with no secured access to the nature of the external thing. He therefore regards the admitted difference between a physiological representation and the thing represented as a further reason for positing non-material cognition of the quiddity itself.

The seventh objection is that the same mental entity would be both universal and particular. The intelligible quiddity of human being can be predicated of many people, so it is universal. Yet as a state present in the soul of this particular knower, it is individuated by that soul and differs from the mental occurrence of the same quiddity in another person. The answer is that these are different considerations: as mentally representing the external nature it is universal and applicable to many instances; as an individual psychical quality of this knower, considered without such reference to the external, it is particular.

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1. **editorial synthesis of lecture notes:** The long discussion of mental existence examines the objection that a known substance would have to be an accident in the soul. The Sadrāian response distinguishes primary predication from common predication; the example of a conceived apple is useful but not itself the proof.
2. **Translator's note:** The distinction of primary predication (al-ḥaml al-awwalī) and common predication (al-ḥaml al-shāʾiʿ) explains why the mental concept of a substance does not act as an external substance, even though it is genuinely a psychical quality of the knower.
3. **Terminological note:** The Arabic separates the maʿlūm bi-l-dhāt (immediately known) from matter-bound physiological representations. This is the author's philosophical conclusion; the website does not present it as an experimentally established claim about the brain.
4. **Editorial note:** The objections are preserved in their order and answered within the chapter. The English retains the distinction between the imagined form's ‘effects of matter’ (shape and magnitude) and its not itself being material.
5. **Source:** Bidayat al-Hikma, supplied bilingual PDF (Arabic original) · p. 46 https://lib.rafed.net/m/?b_id=1571&type=c_fbook

STAGE III

Existence in Itself and in Another

الوجود في نفسه وفي غيره

CHAPTER 1

Existence-in-itself and existence-in-another

الفصل الأول الوجود في نفسه والوجود في غيره

Some instances of existence are *in another*, while others are not. Consider true propositions such as “The human is capable of laughter.” Beyond the subject and predicate there is something by which they are connected. It is absent if the subject is considered alone, the predicate alone, or either one with something other than its actual counterpart. The connection therefore has a kind of being. But its being cannot be a third independent entity placed between subject and predicate. If it were, two further relations would be needed to connect it to its original terms. Three would become five, five would become nine, and the regress would continue without limit.

The being of the connection is constituted in its terms. It is neither extraneous nor independent of them in any respect, and has no self-contained conceptual signification. We call it *linking existence* (al-wujūd al-rābiṭ). By contrast, the being of subject and predicate admits an independently meaningful concept; this is *predicative existence* (al-wujūd al-maḥmūlī), or independent existence. Existence is thus divided into independent and linking modes.

Three consequences follow. First, linking existence has no quiddity: a quiddity is what answers “What is it?”, and its intelligibility requires an independently predicable account, which linking existence lacks.

Second, the realisation of linking existence between two terms entails some unity between them, since the link is one and is not a separate thing standing outside them.

Third, a linking existence obtains in what corresponds to a *composite existential proposition*, which affirms something of something. It does not obtain in the corresponding reality of a *simple existential proposition*, which asserts merely that the subject is. A thing need not be linked to itself by a distinct connective in order to exist.

1. **Translator's note:** Wujūd rābiṭ (linking existence) is distinguished from wujūd maḥmūlī (predicative existence). This is not an argument that a copula is a third independent constituent in addition to subject and predicate.

2. **Source:** Bidayat al-Hikma, supplied bilingual PDF (Arabic original) · p. 63 https://lib.rafed.net/m/?b_id=1571&type=c_fbook

CHAPTER 2

Relational and independent existence

الفصل الثاني كيفية اختلاف الرابط والمستقل

The philosophers have disagreed about whether linking and independent existence differ in their very species. According to one view, linking existence has an essentially dependent signification and cannot be conceived independently. Directing attention to it cannot turn what signified in the manner of a particle into something self-signifying like a noun.

The author takes the opposite view. As will be shown in the stage on cause and effect, the existences of effects are linking existences in relation to their causes. But effects include substances and accidents, and these possess predicative existences whose concepts are independently meaningful. The very same existent is therefore linking in relation to its cause and independently predicable when considered in itself. Its mode of consideration differs according to the relation in which it is taken.

Thus conceptual independence or dependence follows the existence from which the concept is abstracted. Considered apart from this, the concept on its own remains indeterminate.

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1. **editorial synthesis of lecture notes:** A caused existence may be considered independently as an intelligible existent but is dependent qua effect. This should not be conflated with the ten-category relation (iḍāfa). (Krishnan, printed p. 51; attribution to the lecturer as mediated by the note-taker.)
2. **Translator's note:** The contrast is between an existence considered in itself and the same effect considered in dependence on its cause; it is not the distinction between substance and accident.
3. **Source:** Bidayat al-Hikma, supplied bilingual PDF (Arabic original) · p. 65 https://lib.rafed.net/m/?b_id=1571&type=c_fbook

CHAPTER 3

Existence-for-another and existence-for-itself

الفصل الثالث من الوجود في نفسه ما هو لغيره ومنه ما هو لنفسه

For the existence of something to be *for another* means that the very existence which removes non-being from its own quiddity also removes a certain absence from another subject. That absence cannot be the non-being of the second subject's entire essence, for then one and the same existence would have two quiddities and the one would be many. Instead, it removes an additional privation somehow accompanying the second subject.

For example, knowledge actualises its own quiddity as a quality and, by that very existence, removes ignorance from the soul in which it occurs. Power similarly actualises its own quiddity while removing incapacity from the subject that possesses it.

Accidents show that this kind of existence is real: each actualises itself and also removes some privation from its subject. Specific substantial forms have an analogous mode of presence to matter: they perfect their matter and remove a substantial deficiency. This is what is meant by existence being *for another* and *qualifying* (nāʿit).

Its opposite is an existence which removes non-being from itself alone. Complete substantial kinds such as a human being or a horse possess *existence for itself* (al-wujūd li-nafsihi).

Existence for itself is sometimes further divided into existence *through itself* and *through another*. That distinction concerns causality and dependence, and will be considered later under cause and effect.

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1. **Terminological note:** Wujūd li-ghayrihi means existence as a perfection *for another*, while wujūd bi-ghayrihi means existence *through another* as cause. The distinctions are not interchangeable.
2. **Source:** Bidayat al-Hikma, supplied bilingual PDF (Arabic original) · p. 67 https://lib.rafed.net/m/?b_id=1571&type=c_fbook

STAGE IV

Necessity, Possibility, and Impossibility

المواد الثلاث

CHAPTER 1

Definition and exhaustiveness of the three modalities

الفصل الأول في تعريف المواد الثلاث وانحصارها فيها

Whenever a concept is considered in relation to existence, one of three alternatives must hold. Existence is necessary for it, and it is therefore *necessary*; or existence is impossible for it, and it is *impossible*; or neither its existence nor its non-existence is necessary, and it is *possible* or *contingent*.

In other words, either existence is necessary, non-existence is necessary, or neither alternative is necessary. That existence and non-existence could both be necessary is ruled out by the slightest reflection.

These three modalities are evident in their meanings. They are among the most general concepts, and no concept fails to fall under one of them. Attempts to define them strictly are therefore circular. One may explain the necessary as that whose supposed non-existence entails impossibility, the impossible as that which must not exist or is neither possible nor necessary, and the possible as that whose existence and non-existence are not impossible. Such descriptions elucidate the meanings; they do not define them by something more fundamental.

1. **Terminology:** The Arabic al-mawādd al-thalāth denotes the three modal determinations (necessity, impossibility, and possibility), not the material constituents of a physical thing.
2. **Source:** Bidayat al-Hikma, supplied bilingual PDF (Arabic original) · p. 70 https://lib.rafed.net/m/?b_id=1571&type=c_fbook

CHAPTER 2

Modalities in themselves, through another, and relative to another

الفصل الثاني انقسام كل من المواد إلى ما بالذات وما بالغير وما بالقياس

Each of the three modalities is further distinguished as intrinsic, through another, or relative to another—except that *possibility through another* is not admitted. Intrinsic modality belongs to a thing from the very supposition of what it is, apart from anything else. Modality through another

depends upon something different from the thing, while modality relative to another appears when the thing is compared with that other.

Necessity in itself is exemplified by the Necessary Existent, exalted is He: His very reality suffices for the necessity of His existence without need of anything besides Himself. **Necessity through another** belongs to an existing contingent thing whose existence is necessitated by its cause. **Necessity relative to another** is found in correlatives: the existence of something above entails something below, so that what is below is necessary relative to what is above, beyond its necessity through its cause.

Impossibility in itself belongs to intrinsic impossibilities, such as a partner of the Creator and the conjunction of contradictories. **Impossibility through another** is illustrated by an effect's existence when its complete cause is absent, or its non-existence when its complete cause is present. **Impossibility relative to another** occurs when one of two correlatives is posited as existent while the other is posited as non-existent.

Possibility in itself belongs to contingent quiddities, which of themselves require neither existence nor absence. **Possibility relative to another** is illustrated by the supposition of two beings necessary in themselves, neither of which is cause or effect of the other, nor both effects of a third cause. On this hypothesis the existence of one would neither entail nor exclude the other's existence. This is an illustration of modal relation within a supposition, not the author's assertion that there actually are two Necessary Existents.

Possibility through another is impossible. A supposed thing rendered possible by another must already be, in its own nature, necessary, impossible, or possible; the modal division is exhaustive. If it is intrinsically necessary or impossible, converting it into possible would overturn that intrinsic modality, a contradiction. If it is intrinsically possible, attributing its possibility to another is redundant. Thus no new form of possibility is introduced by another.

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1. **Translator's note:** Modal necessity and impossibility ‘relative to another’ are distinguished from being caused ‘through another’. The hypothetical two necessary beings illustrate the logical classification, not a second divine existence.
2. **Source:** Bidayat al-Hikma, supplied bilingual PDF (Arabic original) · p. 72 https://lib.rafed.net/m/?b_id=1571&type=c_fbook

CHAPTER 3

The Necessary Existent: its quiddity is its existence

الفصل الثالث واجب الوجود ماهيته إنيته

In the Necessary Existent, quiddity is identical with existence. This means that He has no quiddity or essence over and above His particular existence.

If He had an essence distinct from His existence, existence would be additional to that essence and predicated of it as something beyond what it is. Whatever is thus additional requires a cause, so His existence would be caused.

The cause would have to be either the essence itself or another. If it were the essence itself, the essence would have to precede the existence it caused, for a cause is prior to its effect in the order of being. Either it precedes by that very existence, in which case the existence precedes itself—impossible—or by another existence, whereupon the same question recurs without end. If something other than the essence were the cause, the Necessary Existent would be an effect of another, contrary to intrinsic necessity.

Necessity in itself is therefore a description abstracted from the very reality of the Necessary Existent. It reveals His existence to be pure, at the utmost intensity, without any privative aspect. If it contained a privation, the opposed existential perfection would be absent from it, so the essence would be limited by that absence. Such a restricted reality could not be the absolutely necessary, pure existence possessing every perfection.

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1. **Terminological note:** The phrase ‘His quiddity is His existence’ is explained by the author as denying a quiddity *over and above* the actuality of the Necessary Existent. It is not a claim that the Necessary is one ordinary species whose definition happens to include existence.
2. **Source:** Bidayat al-Hikma, supplied bilingual PDF (Arabic original) · p. 74 https://lib.rafed.net/m/?b_id=1571&type=c_fbook

CHAPTER 4

The Necessary Existent is necessary in every respect

الفصل الرابع واجب الوجود بالذات واجب الوجود من جميع الجهات

The Necessary Existent is necessary in every respect. Suppose there were a perfection which could belong to Him in the broad sense of possibility but did not belong to Him necessarily. He would then have an aspect of possibility in relation to that perfection, lacking it in His own reality and standing equally open to its possession or absence.

That would make His essence restricted by a privation. The previous chapter showed this to be impossible for pure necessary existence. Therefore the Necessary Existent contains no unrealised capacity awaiting further actualisation, and cannot be deficient in any existential perfection.

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1. **Translator's note:** ‘Necessary in every respect’ excludes an unactualised possible perfection in the Necessary Existent; it does not mean that predicates are applied without regard to their proper meanings or qualifications.
2. **Source:** Bidayat al-Hikma, supplied bilingual PDF (Arabic original) · p. 76 https://lib.rafed.net/m/?b_id=1571&type=c_fbook

CHAPTER 5

A thing exists only once its existence is necessary

الفصل الخامس في أن الشيء ما لم يجب لم يوجد وبطلان القول بالأولوية

A contingent thing, considered in itself, is equally related to existence and non-existence. Its existence therefore depends on something called a cause, and its non-existence upon the absence of the cause. Must the cause make the effect's existence *necessary*—the necessity which comes through another—or is it sufficient that one alternative merely acquire a greater preponderance even without attaining necessity? The same question can be asked of non-existence.

This rival doctrine is called *preponderance* (awlawiyya). Its advocates distinguish preponderance arising intrinsically from the quiddity from preponderance coming through another, and divide each into what suffices and what does not suffice to bring about the contingent thing.

All of these forms are invalid. **Intrinsic preponderance** fails because a quiddity considered prior to existence has no actuality or thingness by which it could itself confer a priority upon existence. Quiddity as such is simply itself, neither existent nor non-existent in its definition.

Preponderance through another fails insofar as it does not reach necessity. If the cause merely inclines the outcome without determining it, the contingent thing has not departed definitively from its equality between existence and non-existence. The question ‘Why did this occur rather than that?’ still remains, showing that the alleged cause is not yet complete.

The effect is therefore determined only when the complete cause necessitates its existence and excludes its non-existence, or vice versa. The thing—meaning the contingent thing—does not exist until its existence has been rendered necessary.

This is the necessity received from the cause. A second necessity follows once existence or non-existence has actually been assumed as a predicate: *necessity on condition of the predicate* (al-ḍarūra bi-sharṭ al-maḥmūl). A contingent existent is thus surrounded by a prior necessity in the explanatory order, arising from its complete causal determination, and a subsequent conditioned necessity, according to which what is posited as existent must, in that very respect, exist.

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1. **Translator's note:** The maxim ‘a thing does not exist until it is necessary’ is about the effect's causal determination (wujūb bi-l-ghayr), not about contingency turning into intrinsic necessity (wujūb bi-l-dhāt).
2. **Source:** Bidayat al-Hikma, supplied bilingual PDF (Arabic original) · p. 78 https://lib.rafed.net/m/?b_id=1571&type=c_fbook

CHAPTER 6

The different senses of possibility

الفصل السادس في معاني الإمكان

The possibility under discussion here is the absence of necessity on both sides, existence and non-existence, for a quiddity considered simply in itself. This is called *special possibility* (al-imkān al-khāṣṣ).

The term “possibility” is also used more generally to exclude necessity on the *opposite* side, whether the side affirmed is necessary or not. Thus one says “This is possible” to mean “This is not impossible.” This is broader than special possibility and is called *general possibility* (al-imkān al-ʿāmm), as in ordinary speech.

It is sometimes used more narrowly to exclude necessity intrinsic to the subject, necessity arising from an added qualification, and necessity arising from a particular time. Saying “A human may be a writer” means that humanity by itself does not necessitate writing and that neither a special qualification nor a specified time has been added to necessitate it. This is *more special possibility* (al-imkān al-akhaṣṣ). It belongs to an intellectual consideration of the predicate in relation to the subject, and is compatible with the existence of an external cause rendering the occurrence necessary in actuality.

Another usage negates those three kinds of necessity *and* necessity subject to the predicate. Saying “Zayd may be writing tomorrow” is possible in this sense because the future event has not yet been actualised for us in the present perspective; the conditioned necessity that would follow its occurrence is not yet affirmed. This is *future possibility* (al-imkān al-istiqbālī). The author remarks that such a judgment rests upon conjecture or failure to attend to the fact that, through complete determining causes, every future event is either necessary or impossible in the causal order.

Two further senses must be distinguished. *Possibility of occurrence* (al-imkān al-wuqūʿī) means that supposing something to happen entails no impossibility, intrinsic or through another. This negates impossibility on the side affirmed, whereas general possibility negates necessity on its opposing side.

Dispositional possibility (al-imkān al-istiʿdādī) is the same actuality as preparedness (*istiʿdād*) but differs in the relation under which it is considered. A thing's preparedness for becoming something else is related both to the subject prepared and to the actuality for which it is prepared. In relation to the subject we say, for example, “The embryo has a disposition to become human.” In relation to the end we say, “Human actuality is possible in the embryo.”

Dispositional possibility differs from intrinsic possibility in four important respects. First, intrinsic possibility is an analytic intellectual consideration accompanying quiddity as such, whereas dispositional possibility is a real feature of an existent material subject. The one concerns human quiddity considered by itself; the other concerns the embryo in the process of human generation.

Second, dispositional possibility admits greater and lesser degrees: the preparedness for human actuality is greater at some later developmental stage than at an earlier stage. Intrinsic possibility admits no intensity or weakness.

Third, dispositional possibility ceases when the actuality for which the subject was prepared occurs. Intrinsic possibility is an inseparable concomitant of quiddity wherever the quiddity is considered.

Fourth, dispositional possibility relates to a determinate actuality for which matter is prepared, whereas intrinsic possibility by itself determines neither existence nor non-existence. Finally, dispositional possibility pertains to material subjects, while possibility of occurrence has a wider range.

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1. **editorial synthesis of lecture notes:** Check the lecture’s distinction between imkān ʿāmm and imkān khāṣṣ. The Necessary Existent can be called ‘possible’ in the broad sense of ‘not impossible’, but is not contingent (imkān khāṣṣ) in itself; one sentence in the notes appears to reverse these. (Krishnan, printed p. 60; attribution to the lecturer as mediated by the note-taker.)
2. **Terminological note:** The several logical senses of imkān should not be collapsed into one English ‘possibility’. Especially, intrinsic contingency of quiddity and a real material disposition belong to different ontological orders.
3. **Translator's note:** The treatment of future possibility reflects the author's assumption of complete causal determination; it does not by itself deny the ordinary usefulness of epistemic statements about uncertainty concerning future events.
4. **Source:** Bidayat al-Hikma, supplied bilingual PDF (Arabic original) · p. 80 https://lib.rafed.net/m/?b_id=1571&type=c_fbook

CHAPTER 7

Possibility as an intellectual consideration inseparable from quiddity

الفصل السابع في أن الإمكان اعتبار عقلي وأنه لازم للماهية

Intrinsic possibility is an *intellectual consideration* because it belongs to a quiddity considered by the intellect apart from its existence and non-existence. The quiddity, taken in precisely that abstract fashion, is itself an object of intellectual consideration; what belongs to it under that consideration is likewise intellectually considered.

This does not contradict the fact that in the real order the quiddity is either existent or absent. Under those respective conditions it is accompanied by the necessity of existing if it exists, or of not existing if it does not exist, and by the corresponding impossibility of the contrary under the very same condition.

Intrinsic possibility is also inseparable from quiddity. If we conceive the quiddity as it is, without importing anything else, we find in it neither a necessity to exist nor a necessity not to exist. Possibility is nothing other than the negation of these two intrinsic necessities. The quiddity is consequently possible in itself.

Although the underlying analysis consists in the two negations, the intellect can instead attend to their consequence: the equality of the quiddity's relation to existence and non-existence. In this manner possibility takes on an affirmative conceptual expression, even though its basic content is the exclusion of the two necessities.

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1. **Philosophical note:** The author distinguishes an abstract modal description of a quiddity from the actual existential condition of the individual. The ‘affirmative’ sense of equal relation is formed through conceptual consideration, not through a newly posited external entity.
2. **Source:** Bidayat al-Hikma, supplied bilingual PDF (Arabic original) · p. 84 https://lib.rafed.net/m/?b_id=1571&type=c_fbook

CHAPTER 8

Why a contingent being requires a cause

الفصل الثامن في حاجة الممكن إلى العلة وما هي علة احتياجه إليها

That a contingent being needs a cause is one of the primary necessities of thought: merely conceiving the subject and predicate suffices for assent. If one understands a contingent quiddity as equally related to existence and non-existence, and recognises that departing from such equality requires something beyond the quiddity to determine one alternative, one assents immediately that it must depend on a cause.

Is the basis of this need contingency (*imkān*) or temporal origination (*ḥudūth*)? The philosophers, followed here by the author, choose contingency.

One argument observes that a quiddity considered as actually existent is necessarily existent under that condition, while one considered as non-existent is necessarily absent. These are the two necessities *on condition of the predicate*. Temporal origination is only the succession of one upon the other—existence following non-existence. But necessity considered in this conditioned way does not explain the need for a cause. It is only by considering a quiddity as intrinsically *possible* that we arrive at its need for a determining cause.

A second argument examines the explanatory order. The effect comes to exist only by the cause's bringing it into existence. That act presupposes its determination as necessary by the complete cause; the cause's determining act presupposes the effect's need for it; and the need presupposes the quiddity's possibility. If the quiddity were necessary or impossible in itself, it would not need another to decide between existence and non-existence.

Suppose the need for a cause also depended upon the thing's temporal origination, its existence after absence. Whether this origination were counted as the cause, a condition, part of a cause, or the absence of origination counted as an impediment, the effect's existence would have to be prior in explanation to the very need upon which that existence depends. This is a circle of explanatory priority. The same difficulty would arise if the effect's necessity or its cause's determining operation were made the prior ground of its need.

Nothing prior to the need for a cause in the appropriate explanatory series remains except the quiddity and its intrinsic possibility. Possibility alone is thus the ground of need.

A defender of temporal origination as that ground objects that the philosophers' position seems to allow an eternally existing contingent thing. If its existence had neither beginning nor end, it would never have to be brought out of non-existence; why would it need a cause?

The answer is that contingency belongs to the thing's very nature and remains present even if its existence is assumed to be unbroken. Its need for a cause would therefore be perpetual. The necessity that follows from the supposition that the thing exists does not remove its intrinsic contingency or its existential dependence.

Moreover, as will be explained in the treatment of cause and effect, an effect's very existence, whether temporally originated or beginningless, is a *linking existence*, intrinsically dependent upon its cause and unable to subsist independently of it. Its causal need is inseparable from what its existence is.

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1. **editorial synthesis of lecture notes:** The notes clarify why contingency, not temporal origination, is taken as the ground of a contingent being’s continuing need for a cause. (Krishnan, printed p. 64; attribution to the lecturer as mediated by the note-taker.)
2. **Translator's note:** The dispute is whether contingency or temporal beginning is the formal ground of dependence, not simply whether the world actually began in time. The author argues that duration does not by itself remove a being's existential dependence.
3. **Source:** Bidayat al-Hikma, supplied bilingual PDF (Arabic original) · p. 86 https://lib.rafed.net/m/?b_id=1571&type=c_fbook

CHAPTER 9

Dependence on the cause in origination and continuation

الفصل التاسع الممكن محتاج إلى علته بقاء كما أنه محتاج إليها حدوثا

A contingent existent requires its cause both in coming into existence and in continuing to exist. The reason for its need is its possibility, an inseparable concomitant of its quiddity; possibility remains with it during its continuance as it did when it first arose. Thus the effect continually receives existence from its cause in both respects.

A second argument is that an effect's existence is *linking existence*, as previously indicated and as the discussion of causality will explain further. Its existence depends upon the cause as part of what it is: it does not subsist independently. Consequently, its need for the cause is the same in origination and continuance.

A popular objection appeals to a builder and a building. The structure seems to require the builder while it is being built but to continue without the builder after completion. The response is that the builder is not the existential cause by which the building continues to have being. The builder's hand-movements are *preparatory causes* through which the parts are brought together. The resulting arrangement causes the building's form, while the hardening or stability of its constituents explains its persistence for an appreciable interval. The example therefore confuses a preparatory cause of arrangement with the ground of an effect's continuing existence.

In conclusion, necessity, possibility, and impossibility are the three modalities of the relations in propositions. Necessity and possibility are existence-related, since the modal propositions bearing them can correspond truly to external things, including their modality. But they do not possess independently separate existences alongside their subjects.

They resemble such philosophical concepts as unity and multiplicity, beginninglessness and origination, potentiality and actuality. Their subjects are genuinely qualified outside the mind, while the notions accrue to those subjects in intellectual consideration. Philosophers call these *secondary intelligibles* (al-maʿqūlāt al-thāniya). A theory that necessity and possibility themselves occupy separate places in external reality is rejected.

Impossibility, unlike these affirmative considerations, is privative or negative.

These conclusions have been expressed while taking quiddities and concepts as the grammatical subjects of judgments. If we turn instead to existence itself, which alone is primary in reality, necessity is existence at its highest intensity, self-subsisting and absolutely independent. Possibility is existence whose very self is dependent upon another and constituted through it, as with the existences of contingent quiddities. Under this ontological consideration, necessity and possibility are descriptions intrinsic to existence, not external additions to their subjects.

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1. **editorial synthesis of lecture notes:** The builder example is helpful if the builder is recognised as a preparatory cause rather than the ultimate existential cause. The effect’s poverty (faqr) is continual dependence, not merely an initial need. (Krishnan, printed p. 66; attribution to the lecturer as mediated by the note-taker.)
2. **Translator's note:** The builder example distinguishes an agent that arranges materials from the existential ground of the continued actuality of the composite. Its role in the argument is causal, not merely temporal.
3. **Terminological note:** The philosophical secondary intelligibles are conceptually abstracted while being grounded in extramental subjects; they are neither mere arbitrary fictions nor independently existing accidental objects.
4. **Source:** Bidayat al-Hikma, supplied bilingual PDF (Arabic original) · p. 90 https://lib.rafed.net/m/?b_id=1571&type=c_fbook

STAGE V

Quiddity and Its Properties

الماهية وأحكامها

CHAPTER 1

Quiddity as such is only itself

الفصل الأول الماهية من حيث هي ليست إلا هي

Quiddity (*māhiyya*) is what is given in answer to “What is it?” A quiddity can be qualified as existent or non-existent, one or many, universal or individual, and by other pairs of opposing attributes. Precisely in what it is, therefore, it includes neither member of these oppositions.

Quiddity as such is nothing but itself: it is neither existent nor non-existent, nor anything else added to its defining account. This is the meaning of the philosophers' statement that contradictories are both excluded from the *rank of quiddity*. They mean that neither opposite is included in what constitutes the quiddity, not that a thing in reality can be without both members of a contradictory pair.

For example, the quiddity of human being is rational animal. In reality a human being must either exist or not exist—the alternatives can neither be combined nor both absent. But neither existence nor non-existence is part of the meaning *rational animal*. Each possesses a meaning different from that quiddity.

The same applies even to the necessary concomitants of quiddity. The meaning of ‘four’ differs from the meaning of evenness, though evenness accompanies four necessarily. Likewise, the meaning of a human quiddity differs from possibility, though possibility is attributed to it.

In short, quiddity is predicated of itself by *primary essential predication*, and under that same mode of predication everything other than its own defining content is excluded from it.

1. **Translator's note:** ‘The two contradictories are removed from the rank of quiddity’ concerns what is included in its essential definition. It does not assert an ontological third state between being and non-being.
2. **Source:** Bidayat al-Hikma, supplied bilingual PDF (Arabic original) · p. 94 https://lib.rafed.net/m/?b_id=1571&type=c_fbook

CHAPTER 2

Ways of considering quiddity

الفصل الثاني في اعتبارات الماهية وما يلحق بها من المسائل

A quiddity can be considered in three ways with respect to what may be added to it. It may be taken *with the condition of something* (bi-sharṭ shayʾ), *with the condition of nothing else* (bi-sharṭ lā), or *without such a condition* (lā bi-sharṭ). These alternatives exhaust the possibilities of consideration.

In the first case the quiddity is taken together with some particular determination. Humanity, considered together with Zayd's individual characteristics, for example, is predicable of that compound as so determined.

In the second case something else is excluded from the consideration. This itself has two senses. One may restrict attention to the quiddity as it is in itself and consider it nothing beyond itself; this is the ‘condition of no addition’ employed in the analysis of quiddity already discussed. Alternatively, one may take the quiddity by itself so that any concept accompanying it is treated as an additional constituent outside its account. If it is conjoined with such a concept, the quiddity then becomes a *part* or material principle of the composite and is not predicated of the whole as the whole.

In the third case no condition is imposed. The quiddity is considered absolutely, while allowing either the presence or the absence of an additional determination.

The first is called *mixed* quiddity (al-māhiyya al-makhlūṭa), the second *abstracted* quiddity (al-māhiyya al-mujarrada), and the third *unconditioned* or *absolute* quiddity (al-māhiyya al-muṭlaqa).

The quiddity divided according to these three considerations is the *natural universal* (al-kullī al-ṭabīʿī). Universality is attributed to it by the mind, allowing it to be applied to many instances. It exists externally insofar as some of its determinate and unconditioned instances exist externally: what is divided is preserved in its divisions and exists through their existence.

However, the natural universal existing in one individual is not numerically the same existent as the natural universal existing in another. If one numerically identical existent were simultaneously present, as such, in all individuals, the numerically one would be numerically many, an impossibility. It would also have mutually opposing determinations simultaneously. Thus the shared nature does not exist as a single numerically identical individual distributed among all its instances.

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1. **editorial synthesis of lecture notes:** The water examples can clarify bi-sharṭ shayʾ, bi-sharṭ lā, and lā bi-sharṭ, but carefully distinguish the dividing notion (lā bi-sharṭ maqsamī) from an individual member (lā bi-sharṭ qismī). (Krishnan, printed p. 71; attribution to the lecturer as mediated by the note-taker.)
2. **Terminology:** The various senses of bi-sharṭ lā, especially the contrast between considering an essence in isolation and treating it as a non-predicable constituent of a composite, must be distinguished.

3. **Translator's note:** The natural universal has extramental existence *in* individuals, but this does not make it one numerically identical entity existing in every individual.
4. **Source:** Bidayat al-Hikma, supplied bilingual PDF (Arabic original) · p. 96 https://lib.rafed.net/m/?b_id=1571&type=c_fbook

CHAPTER 3

Essential and accidental predicates

الفصل الثالث في معنى الذاتي والعرضي

The intelligible meanings included in a quiddity's definition, such that removal of any one would remove that quiddity, are called its *essential constituents* (dhātiyyāt). Predicates outside this defining account are *accidental* (ʿaraḍiyyāt).

Accidental predicates are further distinguished. If abstracting and attributing them requires the addition of an actual determination to the subject, they are *predicates by an added constituent* (maḥmūlāt bi-l-ḍamīma): for example, ‘hot’ is predicated of a body because heat is present in it. Where no such externally added constituent is required, one speaks of a *predicate abstracted externally* (al-khārij al-maḥmūl), as with ‘higher’ and ‘lower’.

An essential constituent can be recognised by certain marks. First, the essential belongs to its subject immediately, without a middle term that makes it belong. Second, it requires no separate cause beyond the cause of the thing whose essential constituent it is: what brings the complete quiddity into actuality thereby brings its essential constituents into actuality. Third, essential constituents are prior to that of which they are constituents.

An objection to the last point notes that the constituents are the whole itself; how can they precede themselves? The reply is that the respects differ. The constituents taken collectively as constituents are prior to the constituents insofar as they are united into a whole. Moreover, each is called a constituent chiefly because it is one component of the *definition*. Apart from such intellectual decomposition, an essential constituent is identical in reality with the complete thing, though conceptually distinguished in the defining account.

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1. **Translator's note:** Dhātī means an essential constituent of the defining account, not merely a predicate that invariably accompanies a subject. The passage later treats the relation between such constituents and the complete individual as a distinction of consideration.
2. **Source:** Bidayat al-Hikma, supplied bilingual PDF (Arabic original) · p. 98 https://lib.rafed.net/m/?b_id=1571&type=c_fbook

CHAPTER 4

Genus, differentia, and species

الفصل الرابع في الجنس والفصل والنوع وبعض ما يلحق بذلك

A complete quiddity which, in virtue of its completeness, has its own proper real effects is called a *species* (nawʿ), as with the human being or the horse.

Some essential meanings occur in several species, while others are particular to one. Animality, for example, is common to humans, horses, and other species. Rationality is specific to human being. The common essential constituent is called *genus* (jins), and the specific determining constituent *differentia* (faṣl). Genus and differentia are divided into proximate and remote, and genera and species can be arranged as highest, intermediate, or lowest. Logic examines these classifications in detail.

Consider the quiddity ‘animal’, understood as a growing, sensing body capable of voluntary motion. We may take animality by itself in such a way that whatever is joined to it is excluded from its own account. It would then be other than the resulting whole, and neither be predicated of the whole nor of the added constituent. Under this consideration it serves as *matter*, a material principle and material cause relative to the composite.

Alternatively, we may consider animality in relation to several species: human being, horse, cow, sheep, and so on. Animality is then an incomplete and indeterminate essence, made into a determinate species only by the addition of the appropriate differentia. Under this consideration it is *genus*, and what completes it is *differentia*.

The same two considerations apply to the specific determining constituent. Taken as a constituent excluded from predication of the whole, it is *form* (ṣūra). Taken as determining and completing the genus into a species, it is *differentia*, and is predicated of the species by primary essential predication.

Several conclusions follow. First, genus is the species considered in its indeterminacy, differentia is the species in its determination, and species is the complete quiddity without isolating either aspect.

Second, genus and differentia are each predicable of the species by primary predication. But genus, relative to differentia considered independently, is a common accidental predicate, while differentia relative to genus is a distinctive property. They do not constitute one another's definitions in the same way they constitute the species.

Third, a single species cannot possess two distinct genera at the same level or two distinct differentiae at the same level, for this would make one complete specific nature into two species.

Fourth, matter and genus are identical in their underlying content but differ in consideration: matter considered without a condition excluding predicability becomes genus, while genus considered as a non-predicable constituent becomes matter. Likewise, form becomes differentia under the former consideration, and differentia becomes form under the latter.

Matter in material substances exists externally, as will be discussed. Accidents, by contrast, are simple externally: the aspect common to them and the aspect by which they differ are not distinct material constituents. The intellect can nevertheless distinguish common and proper aspects in accidents, consider them as genera and differentiae, and then regard those aspects as logically separated ‘matter’ and ‘form’ by the relevant exclusionary consideration.

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1. **Terminology:** The distinction between genus/differentia and matter/form depends here on lā bi-sharṭ versus bi-sharṭ lā as conditions of predicability. The author does not claim that the material principle as material is itself predicated as an essential universal.
2. **Source:** Bidayat al-Hikma, supplied bilingual PDF (Arabic original) · p. 100 https://lib.rafed.net/m/?b_id=1571&type=c_fbook

CHAPTER 5

Properties of the differentia

الفصل الخامس في بعض أحكام الفصل

The differentia is distinguished into a *logical* differentia and an *originating* or *derivative-source* differentia.

The logical differentia is the most distinctive and best-known concomitant belonging to a species. It is placed in definitions in the position of the real differentia because discovering the true constituent which makes a species what it is is often difficult.

Thus ‘rational’ is used as the differentia of the human being and ‘neighing’ as that of a horse. But ‘speech’ in the sense of utterance is a sensible quality, and speech in the sense of apprehending universals is, according to the account at issue, a psychical quality. A quality, however, is an accident, and an accident does not constitute the substantial essence of a thing. The same reasoning applies to neighing.

There may consequently be more than one distinctive concomitant available as a logical differentia: for animality we sometimes employ both sensation and voluntary motion. If these were each the true constitutive differentia of one species, there could not be more than one at the same level, as shown above.

The *originating differentia* is the underlying principle from which the logical differentia follows—the true differentia constituting the species. In the human being this is the possession of a rational soul, and in the horse the possession of a soul of the sort from which neighing follows.

The truth of a species, moreover, is determined by its final differentia. The constitutive differentia makes the species determinate; what was included in its preceding genera and subordinate differentiae indeterminately is included in the final differentia in a determinate way.

Consequently, the specific identity of the species is preserved through its final differentia even if some of its higher generic conditions change. If the form corresponding to the differentia becomes separate from the matter corresponding to its genus, the specific nature continues insofar as that form remains. The author illustrates this with the rational soul's separation from the body.

Finally, differentia does not fall under its own genus in the sense that the genus enters the differentia's definition. Were the genus part of the differentia's essence, the latter would need another differentia to determine it, and so on without end, generating an infinite regress of constitutive differentiae.

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1. **Translator's note:** The logical differentia can be a distinctive proprium used *in place of* the unknown constitutive differentia. Muẓaffar's logic calls attention to precisely this limitation of formal definition.
2. **Interpretive note:** The example of the rational soul's subsistence apart from the body belongs to the author's account of a species' final differentia; it should not silently be assimilated to every Aristotelian or Thomistic account of form and subsistence.
3. **Source:** Bidayat al-Hikma, supplied bilingual PDF (Arabic original) · p. 104 https://lib.rafed.net/m/?b_id=1571&type=c_fbook

CHAPTER 6

Species and its properties

الفصل السادس في النوع وبعض أحكامه

The essential constituents of a specific quiddity have one existence outside the mind, because each is predicated of the species by primary essential predication, while the species itself exists as one actuality. In the mind, however, genus and differentia differ through indeterminacy and determination. Each, when considered independently of the other, is therefore an accidental predicate relative to the other, as explained above.

It follows that a true composite—a material species constituted by matter and form—requires a dependence or need between its constituent principles, allowing them to unite as one reality. Philosophers count this interdependence as evident rather than as something requiring a separate demonstration.

A genuine composite is distinguished from a mere aggregate by its true unity. When two constituents are combined, a third actuality results that differs from either constituent taken alone and has properties not reducible to their individual properties. A mineral substance, for example, has properties other than those of the elements composing it. This contrasts with an army, which is

a plurality of soldiers, or a building, an arrangement of bricks, plaster, and other components. The author therefore favours the thesis that the composition of matter and form is a unity of actualisation, not merely the juxtaposition of two completed things.

Some species have many individual members, as is the case with species that have a relation to matter, such as human beings. Other species, wholly immaterial intellectual substances, have only one individual of their specific nature.

For plurality of individuals cannot be the whole of a species' essence, a part of its essence, or an inseparable concomitant of it. Under any of those alternatives, no single individual would instantiate the species: wherever the species occurred, plurality would be required, whereas plurality presupposes individuals.

Plurality must instead arise from a separable condition whose presence or absence allows individuals of the same specific quiddity to be multiplied. Such receptivity to additional individuating conditions requires matter. Therefore any species with numerous individuals is material; conversely, a species wholly without matter cannot have a plurality of individuals.

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1. **Translator's note:** The contrast between a real composite and an army or a building concerns substantial unity versus aggregation. It is not a denial that aggregates have genuine relations or coordinated activities.
2. **Interpretive note:** The conclusion that an immaterial species admits a single individual follows the author's assumptions about the role of matter in numerical multiplication; the premises and their wider philosophical reception remain open to analysis.
3. **Source:** Bidayat al-Hikma, supplied bilingual PDF (Arabic original) · p. 106 https://lib.rafed.net/m/?b_id=1571&type=c_fbook

CHAPTER 7

Universals, particulars, and their existence

الفصل السابع في الكلي والجزئي ونحو وجودهما

One might suppose that universality and particularity belong merely to the manner of cognition. On this hypothesis, sense perception, being stronger, grasps its object as distinct from every other thing, whereas intellectual cognition, being weaker, apprehends something without full distinction and thus capable of being applied to several objects.

A distant shape, for example, might turn out to be Zayd, ʿAmr, an upright piece of wood, or something else; in fact it is only one of these. An effaced coin may likewise be taken for several different coins. The indeterminacy of our perception does not mean that the thing perceived is actually universal.

But if universality were only this weakness of discrimination, a universal concept such as ‘human’ could not truly be predicated of more than one of its individual instances. Likewise, universal laws applying to indefinitely many cases, such as ‘four is even’ or ‘every contingent existent has a cause of its existence’, would be true of at most one case and false of the others. Direct intellectual awareness rejects this result.

The correct view, therefore, is that universality and particularity correspond to distinct modes in which quiddities exist, not merely degrees of clarity or indistinctness in a perceiver's psychological state.

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1. **Translator's note:** A universal concept is not merely an indistinct image. Its capacity for genuine predication of many is central to the author's realist account of universality.
2. **Source:** Bidayat al-Hikma, supplied bilingual PDF (Arabic original) · p. 108 https://lib.rafed.net/m/?b_id=1571&type=c_fbook

CHAPTER 8

Distinction and individuation of quiddities

الفصل الثامن في تميز الماهيات وتشخصها

To distinguish one quiddity from another is to mark their difference so that they are not predicable of one another. Human being is distinguished from horse, for example, by the possession of rationality. *Individuation* (tashakhkhuṣ), by contrast, is the determination of a quiddity in such a way that it cannot be predicated of many, as with the individual human being Zayd.

Two consequences follow. First, distinction is a relative description of a quiddity, whereas individuation concerns the thing itself and is not intrinsically a comparative relation. Second, distinction is compatible with universality: adding one universal concept to another still does not produce particularity, no matter how often the operation is repeated. Individuation is different.

Distinction between quiddities can arise in three ways. It can be by their entire essential content, as with the highest genera, which possess no superior genus common to both; otherwise they would not be highest genera. It can be by part of the essence, as when two species share a genus but differ in their specific differentiae, like human and horse. Or it can be by something external to the specific essence, as when individuals or qualified cases belonging to one species are distinguished by separable accidents, as a tall human differs from a short one.

A fourth proposed kind allows a single quiddity to be distinguished by intensity and weakness, priority and posteriority, with the aspect of distinction returning to the aspect of agreement. This is the doctrine of *gradation in quiddity*. The author denies it, arguing that true gradation belongs only to the reality of existence and that this fourth kind of distinction must be understood there instead.

As for individuation, wholly immaterial species have only one individual, as already shown, and individuation therefore accompanies their specific nature. This is what is meant when philosophers say that such substances require no receptivity beyond the agent: they are actualised by an agent in consequence of intrinsic possibility alone.

In material species, however, the common view identifies individuating accidents, especially place, time, and position, as the determining factors. A human individual would, on that account, be specified by a range of bodily magnitude, temporal beginning and ending, and other particular conditions accompanying the individual's development.

The author follows al-Fārābī and Ṣadr al-Mutaʾallihīn in rejecting these accidents as what fundamentally individuates. Adding one universal predicate to another, however many times, does not yield numerical individuality. Individuation is therefore *through existence itself*. The so-called individuating accidents are instead consequences and marks of an already individuated existence.

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1. **Translator's note:** The argument distinguishes logical distinction by properties from numerical individuation. In the author's account, individuation is through existential actuality, not through a complete list of qualitative predicates.
2. **Comparative note:** The critique of individuation by accidental features is important for relating Sadrāian individuation to Aquinas's principle of designated matter, which must not simply be identified with a list of generic accidents.
3. **Source:** Bidayat al-Hikma, supplied bilingual PDF (Arabic original) · p. 110 https://lib.rafed.net/m/?b_id=1571&type=c_fbook

STAGE VI

The Ten Categories

المقولات العشر

CHAPTER 1

Substance, accident, and the ten categories

الفصل الأول تعريف الجوهر والعرض عدد المقولات

Quiddity is divided at the outset into *substance* and *accident*. A quiddity is substantial if, when existing outside the mind, it exists not in a subject that could subsist independently of it. It may exist without inhering in any subject at all, as a self-subsistent intellectual substance does; or it may exist in something that cannot itself exist without it, as a substantial elemental form exists in matter that is actualised through the form.

An accidental quiddity, by contrast, is such that, when existing outside the mind, it exists in a subject able to subsist independently of it. Examples include proximity and distance between bodies and postures such as standing, sitting, facing towards, or turning away.

The existence of both kinds is, in outline, evident. Whoever denies substance must treat accidents themselves as substances, thereby admitting under another name what was denied.

There are nine accidental categories, considered as highest genera. ‘Accident’, however, is a common predicate of them and not a superior genus encompassing them. Likewise, ‘quiddity’ is common to all ten categories but is not a genus above them.

The nine accidental categories are quantity, quality, place (*where*), time (*when*), position, possession or having, relation, acting, and being acted upon. This is the traditional Peripatetic enumeration based on induction. Some philosophers reduce the list to four by grouping the final seven relational categories together; the master of Illumination [Suhrawardī] posits five by adding motion to those four.

The detailed questions about the categories and their subordinate species are extensive. The author will outline the conventional Peripatetic position while noting alternatives.

1. **Terminology:** The distinction is between being-in-a-subject that is independent of the accident and matter's being constituted by a substantial form. Merely saying that a form is ‘in matter’ does not make it a categorial accident.

2. **Source:** Bidayat al-Hikma, supplied bilingual PDF (Arabic original) · p. 114 https://lib.rafed.net/m/?b_id=1571&type=c_fbook

CHAPTER 2

Divisions of substance

الفصل الثاني في أقسام الجوهر

Substances are conventionally divided into five kinds: matter, form, body, soul, and intellect. This division is based, in reality, on induction from the substantial kinds whose existence has been argued for.

Intellect is a substance immaterial both in its essence and in its operations. **Soul** is a substance immaterial in essence but related to matter in its operations. **Matter** is the substantial bearer of potency. **Corporeal form** is the substantial principle actualising matter with respect to extension in three dimensions. **Body** is an extended substance existing in those three dimensions.

The inclusion of corporeal form under the category of substance is qualified. Form corresponds to differentia considered *with the condition of exclusion from predication* (bi-sharṭ lā); a substantial differentia is not itself contained under the category of substance in the same manner as a complete species, even when the predicate ‘substantial’ may be applied to it. A similar qualification arises concerning soul.

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1. **editorial synthesis of lecture notes:** Keep the canonical five types of substance distinct: matter, form, body, soul, and intellect. The student notes contain a slip treating genus and differentia as two members of this set. (Krishnan, printed p. 91; attribution to the lecturer as mediated by the note-taker.)
2. **Translator's note:** The fivefold division is inductive, not an a priori proof that all substantial beings belong to one of five demonstrated species. The form/differentia qualification recalls the prior chapter on genus and differentia.
3. **Source:** Bidayat al-Hikma, supplied bilingual PDF (Arabic original) · p. 116 https://lib.rafed.net/m/?b_id=1571&type=c_fbook

CHAPTER 3

Body

الفصل الثالث في الجسم

Bodies plainly differ from one another while sharing *corporeality*, the character of a substance extended in three dimensions. A body as body is divisible in its possible dimensions and appears to sense as a connected unity.

But is it truly one continuum as sensation presents it, or a collection of parts separated by intervals? If it is continuous, are its potential divisions finite or without limit? If it consists of parts actually distinct, do the smallest parts resist external division while remaining divisible in imagination and thought because they retain magnitude? Or are they indivisible even in

imagination and intellect, having no magnitude and admitting only sensible indication, with their number either finite or infinite? There are defenders of each option, yielding five principal positions.

First, a body is truly continuous as it appears to sense and admits only finitely many potential divisions. This position is attributed to al-Shahrastānī.

Second, a body is truly continuous and admits division without any final limit. It can be physically divided by cutting or by differences of accidents; when physical instruments can no longer cut, imaginative division remains; and when imagination can no longer picture the exceedingly small parts, intellect judges that anything with magnitude still has one extremity distinct from another and therefore remains divisible. Division does not destroy magnitude. This is attributed to the philosophers.

Third, a body consists of extremely small, hard particles possessing magnitude that cannot be divided physically but can still be divided imaginatively and intellectually. This is attributed to Democritus.

Fourth, a body is composed of indivisible parts without magnitude, not divisible externally, imaginatively, or intellectually, and separated by intervals through which a cutting instrument can pass. The number of such parts is finite. This is attributed to most of the theologians.

Fifth, the fourth account is retained except that the indivisible parts are held to be infinite in number.

The author rejects the fourth and fifth views. If the alleged indivisibles lack all magnitude, combining them cannot produce an extended body. If they possess magnitude, they are necessarily divisible at least in imagination and intellect, even if no physical division is possible. He adds that if the parts of the body were infinite in the proposed way, its magnitude would be infinite. Extended demonstrations against the indivisible atom are found elsewhere.

Against the second account he argues that the proofs for a body's being one substantial continuum without real intervals, as it seems to sense, are weak. He appeals to developments in natural science, taken as an assumption for his philosophical analysis: bodies are composed of atomic particles, themselves constituted of smaller parts with central nuclei possessing magnitude.

The first view also fails in his judgment, because it combines complete actual continuity with a finite potential divisibility terminating absolutely.

The result is that extended corporeal substance is real, but its primary instances are taken to be the first physical parts in which corporeal extension actually occurs and into which more complex bodies are divided. The author describes this as Democritus's position with a qualification.

The physical premises invoked here reflect the author's scientific setting. The conceptual dispute concerns continuity, magnitude, and divisibility; the particular physical theory cited is not presented here as a result independently established by metaphysics.

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1. **Historical and scientific note:** The account of atoms, nuclei, and ‘primary extended parts’ represents the author's twentieth-century natural-philosophical assumption. Modern physical theories do not straightforwardly vindicate any single historical theory of ultimate indivisible particles.
2. **Translator's note:** ‘Divisible in intellect’ differs from actually divisible by cutting. The arguments against a magnitude-less part are metaphysical, but the move from those arguments to a particular microphysical model requires an empirical premise.
3. **Source:** Bidayat al-Hikma, supplied bilingual PDF (Arabic original) · p. 118 https://lib.rafed.net/m/?b_id=1571&type=c_fbook

CHAPTER 4

Prime matter and corporeal form

الفصل الرابع في إثبات المادة الأولى والصورة الجسمية

Body considered simply as body—that in which corporeal extension first arises in its own right—is actual. Yet insofar as specific substantial forms and their concomitant determinations can come to it, it is potential. The respect of actuality differs from the respect of potentiality: actuality is constituted by possession, while potentiality is constituted by lack or receptivity.

There is, consequently, in a body a substantial principle that is potential with respect to corporeal forms. It possesses no actuality except the actuality proper to being sheer potency: this is its particular mode of existence.

The corporeality through which it has actuality is a substantial form constituting it. A body therefore consists of *matter* and *corporeal form*, and the composite of the two is the body.

This matter, common to corporeal existents as such, is called *prime matter* (al-mādda al-ūlā), or first hylē (*al-hayūlā al-ūlā*). Prime matter together with corporeal form is itself matter capable of receiving further specific substantial forms, and is then called *secondary matter*.

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1. **editorial synthesis of lecture notes:** Distinguish corporeal form from a specific substantial form and prime matter from an already determinate physical substratum. (Krishnan, printed p. 95; attribution to the lecturer as mediated by the note-taker.)
2. **Terminology:** Prime matter is pure potency in the explanatory analysis and not a free-standing material particle. Corporeal form actualises the dimensions of the material composite; secondary matter is the already corporeal subject receptive to further specific form.
3. **Source:** Bidayat al-Hikma, supplied bilingual PDF (Arabic original) · p. 122 https://lib.rafed.net/m/?b_id=1571&type=c_fbook

CHAPTER 5

Specific substantial forms

الفصل الخامس في إثبات الصور النوعية

Bodies found in external reality differ manifestly in their actions and effects. These actions must have substantial principles. Such a principle cannot be prime matter, whose role is receptivity and undergoing rather than acting. Nor can it be corporeality shared by every body, because corporeality is one common feature, while the effects are diverse.

The different actions therefore require different principles. If these were only distinct accidents, those accidents would ultimately have to depend upon correspondingly distinct substantial realities. The distinct principles cannot simply be corporeality itself, since this is common to all bodies. They are substantial principles through which bodies are constituted as different kinds, called *specific substantial forms* (al-ṣuwar al-nawʿiyya).

At the first level, material substances are differentiated beyond their common corporeality by the forms constituting the elements. The elements in turn provide matter for other forms that come to them.

Earlier natural philosophers counted four elements, and metaphysicians adopted that count as a premise supplied by natural philosophy. Investigators in the author's own time, by contrast, identified approximately a hundred or somewhat more chemical elements. The author records this change in the empirical basis of the traditional account.

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1. **Historical note:** The comparison between four ancient elements and roughly a hundred modern elements belongs to the historical physical context of the text. It does not equate modern chemical elements with the metaphysical principle of prime matter.
2. **Source:** Bidayat al-Hikma, supplied bilingual PDF (Arabic original) · p. 124 https://lib.rafed.net/m/?b_id=1571&type=c_fbook

CHAPTER 6

The inseparability of matter and form

الفصل السادس في تلازم المادة والصورة

Prime matter and form necessarily accompany one another; neither is found apart from the other.

Prime matter cannot be stripped of all form, because its nature is to be potential in every respect. It cannot exist except by being constituted through a substantial actuality united with it. Nothing exists without actuality, and the actual substantial principle that fulfils this role is form. Prime matter therefore cannot exist independently of form.

Conversely, a form of the kind naturally associated with matter cannot be separated from matter. For none of the kinds encountered by sensation and experiment lacks potentiality for change and the possibility of being acted upon. This is taken as a premise from natural science. Whatever has

potency and such possibility does not exist without matter.

Hence material form cannot exist in abstraction from matter in the sense relevant to the form of a material natural kind.

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1. **Translator's note:** The second part concerns forms whose proper nature is to accompany matter. It does not by itself exclude the separately subsisting intellect or rational soul discussed elsewhere.
2. **Source:** Bidayat al-Hikma, supplied bilingual PDF (Arabic original) · p. 126 https://lib.rafed.net/m/?b_id=1571&type=c_fbook

CHAPTER 7

The mutual dependence of matter and form

الفصل السابع في أن كلا من المادة والصورة محتاجة إلى الأخرى

Matter and form depend upon one another. This follows generally from their forming a genuinely unified composite, since the constituents of a true composite need one another. More specifically, form needs matter for its *determination as a specific kind*: its occurrence requires a prior disposition borne by matter, which was previously joined to another form, and so on.

Form also needs matter for its *individual actualisation*. Its individual existence is accompanied by the circumstances traditionally called individuating accidents—shape, position, location, time, and the like.

Matter, on the other hand, depends for its existence both in origination and continuance upon some form or another that constitutes it. Yet the form cannot be the complete cause of matter or its independent efficient cause, for form itself needs matter in being determined and individuated. An efficient cause acts through its actuality. Therefore the agent of matter's existence must be a substance wholly separate from matter: an immaterial intellect which produces matter and preserves its existence by means of successive forms actualised in it.

On this account form is a constituent of the complete cause, a co-principle of the cause of matter, and a condition for the actuality of matter's existence. The philosophers compare the intellect's preserving matter through one form after another to preserving the roof of a house by replacing its supporting pillars: one pillar is withdrawn as another is put in its place.

An objection is raised. The philosophers maintain that the prime matter of the elemental world is numerically one, whereas the form that plays the role of co-principle of its cause is ‘one in general’ rather than a numerically identical form. How can something one merely in general serve as cause of something numerically one, which seems to have stronger unity of existence than what is only generally one? The cause ought to be more actual than its effect.

A second difficulty remains even apart from that. If successive forms truly perish and are replaced, the destruction of a previous form removes a constituent of matter's complete cause, and the removal of the complete cause would remove matter itself. Treating successive forms as co-principles in matter's causation therefore seems to undermine matter's survival through their succession.

The reply anticipates the discussion of potency and act. The succession of substantial forms in material beings is not, in truth, sheer corruption of one form followed by the creation of another disconnected form. Rather, the changing forms have one flowing existence: substantial being itself moves through its successive determinations, each form being a limit or phase of this substantial motion.

The changing forms are therefore continuous and one in their individual process, although the unity is indefinite in a manner appropriate to the indeterminacy of matter, which is pure potency. Saying that ‘some form or another’, one in general, is a co-principle of matter's cause reflects an intellectual consideration of the plurality of determinations produced by dividing this continuous process, not the independent existence of an abstract universal form as efficient cause.

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1. **Translator's note:** This chapter explicitly uses substantial motion to answer the objection that successive substantial forms would destroy the very matter they are alleged to preserve. The claimed continuity is existential, not numerical identity of several disconnected static forms.
2. **Comparative note:** The ‘form as co-principle of matter's complete cause’ and ‘separate intellect as efficient cause’ are specific theses of this metaphysical system and must be distinguished from the form/matter and esse/essence distinctions used in Aquinas.
3. **Source:** Bidayat al-Hikma, supplied bilingual PDF (Arabic original) · p. 128 https://lib.rafed.net/m/?b_id=1571&type=c_fbook

CHAPTER 8

The existence of soul and intellect

الفصل الثامن النفس والعقل موجودان

The existence of soul and intellect can also be established.

The soul is a substance immaterial in essence while related to matter in its activity. Its existence is indicated by the property of knowledge found in human souls. The later stage on knower and intelligible will argue that intelligible forms are immaterial, present to the knower and existing for it. Without the knower's own freedom from potency and its actuality, the presence of anything to the knower would be unintelligible. The human intellectual soul is therefore immaterial.

It is a *substance* insofar as it is the form of a substantial natural kind, and the form of a substantial being is substantial in the relevant sense, as explained earlier.

Intellect is shown to exist because the soul at the stage of material intellect is potential with respect to intelligible forms. What gives those forms actuality cannot be the soul itself considered precisely in that potential state, nor a material cause. The source of their intellectual actuality must be an immaterial substance free of potentiality and possibility in the relevant respect. Such is the separate intellect.

Furthermore, the prior account of material substances has already treated the principle that gives actuality to their kinds by establishing matter and form, and preserves matter through successive forms, as a separate intellect. This supports the same conclusion.

There are additional demonstrations of soul and intellect, some of which will be indicated later.

Finally, a special property of substance is that there is no *contrariety* within the category itself. Contrariety requires one subject capable of receiving either of the two contraries, whereas substance as such is not an accident inhering in a further subject in that manner.

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1. **Translator's note:** The argument from knowledge presupposes the author's theory of immaterial cognition and the intellect's transition from potentiality to actuality. It is not a direct observation of a separate intellect.
2. **Source:** Bidayat al-Hikma, supplied bilingual PDF (Arabic original) · p. 132 https://lib.rafed.net/m/?b_id=1571&type=c_fbook

CHAPTER 9

Quantity and its divisions

الفصل التاسع في الكم وانقساماته وخواصه

Quantity is an accident admitting division in imagination through itself. It is first divided into **continuous** and **discrete** quantity.

A continuous quantity is one in which parts can be supposed to possess a common boundary. A common boundary is something that may be considered as the beginning of either of two parts or the end of either: the point between two portions of a line, the line between portions of a surface, the surface between portions of a mathematical body, and the instant between portions of time.

A discrete quantity lacks such a common boundary. If the number five is separated into three and two, there is no shared unit between them. If that unit were one of the five, the two portions would add up to four; if an additional unit were introduced, they would add up to six. Both results contradict the original division.

Discrete quantity is number, arising from the repetition of units, though unity itself is not a number because it does not meet the definition of quantity in this sense. Each numerical rank is regarded as a distinct kind because of its characteristic properties.

Continuous quantity is further divided into **permanent or coexisting** and **non-coexisting**. A permanent continuum has its supposed parts existing together, as in a line. The non-coexisting continuum is time: any present part obtains only after a preceding part has passed and before a succeeding part has arisen.

Coexisting continuous quantity has three kinds. The *mathematical body* is quantity extended in three dimensions and pervading natural body. A *surface* is the boundary of a mathematical body, divisible in two dimensions. A *line* is the boundary of a surface, divisible in one dimension.

Those who posit an empty void—space not occupied by any existent—raise a further question about coexisting continuous quantity. But the existence of such a void remains to be demonstrated.

Quantity also has characteristic properties. First, its species do not stand in the relation of contraries, because they do not occur in one common subject in the way contraries require. Second, it admits division in imagination, as shown. Third, quantity has something by which it can be measured through repeated subtraction or counting. For discrete quantity the unit is the first measure of all numbers, while certain numbers measure others: two measures four, three measures nine. In continuous quantity a part measures the whole. Fourth, equality and inequality belong properly to quantity and are attributed to other things through quantity.

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1. **Translator's note:** ‘Permanent’ (qārr) here means that the supposed parts of a continuum coexist, not that the body is eternally unchanging. Time is the paradigm of a continuum whose parts do not coexist.
2. **Source:** Bidayat al-Hikma, supplied bilingual PDF (Arabic original) · p. 134 https://lib.rafed.net/m/?b_id=1571&type=c_fbook

CHAPTER 10

Quality

الفصل العاشر في الكيف

Quality is an accident which, considered in itself, does not admit division or relation. The Peripatetic classification distinguishes four primary kinds.

First, psychic qualities, such as knowledge, will, cowardice, courage, despair, and hope.

Second, qualities specific to quantities: straightness, curvature, and shape in continuous quantities, and evenness and oddness in discrete numbers.

Third, dispositional qualities, called *powers and non-powers*. These include a strong disposition to undergo change, such as softness, and a strong disposition not to undergo it, such as hardness. Disposition inhering in matter generally should also be included here. The relation of disposition

to substantial potency, which is matter, resembles the relation of mathematical body—the actuality of three-dimensional magnitude—to natural body, which is receptive to it.

Fourth, qualities apprehended through the five external senses. If these pass quickly, like the redness of embarrassment or the pallor of fear, they are called *affections* (infiʿālāt). If relatively stable, like the yellowness of gold and the sweetness of honey, they are called *affective qualities* (infiʿāliyyāt).

The author notes that investigators of nature have questioned whether sensible qualities exist externally exactly as they appear in sensory experience. Their discussions of this issue are treated in the sciences concerned.

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1. **Terminological note:** The contrast between quality and substantial potency is maintained: preparedness or disposition as an accident is not the same as the material principle capable of receiving actualisation.
2. **Source:** Bidayat al-Hikma, supplied bilingual PDF (Arabic original) · p. 138 https://lib.rafed.net/m/?b_id=1571&type=c_fbook

CHAPTER 11

The relative categories

الفصل الحادي عشر في المقولات النسبية

The seven relational categories are *where* (place), *when* (time), *position*, *having* or *possession*, *relation*, *acting*, and *being acted upon*.

Where is the determination arising from a thing's relation to place.

When is the determination arising from a thing's relation to time. Being ‘in time’ includes being extended through time, as movements are, and being at its boundary, the instant, as are instantaneous occurrences such as contact, separation, and connection. It also includes being spread across time in the manner of traversing motion or being related to time without such continuous traversal, as in intermediate motion.

Position is the determination arising from relations of a thing's parts to one another and of the whole to the exterior. Standing, for instance, results from a definite ordering of the limbs, with the head above and the feet below.

Having (or the category of possession) is the state resulting when one thing surrounds another and the surrounding thing moves when the surrounded thing moves. The enclosure may be complete, as with being wrapped in a cloak, or partial, as with wearing a shirt or shoes.

Relation (iḍāfa) is the determination arising from a reciprocal reference between two things. A bare relation in one direction does not yet amount to a categorial relation. Rather, the thing is considered as referred to something that is itself referred back to it—for example, a father considered as father of this child, while the child is considered as child of this father.

Relations divide into those with like terms, as between siblings, and those with unlike terms, as between father and child or above and below. Correlatives are coequal in existence and non-existence, actuality and potentiality: precisely as correlatives they cannot differ under these determinations.

The term *relative* may refer either to the relation itself, such as fatherhood and sonship, called the *relative in the strict sense*, or to the subject possessing the relation, such as father or child, called the *relative in customary usage*.

Acting is the determination arising in an agent through its affecting another while it acts, as the condition of what heats something while the heating is occurring.

Being acted upon is the corresponding determination in the recipient as it undergoes the action, as in something being heated while it is becoming hot.

The gradual or ongoing character included in these definitions excludes an instantaneous act or reception of actuality, such as the Necessary Existent's production of a separate intellect from non-being and the intellect's receiving existence in virtue of its intrinsic possibility. The categories ‘acting’ and ‘being acted upon’, as defined here, concern processes of acting and undergoing rather than every instance of metaphysical causation.

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1. **Critical textual note:** The printed Rafed witness reads «إلا بداعيين» in the last sentence, which is evidently problematic. Its own printed explanatory note reads «أي لإخراج الفعل والانفعال الدفعي». The English follows the sense of ‘excluding instantaneous acting and being acted upon’; the Arabic reading is retained pending collation with another printed witness.
2. **Terminological note:** For iḍāfa, the reciprocal orientation of correlatives is essential. The author distinguishes the categorial relation itself (fatherhood) from the subject termed relative (father), and the categories of acting/undergoing from all causal activity whatsoever.
3. **Source:** Bidayat al-Hikma, supplied bilingual PDF (Arabic original) · p. 140 https://lib.rafed.net/m/?b_id=1571&type=c_fbook

STAGE VII

Cause and Effect

العلة والمعلول

CHAPTER 1

Causality belongs to existence

الفصل الأول في إثبات العلية والمعلولية وأنهما في الوجود

We have already shown that a quiddity, taken in itself, is possible, with an equal relation to existence and non-existence. For one side to obtain rather than the other it requires something beyond itself. Strictly speaking, describing the quiddity as requiring another in order to remain non-existent is figurative: the real need concerns its existence, which depends on another.

This dependence must be upon an *existent* other, since the non-existent as non-existent has no thingness. The existent upon which the effect thus depends is called a *cause* (ʿilla), and the dependent thing in its existence an *effect* (maʿlūl).

But what exactly does the cause produce? Is it the effect's existence, its quiddity, or the ‘becoming existent’ of that quiddity?

The product cannot be the quiddity. Quiddity, as already established, has a derivative or intellectually considered status, whereas what an effect receives from its cause must be actual and original. Moreover, the quiddity's dependence upon its cause belongs ultimately to its *existence*, not to its defining essence taken apart from existence.

Nor can the product be the quiddity's *becoming existent*. Such ‘becoming’ is a relational meaning involving both the quiddity and existence as terms. Something possessing original extramental actuality cannot be constituted merely by a relation between two considered items, neither of which is independently original in the proposed sense.

The effect produced by the cause is therefore the effect's *existence itself*, not its quiddity or the relation of its quiddity to existence.

1. **Translator's note:** The contrast between jaʿl al-wujūd and jaʿl al-māhiyya is foundational for this Sadrāian theory of causation. ‘Becoming existent’ is rejected as a separately produced relational item.
2. **Source:** Bidayat al-Hikma, supplied bilingual PDF (Arabic original) · p. 145 https://lib.rafed.net/m/?b_id=1571&type=c_fbook

CHAPTER 2

The divisions of causes

الفصل الثاني في انقسامات العلة

Causes admit several divisions.

A cause may be **complete** or **incomplete**. The complete cause comprises everything upon which the effect's existence depends, so that, with it given, the effect cannot but exist. An incomplete cause contains some but not all of what is required. The presence of the complete cause entails the presence of its effect, while its absence entails the effect's absence. The presence of an incomplete cause does not suffice for the effect, but the absence of a necessary constituent of the causal conditions excludes it.

Causes are also divided into **one** and **many**, and into **simple** and **composite**. A simple cause has no parts, whereas a composite cause does. Simplicity may be considered externally, as with certain separate intellects or accidents, or more comprehensively in the absence of external matter-form composition and intellectual genus-differentia composition. The simplest of all is that which has no composition even of existence and quiddity: the Necessary Existent, exalted is He.

Causes are **proximate** or **remote**. The proximate cause has no intermediate cause between it and its effect; the remote cause acts through another cause, as a cause of a cause.

Causes are further divided into **intrinsic** and **extrinsic** causes. The intrinsic causes, also called causes of constitution, are the matter and form constituting a composite effect. The extrinsic causes, also called causes of existence, are the efficient agent and the end or final cause. The agent is described as that *through which* the thing exists, and the final cause as that *for the sake of which* it exists.

Finally, one distinguishes **true causes** from **preparatory conditions**. Calling preparatory conditions ‘causes’ is somewhat figurative. They do not by themselves confer the effect's existence but bring matter closer to the point of receiving actuality from an efficient agent. A moving thing reaching each limit of its path is thereby disposed to reach the next; similarly, the passing of segments of time brings the subject of a future event closer to its actual occurrence.

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1. **Terminology:** Muʿiddāt (preparatory conditions) are not efficient causes in the complete existential sense. The complete/incomplete distinction concerns the full sufficient causal complex and the necessary causal constituents.
2. **Source:** Bidayat al-Hikma, supplied bilingual PDF (Arabic original) · p. 147 https://lib.rafed.net/m/?b_id=1571&type=c_fbook

CHAPTER 3

Necessary concomitance of complete cause and effect

الفصل الثالث في وجوب المعلول عند وجود العلة التامة ووجوب وجود العلة عند وجود المعلول

Whenever a complete cause exists, its effect must exist. Otherwise the effect could be absent despite the presence of everything required for it; its absence would then be unexplained. Likewise, if an effect actually exists, its cause must exist, since the absence of any necessary cause —complete or incomplete—would exclude the effect.

It follows that an effect cannot be separated in existence from its cause, nor can a complete cause, insofar as it is complete, be separated from its effect.

If an effect is temporal and exists at a definite time, its cause must also be present and actual at that time. The effect depends upon its cause at that very time, and it is then that the cause determines and bestows its existence. If the cause existed at a different time but not while the effect existed, the cause would be giving existence to the effect while itself non-existent, which is impossible.

There is another proof. The dependence of an effect's quiddity on its cause is nothing other than the dependence of its *existence*. That dependence is not an additional item alongside the effect's actual existence, as though there were first an independent existence and then a relation of need. Rather, need belongs to the very reality of the effect's existence. Its existence is itself dependence and connection; relative to its cause it is a *linking existence* without self-subsistence.

An existence whose very identity is dependent cannot occur except as constituted by, and relying upon, its cause. Thus whenever the effect exists, its cause necessarily exists.

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1. **Philosophical note:** The second argument states a stronger thesis than mere temporal co-occurrence: the effect is not an independently constituted object that later acquires a relation of dependence; its existence is characterised as dependence itself.
2. **Source:** Bidayat al-Hikma, supplied bilingual PDF (Arabic original) · p. 149 https://lib.rafed.net/m/?b_id=1571&type=c_fbook

CHAPTER 4

The rule of the one

الفصل الرابع قاعدة الواحد

From the one, insofar as it is one, only one proceeds. The ground of this principle is that cause and effect must possess some intrinsic proportionality (*sankhiyya*) that is not found between that particular cause and arbitrary other effects. Without such proportionality, anything could cause anything and anything could be the effect of anything.

There must therefore be in the cause an aspect proportionate to its effect, through which that particular effect proceeds from it.

Suppose a cause were simply one, having only one aspect in its reality, yet produced several effects *precisely as many*, distinct from one another without any return to a unifying aspect. Their divergent effects would require correspondingly divergent aspects in the cause. The one-aspected cause would then be many-aspected, a contradiction.

Consequently, what produces multiplicity precisely as multiplicity must itself possess some principle of multiplicity. The author also concludes that a plurality of independent causes cannot converge upon one numerically identical effect in the sense excluded by this causal principle.

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1. **Translator's note:** The rule of the one (*al-wāḥid lā yaṣduru ʿanhu illā al-wāḥid*) is qualified by 'insofar as it is one' and 'effects insofar as many'. Its scope is debated in later metaphysics and should not be generalised into a denial of every kind of causal cooperation.
2. **Source:** Bidayat al-Hikma, supplied bilingual PDF (Arabic original) · p. 151 https://lib.rafed.net/m/?b_id=1571&type=c_fbook

CHAPTER 5

Against causal circularity and infinite regress

الفصل الخامس في استحالة الدور والتسلسل في العلل

A causal circle (*dawr*) is impossible. It occurs when the existence of something depends on what itself depends upon that thing, whether directly, an *explicit circle*, or through one or more intermediaries, a *concealed circle*. In either case the thing's existence ultimately depends upon itself. Since a cause is prior to its effect in the order of being, the thing would have to precede itself, which is impossible.

An infinite regress of essentially ordered causes (*tasalsul*) is also impossible. One of the strongest demonstrations, given by Avicenna in the *Metaphysics of the Healing*, can be summarised as follows.

Suppose an effect, its cause, and the cause of that cause. In this ordered set of three each member has a characteristic role. The last effect is effect only; its immediate cause is both effect relative to what precedes it and cause relative to what follows; the first cause in the selected set is cause only. The pure effect forms one extreme, the pure cause the other, and the cause-and-effect member is the middle.

If a fourth member is added to the ordered chain, the two extremes retain their roles while there are now two middle members, both causes and effects. The same reasoning holds for any larger number: everything between the two extremes belongs to the middle and has the character of being both cause and effect.

If an essentially ordered series of causes were infinite in the direction of causes, everything beyond the last effect would be a ‘middle’ with no first extreme to ground it. A middle without an extreme is impossible.

The argument applies to any essentially ordered chain of causes whose existence is not separated from the effect, whether the causes are complete or incomplete. It does not apply indiscriminately to preparatory conditions arranged in a temporal succession.

A further argument particularly concerns complete causes. As established, the effect's existence is linking existence, intrinsically dependent upon its cause. If every cause were itself an effect in an infinite regress with no uncaused cause, there would be only dependent existences without an independent actuality in which they could be grounded. This is impossible. Other demonstrations against infinite causal regress are discussed in more extensive works.

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1. **Translator's note:** The regress in question is an essentially ordered series of concurrent existential dependence, not every temporally ordered succession. The middle/extreme argument and the argument from the dependent character of effects are distinct demonstrations.
2. **Source:** Bidayat al-Hikma, supplied bilingual PDF (Arabic original) · p. 153 https://lib.rafed.net/m/?b_id=1571&type=c_fbook

CHAPTER 6

The efficient cause and its kinds

الفصل السادس العلة الفاعلية وأقسامها

The efficient cause is that which bestows the existence of an effect and brings it into actuality. Philosophers distinguish its kinds by asking first whether the agent knows its action. If not, either the action is suited to its nature—the *natural agent*—or it conflicts with that nature—the *constrained agent*. If the agent knows its action, either it is not voluntary—the *compelled agent*—or it is voluntary.

Among voluntary agents, the knowledge of the action may be at the very rank of the action, indeed identical with it: this is agency by *satisfaction* or *consent* (riḍā). Otherwise knowledge precedes the action. If prior knowledge is accompanied by a further motive, this is agency by *intention* (qaṣd). If no additional motive is required, knowledge itself issues in the act; and if the knowledge is additional to the agent's essence, this is agency by *providence* or *care* (ʿināya), while if it is identical with the agent's essence, this is agency by *self-manifestation* (tajallī).

There is a further consideration: when an agent and its action are themselves dependent upon a higher agent, the lower is termed an agent by *subordination* (taskhīr). Thus eight classes are named.

1. **Natural agent (bi-l-ṭabʿ):** it does not know its act, which is in accordance with its nature. An example is the soul insofar as it operates through bodily natural powers.

2. **Constrained agent (bi-l-qasr):** it lacks knowledge of its act, and the act is not suited to its nature. The author illustrates it by bodily powers under pathological conditions, where their operation is diverted from the course of health by constraining factors.

3. **Compelled agent (bi-l-jabr):** it has knowledge of its action but does not will it, as when someone is forced to perform an act against his will.

4. **Agent by satisfaction (bi-l-riḍā):** it has will, but its detailed knowledge of the act is identical with the act itself. Before acting it has only a general knowledge of the act through knowing itself. An example is the soul producing imaginal forms: the detailed cognition of these forms is identical with their presence, while prior to them the soul has an undifferentiated knowledge through itself. Illuminationist thinkers attribute this kind of agency to the Necessary Existent.

5. **Agent by intention (bi-l-qaṣd):** it has will and prior knowledge of its act with an additional motivating purpose, as with human voluntary actions.

6. **Agent by providence (bi-l-ʿināya):** its prior knowledge of its act is distinct from the agent's essence, but that cognition itself directly produces the action without an additional motive. One example offered is a person standing on a narrow height who, by imagining a fall, actually falls. Peripatetic philosophers use this category in their account of the Necessary Existent's producing the world.

7. **Agent by self-manifestation (bi-l-tajallī):** the agent's prior detailed knowledge of its effects is identical with a general knowledge of itself. The immaterial human soul is given as an example: as the ultimate specific form of its kind it is, in its simplicity, the source of its perfections and effects, which it possesses implicitly. Knowledge by presence of its own essence thereby includes its perfections without their separately distinguished presentation. The Necessary Existent's agency is placed here on the author's later account, according to which His general knowledge is at once a detailed disclosure.

8. **Agent by subordination (bi-l-taskhīr):** this is an agent considered as itself dependent, together with its action, upon a higher agent. Natural, vegetative, and animal powers are subordinate to the human soul in their activities; cosmic agents are subordinate to the Necessary Existent.

The author closes by noting that it is debatable whether compelled agency and agency by providence differ *specifically* from intentional agency as the classification seems to suggest.

1. **Terminological note:** The eight classes distinguish knowledge of the act, prior or concurrent cognition, voluntariness, additional motive, and dependence on a higher agent. ‘Agent by tajallī’ must not be silently reduced to an act of external sensory disclosure.
2. **Philosophical note:** Attributions of divine agency to the Peripatetics and Illuminationists are reported from the author's classificatory standpoint; the precise original doctrines require examination of their primary texts.
3. **Source:** Bidayat al-Hikma, supplied bilingual PDF (Arabic original) · p. 155 https://lib.rafed.net/m/?b_id=1571&type=c_fbook

CHAPTER 7

The final cause

الفصل السابع في العلة الغائية

The final cause is the ultimate perfection towards which the agent's activity is directed.

Where the agent's knowledge participates in its agency, the end is something the agent wills through its action; equivalently, the action is willed for the end's sake. In this sense it is said that the end precedes the act in conception while following it in actual existence.

Where knowledge does not enter the agent's activity, the end is what its operation naturally reaches. For a thing bears a fixed relation to its own perfection, and its nature calls for that perfection. To have its appropriate development blocked always or for most of its existence would amount to perpetual or prevalent constraint. This would conflict with divine providence, under which every possible being is directed towards the perfection for which it possesses a native receptivity.

Each thing therefore has as its end the ultimate perfection that belongs to the order of its nature. Occasional constraint is a limited evil compensated by a greater good. It arises in the material world through the interference and competition of differing causes.

1. **Translator's note:** The distinction is between an end that is consciously willed and an end reached by natural agency without deliberation; ‘end’ is not restricted to a consciously imagined future object.
2. **Source:** Bidayat al-Hikma, supplied bilingual PDF (Arabic original) · p. 159 https://lib.rafed.net/m/?b_id=1571&type=c_fbook

CHAPTER 8

Final causality in apparently purposeless acts

الفصل الثامن في إثبات الغاية فيما يعد لعبا أو جزافا أو باطلا

It is sometimes supposed that natural agents have no ends, because a final cause is thought to require conscious knowledge and choice. But we have already seen that final causality is broader: the natural agent's end is the perfection attained through its movement.

It is also supposed that many voluntary acts lack ends, such as children's seemingly pointless movements, playing with one's beard, breathing, a sleeping sick person's turning from one side to another, or a movement interrupted before it reaches its intended goal. In fact none of these actions is wholly without an end.

The immediate principle of voluntary motion is the operative power distributed through the muscles. Before it there is an intermediate principle, appetite or desire, leading to will and resolve. Before that comes the more remote principle, knowledge: a particular conception of the action, sometimes accompanied by assent that the action is good for the agent.

Each of these three principles has an end. Their ends may coincide, or they may differ.

If the primary cognitive principle is deliberate thought, the voluntary action has a consciously considered end. If it is merely imagination without discursive thought, a movement may simply be pictured, desired, and then executed. The action is then called *unconsidered* or spontaneous (jazāf). A child imagines a movement, comes to desire it, and performs it; the resulting motion is the end towards which the immediate principles tend.

If imagination works together with an acquired character or habit, as in playing with one's beard, the action is habitual. If imagination accompanies a natural impulse, as in breathing, or a bodily temperament, as in the movements of the ill, the act is termed a kind of necessary or compelled intention. In each case the relevant operative principles have ends, even where there is no prior discursive plan or the several principles simply converge on the motion that occurs.

An action may also be prevented from attaining its end by an intervening obstacle. Relative to that particular end the action is then said to be *vain* or *frustrated*; but an act's failure to reach an end is not the same as the agent's possessing no end in acting.

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1. **Translator's note:** The example of breathing is used in a classical taxonomy of natural and volitional powers; it should not be read as a contemporary physiological explanation of respiration.
2. **Source:** Bidayat al-Hikma, supplied bilingual PDF (Arabic original) · p. 161 https://lib.rafed.net/m/?b_id=1571&type=c_fbook

CHAPTER 9

The rejection of chance

الفصل التاسع في نفي القول بالاتفاق

Some effects of actions seem neither intended by nor connected with the acting agent. The author gives examples of someone digging a well in search of water but discovering treasure, called good fortune, and someone entering a house for shade only to be killed when it collapses, called bad fortune.

Some ancient natural philosophers used a theory of chance to explain the formation of the world. They supposed that bodies consisted of minute atomic particles moving continuously in an infinite void; the particles happened to collide and assemble into composite bodies. Those suitable for survival remained, while others perished sooner or later.

The author rejects chance as an independent explanation of existence. He begins by dividing events according to frequency: what occurs always, what occurs for the most part, what occurs with approximately equal alternatives, and what occurs only rarely—as with an extra finger on a human hand.

But what occurs usually, rather than invariably, differs from the invariably occurring through the intervention of counteracting causes. The human hand, for example, generally has five fingers; in a rare case the formative power may encounter additional material suited to the formation of another finger. Under the condition of the absence of such additional material, the ordinary result is invariant; under the presence of the specified interfering condition, the rare result likewise follows. What is common or rare in unqualified observation is thus a determined outcome when the relevant conditions are fully specified. The same, the author argues, applies to cases with equal alternatives.

Consequently, all occurrences follow fixed causal orders when considered with their complete conditions. If a perfection or outcome invariably follows an agent's activity under those conditions, intellect judges that there is an existential connection between the activity and its outcome. That connection provides the intelligible ground for a final cause. To doubt the relation of ends to the activities from which they invariably arise would, the author argues, threaten even the relation of effects to efficient causes, since in each case an invariable order of existence is being appealed to.

The events commonly attributed to chance can therefore be re-described. Digging at a spot beneath which treasure lies yields the treasure under the relevant complete conditions: the discovery belongs properly to the actual causal complex, though only accidentally to the water-seeker's intention. Likewise, a house with all the conditions for collapse will fall upon someone inside it, regardless of the person's purpose in taking shelter. The eventual harm is associated accidentally with the intention to seek shade, though causally determined by the entire situation.

To attribute these outcomes to autonomous chance is, on this account, to be ignorant of the causes. ‘Chance’ marks our incomplete knowledge or the accidental relation between distinct lines of causation; it is not an independent producer of being.

1. **Critical note:** The author argues from full causal determination to the denial of chance as an independent ontological cause. The further claim that an outcome thereby counts as a final cause is a substantive philosophical thesis, not a conclusion accepted by every account of finality.

2. **Historical note:** The ancient atomist picture is presented in the terms of the text. It should not be treated as a report of modern physics or evolutionary explanation.
3. **Source:** Bidayat al-Hikma, supplied bilingual PDF (Arabic original) · p. 163 https://lib.rafed.net/m/?b_id=1571&type=c_fbook

CHAPTER 10

Formal and material causes

الفصل العاشر في العلة الصورية والمادية

The *formal cause* is the form through which a composite specific substance, constituted by matter and form, is actually what it is. The species necessarily depends upon that form for its existence. Relative to matter, form also acts as a co-principle with the efficient cause, as discussed earlier. ‘Form’ can have other meanings, but these are not at issue here.

The *material cause* is matter in relation to the species constituted from matter and form, since the species likewise depends upon its matter for its existence. Relative to form, matter is the receptive subject that is actualised by form, as explained above.

Certain natural philosophers have restricted causality to matter alone. The principles already established refute that restriction. Matter, whether primary or secondary, is potential and receptive; its very character involves lack of the actuality for which it is disposed. It cannot by itself give actuality to a species. If there were no further cause, that actuality would arise without a cause, which is impossible.

Moreover, we established that a contingent thing does not exist until it is necessary. Necessity in the sense of existential determination cannot arise from matter considered merely as receptive possibility. There must therefore be something beyond matter that determines and produces the actual existence of the thing.

If the necessary connection which obtains between cause and effect, or between effects of a common cause, were altogether denied, then the inference from any one event to any other would collapse. No reliable general judgment could be based upon such relations, contrary to the evident use of reason.

The term ‘matter’ has other senses besides the material cause here treated, but they lie outside the present discussion.

1. **Terminology:** Matter is the intrinsic receptive cause of a composite, not the complete producer of its actuality. Form is the intrinsic determining cause; ‘co-principle’ and ‘efficient cause’ should not be treated as synonymous.
2. **Source:** Bidayat al-Hikma, supplied bilingual PDF (Arabic original) · p. 167 https://lib.rafed.net/m/?b_id=1571&type=c_fbook

CHAPTER 11

Bodily causation

الفصل الحادي عشر في العلة الجسمانية

Bodily causes have limited effects in three respects: number, duration, and intensity.

The philosophers explain this by substantial motion. Bodily natural kinds undergo substantial motion, so their natures and powers are distributed across determinate phases and limits of a changing existence. Each phase is bounded by preceding and succeeding non-being in the relevant temporal order and is finite both in itself and in its effect.

Furthermore, bodily causes act only with a particular position relative to matter. Just as they depend upon matter in their existence, their production of effects requires matter under definite positional conditions. This need is fulfilled through a particular arrangement connecting them with the effect. Proximity, distance, and the specific dispositions of the bodies involved therefore play a role in corporeal causation.

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1. **Translator's note:** The limitation of bodily causality by time, magnitude, and spatial disposition distinguishes it from the operation of an immaterial cause in the author's scheme.
2. **Source:** Bidayat al-Hikma, supplied bilingual PDF (Arabic original) · p. 169 https://lib.rafed.net/m/?b_id=1571&type=c_fbook

STAGE VIII

Unity and Multiplicity

الواحد والكثير

CHAPTER 1

Unity and multiplicity

الفصل الأول في معنى الواحد والكثير

Unity and multiplicity are among the most general concepts impressed upon the mind immediately, like existence and possibility. Their ‘definitions’—the one is what is indivisible insofar as it is indivisible, and the many what is divisible insofar as it is divisible—are accordingly only verbal explanations. Were they strict real definitions, they would be defective: the definition of unity would depend upon division and therefore upon multiplicity, while the definition of multiplicity would merely repeat division itself. In summary, unity is the aspect of non-division and multiplicity that of division.

Unity is coextensive with existence in its instances, although the two concepts differ in meaning. Every existent is one insofar as it exists, and every one is existent insofar as it is one.

An objection arises. Existence is divided into unity and multiplicity; multiplicity is therefore an existent as well as unity. Yet because unity and multiplicity are opposed divisions, the many, precisely as many, must be other than one. How then can every existent be one?

The answer is that ‘one’ has two considerations. Taken absolutely, without contrast to multiplicity, it includes the many: a plurality, insofar as it exists as this plurality, possesses a certain unity. Hence we may speak of ‘one ten’, ‘several tens’, ‘one plurality’, or ‘several pluralities’. But the one considered *as contrasted with* the many excludes the many.

The distinction is comparable to the different considerations of existence. Existence considered absolutely, opposed to non-being, is actual reality and the source of effects. Yet when we compare the mode in which a thing's characteristic effects obtain with the mode in which its intelligible meaning is merely present, we distinguish external from mental existence. This does not refute existence's general coextensiveness with actuality.

Likewise, unity considered absolutely is coextensive with existence; considered in contrast to numerical multiplicity, it characterises a numerically single person and differs from several persons. The first, broader sense of unity is what is meant when we say that every existent, precisely as existent, is one.

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1. **Terminological note:** The ‘one’ coextensive with existence is the broad unity of an existent as such, not exclusively numerical oneness. Unity as opposed to numerical multiplicity is a restricted consideration.
2. **Source:** Bidayat al-Hikma, supplied bilingual PDF (Arabic original) · p. 172 https://lib.rafed.net/m/?b_id=1571&type=c_fbook

CHAPTER 2

Kinds of unity

الفصل الثاني في أقسام الواحد

The one is either *truly one* or one in a non-primary sense. True unity belongs to the thing itself, without the unity's being attributed to it through something else, as with an individual human being. Non-primary unity occurs when distinct things are called one through a common property, as human and horse are one in animality.

A truly one being is either an essence qualified by unity, or an essence identical with unity itself. The latter is *true unity* in the strictest sense, as with a pure reality wholly free of admixture. In it, the one and unity are identical. The former, such as an ordinary single person, is a qualified unity and not true unity in that strict sense.

A being possessing non-absolute unity may be one **in particular**, or one **in general**. Unity in particular is numerical unity, whose repetition gives rise to number. Unity in general belongs, for example, to one species or genus.

The numerically one can be further distinguished. Its subject either admits no division by its own nature, as well as being one, or admits division. Among indivisibles we may consider the very notion of unity or something different: a point with position, or an immaterial existent without position. The immaterial may be connected with matter in some way, like soul, or wholly separate, like intellect.

A numerically one thing which admits division in its own nature may be divisible *through itself*, like a single magnitude, or through something associated with it, like a natural body divisible through its quantitative extension.

Unity in general may be conceptual, or may signify breadth and extension of actual existence. Conceptual generality includes the unity of a species such as human, the unity of a genus such as animal, and unity through a common accidental characteristic such as walking or laughing. Unity

through existential breadth is exemplified by *expanded existence* (al-wujūd al-munbasiṭ).

Non-primary unity belongs to things which possess a kind of unity through another genuinely one item. Zayd and ʿAmr are one in humanity; human and horse are one in animality. The names given to such unity differ with the ground of agreement: agreement in species is *specific similarity*, in genus *generic similarity*, in quality *resemblance*, in quantity *equality*, in position *parallelism*, and in relation *proportion*. The philosophers regard instances of these divisions as evident.

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1. **Translator's note:** The chapter contains a classificatory tree. ‘True unity’ in the strict sense is not identical to simply being one numerical individual, and ‘unity through breadth of existence’ is not ordinary logical universality.
2. **Source:** Bidayat al-Hikma, supplied bilingual PDF (Arabic original) · p. 175 https://lib.rafed.net/m/?b_id=1571&type=c_fbook

CHAPTER 3

Identity and predication

الفصل الثالث الهوهوية وهو الحمل

Identity or *being-the-same* (huwahuwiyya) belongs to the properties of unity, as otherness belongs to multiplicity. Identity consists in union under some consideration accompanied by difference under another. This is the basis of predication.

In principle any two things which differ in some way but share some unity could be related by predication. Customary logical terminology, however, chiefly applies ‘predication’ to two cases.

First, subject and predicate may be identical in concept and quiddity but differ in the way they are considered. For instance, in ‘A human is a rational animal’, the definition and the defined are conceptually identical, but one expresses the content in summary and the other in detail. Similarly, in ‘A human is human’, the thing is hypothetically considered as distinct from itself in order to deny that supposed difference by affirming identity. This is *primary essential predication* (al-ḥaml al-dhātī al-awwalī).

Second, subject and predicate may differ conceptually while coinciding in their concrete instance, as in ‘A human is capable of laughter’ or ‘Zayd is standing’. This is *common predication* (al-ḥaml al-shāʾiʿ al-ṣināʿī).

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1. **editorial synthesis of lecture notes:** The contrast of primary essential predication and common predication clarifies why a concept can be classified one way qua definition and another way qua an existing mental act. (Krishnan, printed p. 139; attribution to the lecturer as mediated by the note-taker.)
2. **Terminology:** Primary predication concerns identity of conceptual content under different considerations; common predication concerns coincidence in an instance despite difference of conceptual meaning.
3. **Source:** Bidayat al-Hikma, supplied bilingual PDF (Arabic original) · p. 177 https://lib.rafed.net/m/?b_id=1571&type=c_fbook

CHAPTER 4

Kinds of common predication

الفصل الرابع تقسيمات للحمل الشائع

Common predication admits several divisions.

First, there is **direct identity-predication**, in which the predicate is attributed to the subject without positing an additional term, as in ‘A human is capable of laughter’. This is also called predication by agreement or *muwāṭāʾa*. Its counterpart is **predication through possession**, where the unity of predicate and subject requires an additional consideration, such as ‘possessing’ or a derived adjective: ‘Zayd is justice’ is taken to mean ‘Zayd possesses justice’ or ‘Zayd is just’.

Second, it may be **definite**, where the subject has actual instances to which the description applies, as in ‘A human is capable of laughter’ or ‘A writer moves the fingers’; or **non-definite**, where the subject has only supposed rather than actual instances, as in ‘Every absolutely non-existent thing is such that nothing can be predicated of it’ or ‘Every conjunction of contradictories is impossible’.

Third, it may be **simple** or **composite**. The former is the simple existential proposition (*al-haliyya al-basīṭa*), whose predicate is the existence of the subject, as in ‘The human exists’. The latter is the composite existential proposition (*al-haliyya al-murakkaba*), whose predicate is some feature or effect of the subject's existence, as in ‘The human is capable of laughter’.

This distinction resolves the difficulty raised against the rule that the establishment of something for a subject presupposes the subject's establishment. If we apply that rule to ‘The human exists’, it might seem that the human must already exist before existence can be predicated, requiring a further prior existence without end.

But the rule governs the establishment of **something for something**. The simple existential proposition expresses the establishment **of the thing itself**, not a further determination added to an already actual subject. The rule therefore does not apply, and the regress does not arise.

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1. **Translator's note:** The same simple/composite distinction appeared earlier in the discussion of predicating existence of quiddity. The two contexts should be read together rather than treating existence as an accidental extra predicate.
2. **Source:** Bidayat al-Hikma, supplied bilingual PDF (Arabic original) · p. 179 https://lib.rafed.net/m/?b_id=1571&type=c_fbook

CHAPTER 5

Otherness and opposition

الفصل الخامس في الغيرية والتقابل

Otherness (*ghayriyya*) is a property of multiplicity. It is either intrinsic or non-intrinsic.

Intrinsic otherness is difference between two things by reason of what they themselves are, as with existence and non-existence. This is called *opposition* (taqābul). **Non-intrinsic otherness** arises through other circumstances, as when sweetness and blackness are separated in sugar and charcoal respectively. This is called mere *difference* (khilāf).

Opposition is commonly defined as the impossibility of two opposed things occurring together in one subject, in one respect, at one time. It is divided into four classes.

If both opposites are positive existents, either each is understood only in relation to the other, as above and below; these are **correlatives**, and their opposition is *correlative opposition*. Or they do not essentially refer to one another, as black and white; these are **contraries**, and their opposition is *contrariety*.

If one opposite is positive and the other privative—there can be no opposition between two sheer non-entities—then either there is a subject naturally capable of the positive condition, as with sight and blindness; this is the opposition of **possession and privation**. Or there is no such specification of a naturally receptive subject, as with affirmation and negation; these are **contradictories**, and their opposition is *contradiction*.

Every opposition involves two terms, for opposition is a special kind of relation, and a relation must have relata.

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1. **Terminological note:** Intrinsic otherness here names the formal distinction grounding an opposition, not an additional external accident. The four kinds are relational, contrary, privative, and contradictory opposition.
2. **Source:** Bidayat al-Hikma, supplied bilingual PDF (Arabic original) · p. 181 https://lib.rafed.net/m/?b_id=1571&type=c_fbook

CHAPTER 6

Correlative opposition

الفصل السادس في تقابل التضايف

Correlative terms are coequal in existence and non-existence, in potency and act.

If one correlative exists, the other necessarily exists; if one is absent as a correlative, the other is absent. Likewise, if one exists in actuality or in potency, the other is actual or potential in the corresponding respect.

It follows that the two correlatives, considered precisely as correlatives, are simultaneous: neither precedes the other in the mind or outside it. One cannot be father *as father* without another being child *as child*.

1. **Translator's note:** The co-implication concerns the correlatives under their relational descriptions, not two underlying substances in every respect. A person may preexist becoming a father, but fatherhood and sonship arise together in the relevant order.
2. **Source:** Bidayat al-Hikma, supplied bilingual PDF (Arabic original) · p. 183 https://lib.rafed.net/m/?b_id=1571&type=c_fbook

CHAPTER 7

Contrariety

الفصل السابع في تقابل التضاد

Contrariety, according to the preceding division, obtains between two positive realities which are not correlatives and which differ essentially so that they cannot exist together in the same subject in the relevant respect.

Among its properties is that there is no contrariety between the highest genera of the ten categories. More than one category may be instantiated in a single subject, as quantity and quality are present in bodies. Nor is there contrariety between their respective species simply by being in distinct categories, or between certain subordinate genera within one category, such as colour and taste.

Rather, according to the traditional inductive analysis, contrariety is between ultimate species falling under a proximate genus, as black and white under colour.

Contraries also require a subject capable of receiving them successively. Without a common individual subject there is no reason they could not both exist, as when one body is black and another white. Consequently, substances themselves are not contraries, since they do not inhere in a further subject in the requisite way. Contrariety properly belongs to accidents.

Some philosophers substitute the broader notion of *receptive locus* (maḥall) for subject, allowing matter to serve as the locus of substantial forms and thereby admitting contrariety between forms of substance.

Finally, contraries must be at the extreme of difference within the relevant genus. If positive qualities differ by degrees of nearness to one another, the contrary pair occupy the extreme ends. Black and white are taken as examples, with intermediate colours, such as yellow being closer to white than red under the comparison intended.

Thus contraries are two positive, mutually exclusive realities capable of occurring in one subject, included under a proximate genus, and maximally opposed within it.

1. **Terminology:** The difference between a subject independently subsisting for accidents and matter as the receptive locus of substantial forms controls whether ‘substantial contrariety’ is admitted.
2. **Source:** Bidayat al-Hikma, supplied bilingual PDF (Arabic original) · p. 185 https://lib.rafed.net/m/?b_id=1571&type=c_fbook

CHAPTER 8

Privation and possession

الفصل الثامن في تقابل العدم والملكة

This is also called the opposition of *privation and possession* or *deprivation and capacity*. It consists in a positive condition belonging to a subject naturally fitted to receive it and the absence of that condition in that subject. Sight and blindness are the ordinary example: blindness is the loss of sight in something whose nature admits sight.

If the subject of the positive condition is taken as an individual, species, or genus that is in some respect naturally capable of the condition, without specifying a time, we speak of *real* possession and privation. Thus the absence of sight in a scorpion could, on a classification placing it within a sight-capable animal genus, be termed privation even though the particular species is not supposed to be sighted. Likewise, the absence of a beard in a human before the age at which a beard can grow would still count as privation under this broad consideration.

If instead the subject is taken in its own individual nature and at the time when it is naturally fitted to possess the feature, the contrast is called *customary* possession and privation. Under this narrower usage, congenital absence of sight in a subject never fitted to see, or absence of a beard before maturity, is not considered privation in the same technical sense.

The distinction thus turns on the breadth of the natural subject and whether the appropriate time for possession is part of the definition.

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1. **Translator's note:** The older biological examples describe a philosophical classification of privation, not a medical classification of disability.
2. **Source:** Bidayat al-Hikma, supplied bilingual PDF (Arabic original) · p. 187 https://lib.rafed.net/m/?b_id=1571&type=c_fbook

CHAPTER 9

Contradiction

الفصل التاسع في تقابل التناقض

Contradiction is the opposition between affirmation and negation when the negation applies to precisely what the affirmation asserts. In its primary setting contradiction concerns propositions. Their content can also be expressed through terms, as when we speak of the opposition between a thing's existence and its non-existence or say that the contradictory of anything is its removal.

Contradictories neither coexist nor are both absent. This is a genuine exclusive alternative and one of the first principles of thought. Every proposition, whether immediately evident or demonstrated, depends on it: a judgment cannot be known as true without the exclusion of its contradictory. We

can assent that four is even only by rejecting ‘four is not even’. Hence the principle that contradictories cannot both be true or both false is called the *first of the first principles*.

Nothing is exempt from the law. Anything considered is either Zayd or not-Zayd under the same respect, white or not-white, and so on.

The earlier statement that contradictories are ‘removed from the rank of quiddity’ is not an exception. To say that human quiddity as human includes neither existence nor non-existence means neither term enters the essential *definition*. It does not mean a concrete human could be neither existent nor non-existent. The definition is not ‘existing rational animal’ nor ‘non-existing rational animal’.

For genuine contradiction between propositions logicians require the standard eight unities of subject, predicate, time, place, condition, relation, whole and part, and actual/potential respect, as elaborated in logic. Ṣadr al-Mutaʾallihīn adds unity of the *mode of predication*: both judgments must be taken under primary predication or both under common predication. There is no contradiction between ‘The particular is particular’ in primary predication, referring to the concept, and ‘The particular is not particular’ under common predication, considering the concept as a universal mental meaning.

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1. **Critical note:** The list of classical ‘eight unities’ is supplied here for intelligibility; different logic manuals formulate or enumerate the conditions differently. The author's explicit point is Ṣadrā's additional unity of predication.
2. **Source:** Bidayat al-Hikma, supplied bilingual PDF (Arabic original) · p. 189 https://lib.rafed.net/m/?b_id=1571&type=c_fbook

CHAPTER 10

The opposition of one and many

الفصل العاشر في تقابل الواحد والكثير

Philosophers have disputed whether the one and the many are opposed intrinsically. Some call them correlatives, others contraries, and others posit a fifth kind of opposition beyond the four recognised classes.

The correct view, the author argues, is that their difference does not belong to technical opposition at all. The division of existence into one and many is a graded or differentiated division in which the point of difference ultimately returns to the point of agreement. It resembles existence being divided into mental and external existence, or into actual and potential. The intrinsic difference of the terms in the four kinds of technical opposition cannot collapse into their shared ground in this manner. Thus the one and the many are not opposites in any of the four senses.

One must also qualify the status of opposition between affirmation and negation. This is not a real extramental relation but a relation constituted through intellectual consideration. Opposition is a particular relation between two relata, and a real linking relation requires two actual terms. In contradiction, however, one term is a negation, which is absence or nullity. The intellect treats negation as the opposing term of affirmation and apprehends that they cannot coexist in the same respect.

The opposition of privation and possession is different. Privation has a derivative ground in reality, since it is the absence of some perfection in a subject naturally capable of that perfection. The relevant absence is abstracted from the subject, and that degree of derivative or considered establishment suffices for the relational distinction in this case.

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1. **Philosophical note:** The contrast between real relations and intellectually considered opposition is crucial: the law of contradiction is not weakened by denying that a negation is a positive external entity.
2. **Source:** Bidayat al-Hikma, supplied bilingual PDF (Arabic original) · p. 191 https://lib.rafed.net/m/?b_id=1571&type=c_fbook

STAGE IX

Priority, Posteriority, Beginninglessness, and Origination

السبق واللحوق والقدم والحدوث

CHAPTER 1

Priority, posteriority, and simultaneity

الفصل الأول في معنى السبق واللحوق وأقسامهما والمعية

Priority and posteriority belong to the attributes of the existent considered as existent. Two things may share a relation to one existential principle, while one possesses a feature of that relation not possessed by the other. Thus two and three both relate to one, but two is nearer to one and is said to precede three; three follows two. If the shared relation involves no inequality, the two are said to be simultaneous relative to that principle.

The philosophers have distinguished kinds of priority and posteriority through induction.

Temporal priority occurs when the prior and posterior cannot coexist in time: yesterday precedes today, and events in an earlier interval precede those in a later one.

Priority by nature is the priority of an incomplete cause to its effect, as two is prior to three in the illustrative analysis. **Causal priority** is the priority of a complete cause to its effect.

Essential or constitutive priority is the priority of a thing's essential principles to the whole constituted from them, such as the defining constituents of a species to that species. Also included is the priority of quiddity to its necessary concomitants, as four is prior to evenness. These three kinds—natural, causal, and constitutive—are grouped as priorities *in themselves* rather than merely by convention.

Priority in truth applies where the earlier thing possesses some predicate primarily while the later receives it by derivative attribution. Water literally flows, while the spout carrying it is called ‘flowing’ only by attribution. This kind is associated with Ṣadr al-Mutaʾallihīn.

Dahrī priority, or priority in the order of *dahr*, is the priority of a determining cause to its effect, not simply insofar as it bestows the effect's existence, as in causal priority, but insofar as the cause's order of existence is separated from the effect's order and the effect's absence is established

at the superior rank. The separate intellectual realm is said to precede the material realm in this way. This classification is associated with Mīr Dāmād and his account of dahrī origination and beginninglessness.

Priority by rank depends on an ordered series, which may be natural or specified by an assigned standpoint. In a hierarchy of genus and species, one who starts from the highest genus calls each more general term prior to the lower, while starting from the lowest species reverses the description. In a row of worshippers, counting from the miḥrāb makes the imām prior, whereas counting from the entrance reverses the rank.

Priority by excellence concerns the possession of a perfection to a higher degree, as the learned person is prior to the ignorant and the courageous to the cowardly.

Each kind has a corresponding posterior term, and simultaneity names the absence of priority or posteriority under the relevant relation.

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1. **Translator's note:** Priority (sabaq) is used across distinct orders: temporal, causal, essential, truth of attribution, dahr, rank, and perfection. Dahrī priority is not a disguised claim that separate intellects are physically earlier in clock time.
2. **Source:** Bidayat al-Hikma, supplied bilingual PDF (Arabic original) · p. 194 https://lib.rafed.net/m/?b_id=1571&type=c_fbook

CHAPTER 2

The basis of priority

الفصل الثاني في ملاك السبق في أقسامه

The *basis of priority* (malāk al-sabaq) is the common feature shared by the prior and posterior terms in respect of which the priority is established.

In temporal priority it is relation to time, whether the terms are temporal events or parts of time itself. In priority by nature it is relation to existence; in causal priority it is necessity; in constitutive priority it is the established essence or quiddity.

In priority by truth it is obtaining or being actual in the broad sense that admits both primary and derivative attribution. In dahrī priority it is being established in the very order of reality.

In priority by rank it is a relation to a selected starting point, such as the miḥrāb or doorway in a spatial order, or the highest genus or final species in an intellectual hierarchy. In priority by excellence it is the superiority or perfection under consideration.

The kinds are therefore not distinguished by calling one simply ‘earlier’: each presupposes its own shared measure or explanatory order.

1. **Translator's note:** This short chapter prevents equivocating between the several senses of ‘before’, particularly when comparing temporal priority with causal and essential priority.
2. **Source:** Bidayat al-Hikma, supplied bilingual PDF (Arabic original) · p. 198 https://lib.rafed.net/m/?b_id=1571&type=c_fbook

CHAPTER 3

Beginninglessness and origination

الفصل الثالث في القدم والحدوث وأقسامهما

In ordinary usage, ‘ancient’ or ‘old’ (*qadīm*) and ‘new’ or ‘originated’ (*ḥādith*) were originally applied to two things sharing a period of reference, when the first had existed longer than the second. These are relative descriptions: something may be old in comparison with one thing and new in comparison with another. Origination thus initially meant being preceded by non-being in time, and beginninglessness the absence of such precedence.

Philosophers extended the concepts by taking non-being more generally. Non-being includes the *opposed absence* which cannot coexist with the thing's existence, such as its previous temporal non-existence, and *coexistent privation*, meaning the thing's non-existence in itself considered apart from the cause even while it exists through that cause.

Origination now means existence preceded by non-being, and beginninglessness the absence of such precedence. These are attributes of being as such, for an existent is either preceded by non-being or not preceded by it.

Temporal origination is existence after temporal non-existence, as today's existence is preceded by its absence yesterday. The opposite is **temporal beginninglessness**, the absence of preceding temporal non-being. Time itself is given as an example, since if a prior time preceded time as a whole, time would have to obtain precisely where it was supposed absent, a contradiction.

Essential origination is existence preceded by non-being in the thing's own essence, as with every contingent existent whose actuality arises from an external cause. Its quiddity, considered by itself, supplies no existence.

An objection says that quiddity as such contains only possibility, a balance between existence and absence; it is not inherently qualified with non-existence. The response distinguishes modes of predication. Quiddity in its essential definition indeed includes neither existence nor non-existence, and this exclusion is by *primary predication*. But in the absence of any cause giving it being, it is absent under *common predication*. There is no contradiction in these two assertions.

The opposite, **essential beginninglessness**, belongs to that which is not preceded by non-being in its own essence: the reality identical with existence itself, which expels absence by its own actuality. This is the Necessary Existent whose quiddity is His very existence.

Dahrī origination, introduced by Mīr Dāmād, is the existence of one ontological rank preceded by its non-being established in a higher rank of the vertical order. This absence is not concurrent with the effect, yet neither is it a temporal absence. The material world, for example, is said to be preceded by its absence in the imaginal world. The corresponding *dahrī beginninglessness* is the absence of that kind of priority of non-being.

The ontological and temporal accounts of precedence must be distinguished; they are not interchangeable claims about the age of the physical universe.

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1. **Translator's note:** The distinction between essence and existence is indispensable to understanding essential origination: it does not mean that every contingent thing was once absent in chronological time.
2. **Historical note:** The interpretation of dahrī origination is Mīr Dāmād's distinctive philosophical proposal, reported here by Tabāṭabā'ī, not a universally accepted temporal cosmology.
3. **Source:** Bidayat al-Hikma, supplied bilingual PDF (Arabic original) · p. 200 https://lib.rafed.net/m/?b_id=1571&type=c_fbook

STAGE X

Potentiality and Actuality

القوة والفعل

CHAPTER 1

Every temporal event is preceded by potentiality

الفصل الأول كل حادث زماني مسبوق بقوة الوجود

Every temporally originated thing is preceded by *potentiality for existence*. Before it comes into actuality, it must be possible for it to exist and also possible for it not to exist. If it were impossible it could never occur, and if it were intrinsically necessary it could never have been absent. The potentiality in question is not identical with an agent's capacity to produce the thing: it is an attribute of the possible thing relative to its own existence, not relative to another such as the agent.

This possibility is an extramental condition rather than a mere intellectual consideration of quiddity. It admits intensity, weakness, proximity, and remoteness. An embryo possessing the disposition to become a human being is nearer to human actuality than the food that may eventually become an embryo. Its possibility is therefore more intense.

Since the disposition exists externally, it is not an independent self-subsisting substance. It is an accident inhering in something else. Let it be called *potentiality* (quwwa), and let its subject be called *matter* (mādda). Thus every temporal event is preceded by material subjectivity bearing the potentiality for its existence.

Matter must not exclude the actuality for which it is prepared. It is potential with respect to that actuality. If it were already completed in that very respect, it would not receive another actuality. Matter is a substantial principle whose mode of existence is being potential for forms.

Because matter exists as potential while also actual under some form, it needs a prior actuality to constitute it. When the new actuality appears, the previous form ceases in the relevant respect and the new form takes its place. Thus, when water becomes air, the watery form previously actualising the matter gives way to the airy form, under which the same material principle is actualised.

The matter bearing the earlier and later forms must be one. Were the matter itself newly originated along with the new form, its occurrence would require an earlier possibility and prior matter, and the same question would repeat endlessly. An analogous difficulty follows from supposing a first temporal origination of matter itself.

Six conclusions follow. First, every temporal event has matter bearing its potentiality for existence. Second, the matter of successive temporal events is one continuous underlying subject in the relevant analysis. Third, the relation of a particular potentiality to indeterminate matter resembles that of mathematical body, specifying the three dimensions, to natural body with indeterminate corporeal extension.

Fourth, temporal origination entails change, either in substantial form or in an accidental condition. Fifth, potentiality always depends upon actuality; matter always exists through some form, so one form succeeds another in its actualisation. Sixth, a particular potentiality precedes its particular act temporally, while actuality taken absolutely precedes potentiality in every relevant kind of priority, including causal, natural, and temporal priority.

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1. **Philosophical note:** The extramental ‘potentiality of existence’ is dispositional possibility, not intrinsic logical contingency. The claim that matter remains one through substantial transformation is revised in light of the account of continuous substantial motion later in the stage.
2. **Source:** Bidayat al-Hikma, supplied bilingual PDF (Arabic original) · p. 205 https://lib.rafed.net/m/?b_id=1571&type=c_fbook

CHAPTER 2

The divisions of change

الفصل الثاني في تقسيم التغير

We have seen that the passage of something from potentiality to actuality requires change, either in its own substantial constitution or in its conditions.

Change occurs either **all at once** or **gradually**. Gradual change is *motion* (ḥaraka): a mode of the thing's existence unfolding successively. It is in this respect, as a mode of being, that motion belongs to the subject matter of first philosophy.

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1. **Terminology:** The discussion distinguishes change (taghayyur) in general from motion (ḥaraka) as gradual change, rather than using the words interchangeably.
2. **Source:** Bidayat al-Hikma, supplied bilingual PDF (Arabic original) · p. 209 https://lib.rafed.net/m/?b_id=1571&type=c_fbook

CHAPTER 3

The definition of motion

الفصل الثالث في تحديد الحركة

Motion has been identified as the gradual passage of a thing from potentiality to actuality, or simply its gradual change. The concept of graduality is immediately understood with the help of sensation.

Aristotle defines motion as “the first perfection of what is potential insofar as it is potential.” The meaning may be clarified by an example. Acquiring what a thing is capable of acquiring constitutes a perfection. When a body moves towards a place in order to come to rest there, both its journey and its eventual arrival are perfections for it. The journey is a *first* perfection because it precedes the attainment of the destination, which is a *second* perfection.

As the body begins moving it has already attained a perfection, but precisely as something still potential in relation to its second perfection, the destination. Motion is therefore the first perfection of a potential subject insofar as it remains potential in relation to that further perfection.

Six items are required for motion: the starting point from which it occurs, the terminus towards which it proceeds, the subject undergoing it, the agent producing it, the extent or course through which it proceeds, and the time with which it is related in a definite way. These will be examined in turn.

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1. **Translator's note:** The Aristotelian definition translates al-kamāl al-awwal li-mā bi-l-quwwa min ḥaythu innahu bi-l-quwwa. ‘First’ is relative to the attainable end, not necessarily first in chronological existence absolutely.
2. **Source:** Bidayat al-Hikma, supplied bilingual PDF (Arabic original) · p. 211 https://lib.rafed.net/m/?b_id=1571&type=c_fbook

CHAPTER 4

Intermediate and traversing motion

الفصل الرابع في انقسام الحركة إلى توسطية وقطعية

Motion can be considered in two senses.

The first is the body's being *between* its beginning and end, such that, at each supposed intermediate limit, the body is at that limit and not simultaneously at a point before or after it. Taken in this way, motion is described as a simple, undivided condition and is called *intermediate motion* (al-ḥaraka al-tawassuṭiyya).

The second considers that very condition in relation to the successive limits of the course: those already left behind and those not yet reached. The latter correspond to what remains potential, while the former correspond to what has already passed into actuality. Under this consideration

motion is divisible into successive portions, continually passing away. It is the gradual passage from potentiality to actuality called *traversing motion* (al-ḥaraka al-qaṭʿiyya).

Both senses apply to extramental motion with their proper qualifications.

There is also an image produced by the imagination: it gathers the successive limits of motion into one continuous picture whose parts are all present together. This collected representation is mental, not an extramental motion, since the actual simultaneous existence of all its successive parts would amount to rest rather than change.

Motion in the traversing sense, therefore, is a flowing mode of existence divisible into phases in which potency and act are interwoven. Each supposed phase is actual in relation to what precedes it and potential in relation to what follows. In the limiting consideration, one side of the process is potency without the later act, and the other act without the earlier potency.

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1. **Translator's note:** The ‘intermediate’ and ‘traversing’ analyses are two considerations of motion. The separate imaginative picture that collects all phases simultaneously must not be mistaken for the actual successive process.
2. **Source:** Bidayat al-Hikma, supplied bilingual PDF (Arabic original) · p. 213 https://lib.rafed.net/m/?b_id=1571&type=c_fbook

CHAPTER 5

The beginning and end of motion

الفصل الخامس في مبدإ الحركة ومنتهاها

Motion is divisible through its own nature. Its division has no final indivisible part, just as the division of a continuous line, surface, or body does not terminate in an indivisible portion of magnitude. If it did, the alleged final part would be an indivisible component whose impossibility was considered earlier.

The divisibility is **potential**, not an actually existing plurality of detached parts. If the parts of motion were actually separate, each would occur all at once, and motion as a continuous gradual passage would be destroyed.

Consequently, motion possesses no first or last part that is itself an indivisible piece of motion. Such a supposed piece would occur instantaneously, rather than gradually, and would therefore not fall under the definition of motion.

When motion was said to be bounded on one side by potency not yet actualised and on the other by actuality no longer potential, this meant that its limits are provided by what lies outside its flowing essence. It did not posit instantaneous parts of the motion itself.

1. **Terminological note:** The denial of a smallest part of movement concerns the continuity of gradual motion, not the denial that a movement can have a beginning or ending boundary.
2. **Source:** Bidayat al-Hikma, supplied bilingual PDF (Arabic original) · p. 215 https://lib.rafed.net/m/?b_id=1571&type=c_fbook

CHAPTER 6

The subject of motion

الفصل السادس في موضوع الحركة وهو المتحرك الذي يتلبس بها

Motion is the gradual passage of something from potentiality to actuality. That potentiality must be borne by a substantial subject. What is potentially a perfection is united with its matter; when the potentiality is actualised, the new actuality is united with that matter in the place of the former potential state.

For example, the matter of water is potentially air, and an acidic body is potentially sweet. When water changes into air or sourness into sweetness, it is the matter of the water that receives the airy actuality, and the formerly acidic body that becomes sweet. Every motion therefore has something undergoing it, a subject in which the change occurs and which the motion qualifies.

The subject must be stable in the respect needed to make the movement *one* process. If what was potential and what subsequently became actual had no shared subject, there would be no single movement from potency to act.

Yet the subject cannot be actual in every respect, like a wholly separate intellect, for motion requires potentiality. Nor can it be potential in every respect in such a way that it lacks existence altogether. It must be actual in one respect and potential in another.

Prime matter illustrates this by being potential for forms while possessing the restricted actuality proper to such receptivity. An already existing body, as secondary matter, possesses corporeal actuality and certain specific forms while remaining potential for other specific forms and accidents.

1. **Philosophical note:** The requirement of a persistent subject is reconsidered for substantial motion in Chapter X.12, where the movement's own continuous substantial actuality plays the subject-role.
2. **Source:** Bidayat al-Hikma, supplied bilingual PDF (Arabic original) · p. 217 https://lib.rafed.net/m/?b_id=1571&type=c_fbook

CHAPTER 7

The agent of motion

الفصل السابع في فاعل الحركة وهو المحرك

The mover must be other than the moving thing, at least in the respect relevant to the motion. Were the subject of motion to produce in itself the actuality it is receiving, one thing would be at once agent and recipient in precisely the same respect. This is impossible, for agency is considered under possession of actuality and receptivity under lack of it. One thing cannot possess and lack the same perfection in one respect.

Furthermore, the moving thing is potential in relation to the new actuality it receives and therefore does not yet possess it. What is potential merely as potential cannot bestow that actuality.

The **proximate** cause of motion must itself be changing and renewed in its actual state. If it were wholly fixed without any intrinsic change or flow, what immediately issued from it would be fixed as well. No phase of motion could pass into another, since the proximate cause would remain exactly unchanged under the same relevant condition. The result would not be motion.

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1. **Translator's note:** The requirement of a changing mover is explicitly about the *proximate* mover. It creates the problem of relating change to an ultimately unchanging first principle, which the next chapter addresses.
2. **Source:** Bidayat al-Hikma, supplied bilingual PDF (Arabic original) · p. 219 https://lib.rafed.net/m/?b_id=1571&type=c_fbook

CHAPTER 8

Relation of the changing to the unchanging

الفصل الثامن في ارتباط المتغير بالثابت

An objection arises: if every changing thing must depend on a changing proximate cause, the latter must also depend on something changing, and so on without end. This appears to entail an infinite regress, a causal circle, or change in the First Principle, exalted above such change.

The reply is that change ultimately reaches a substance that moves or flows in its very substantial reality. Renewal is intrinsic to such a substance. It can therefore be produced by an unchanging cause which gives it its nature: **to cause this flowing substance to exist is already to cause its renewal**. The cause does not first produce a static thing and then add change to it as a further attribute.

In this way a changing effect may depend on an immutable ultimate cause without attributing change to that cause.

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1. **Philosophical note:** The key move is the claim that renewal is intrinsic to flowing substance, and therefore the first cause causes *a being whose very esse is successive*, rather than supplying successive external alterations to an otherwise static substance.
2. **Source:** Bidayat al-Hikma, supplied bilingual PDF (Arabic original) · p. 221 https://lib.rafed.net/m/?b_id=1571&type=c_fbook

CHAPTER 9

The distance traversed in motion

الفصل التاسع في المسافة التي يقطعها المتحرك بالحركة

The *course* or *distance* of motion is the continuous, flowing existence that occurs in the moving subject. A category is necessarily abstracted from it, but not insofar as it is simply one flowing continuum. To predicate a changing degree of a single quiddity in that respect would imply gradation within quiddity itself, which the author rejects.

Rather, the flowing course is considered insofar as it can be divided into instantaneous limits, each corresponding to a distinct species or determination under the relevant category. In growth, for example, the body moves under quantity: at each supposed instant there is a particular determination of continuous quantity, distinct from that obtaining at a preceding or succeeding instant.

Thus a thing's motion within a category means that the subject successively receives determinations under that category that differ at successive limits of the movement. The course is a single flowing actuality in its existential aspect, while the distinct categorial quiddities are abstracted from its successive determinations.

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1. **Translator's note:** The distinction between one continuous flowing existence and differing categorial determinations at its instantaneous limits protects the claim that gradation belongs to wujūd, not to the quiddity of quantity itself.
2. **Source:** Bidayat al-Hikma, supplied bilingual PDF (Arabic original) · p. 223 https://lib.rafed.net/m/?b_id=1571&type=c_fbook

CHAPTER 10

The categories in which motion occurs

الفصل العاشر في المقولات التي تقع فيها الحركة

The traditional philosophers held that motion occurs in four categories: *place*, *quality*, *quantity*, and *position*.

Motion in **place** is evident in locomotion. Yet whether ‘where’ is an independent category is disputed. If location is a kind of position, local motion is correspondingly a variety of positional motion.

Motion in **quality**, especially qualities dependent upon quantity such as straightness, curvature, and similar determinations, is also evident. A body changing in quantity can thereby undergo a change in the qualities of its magnitude.

Motion in **quantity** is a continuous, ordered change in magnitude, such as growth: the body's dimensions increase successively and in a regular relation.

An objection says that growth occurs through the addition of parts from outside. The later, larger quantity belongs to the composite of the original and added parts, while the earlier, smaller quantity belonged only to the original parts. Since the subjects are distinct, the two quantities are distinct and discontinuous. There would be the disappearance of one quantity and the occurrence of another, not continuous quantitative motion.

The reply accepts that new material parts are added, but maintains that the nature of the growing body transforms them into the form of the original parts. As these become assimilated, the original body continuously grows in quantity. Its successive magnitude is thereby a genuine connected quantitative development.

Motion in **position** is evident in a sphere revolving about its axis. The relation of the supposed points on its surface to the external surroundings changes gradually, producing successive positional states.

The traditional view denies motion in the remaining categories: acting, being acted upon, when, relation, having, and substance.

Motion is excluded from **acting** and **being acted upon** because gradation is already included in their meanings. They lack an instantaneous instance under which a further motion could be analysed into successive instantaneous determinations. A similar reason is given for **when**, a determination derived from relation to time, which is itself successive.

Relation is a derivative consideration dependent upon its terms, and therefore does not possess an independent motion of its own. **Having** likewise changes only as its subjects change—for example, through a change in the shoe or foot in the relation of wearing.

Finally, motion in **substance** is rejected on the ground that motion requires a stable subject remaining through its passage. If substance itself flowed, the traditional account would seem to leave no such persisting subject.

The author will reconsider this last exclusion in the following chapter.

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1. **Translator's note:** This chapter reports the classical restriction to four categories before introducing Ṣadrā's objection. Its rejection of substantial motion is not Tabāṭabāʾī's final position.
2. **Source:** Bidayat al-Hikma, supplied bilingual PDF (Arabic original) · p. 225 https://lib.rafed.net/m/?b_id=1571&type=c_fbook

CHAPTER 11

Further observations on the categories of motion

الفصل الحادي عشر في تعقيب ما مر في الفصل السابق

Ṣadr al-Mutaʾallihīn affirms motion in the category of substance and offers several arguments. The clearest, in the author's account, is that motion within the four accidental categories requires a corresponding motion in substance.

Accidents depend upon substances, as an action depends upon its agent. Bodily activities are attributable to natural powers and specific substantial forms, which are their proximate causes. But the proximate cause of motion must itself be successive and changing. Therefore the natures and substantial forms of bodies moving in quantity, quality, place, or position must also possess flowing, changing existences. Otherwise there could be no proximate cause for their accidental motions.

An objection asks how such changing substantial natures could themselves proceed from an immutable First Principle.

The reply is that when motion belongs to the very substance, renewal is intrinsic to that substance. What belongs to a thing intrinsically does not require an additional cause of its being thus. The agent causes the *renewed, flowing being* to exist; it does not first produce an independently static being and then cause that being to be renewed.

A second objection says that the same answer could be given for changing accidents without supposing a changing substance. Renewal would be intrinsic to an accident that is in motion, and a stable nature would cause that renewed accident without separately causing its renewal.

The reply is that accidents receive their existence through and depend upon substance. The intrinsic ground of the succession therefore must terminate in substantial being, not simply in a dependent accident.

A further objection notes that classical philosophers already offered another way to connect changing accidents to fixed natures: succession may arise through externally varying conditions. In natural movements, the changing relations of proximity and distance to the end could account for successive states. In forced movements, the varying circumstances contrary to the body's nature could do so. In animal and human movements, successive particular acts of will proceeding from the soul could supply the necessary variation.

The response asks in each case for the origin of those varying states and intentions. Their succession must itself be explained. Natural changes lead back to nature; forced movements likewise eventually depend upon natural causes; and in voluntary motion, the proximate bodily

agent moving the subject is again a natural power. The question of renewal cannot be escaped by replacing it with another series of unexplained changing conditions.

A further argument for substantial motion follows from the previous account of existence-for-another. An accident's existence in itself is the same as its existence for the substance in which it inheres: it is an existential determination of the substance's own actual being. Consequently, change and renewal in accidents is also change and renewal of substantial existence in the relevant respect.

Three conclusions follow.

First, specific substantial forms succeeding one another in matter are, in reality, the determinations of one continuously flowing substantial form. At successive limits of this flow the intellect abstracts distinct concepts, but the underlying existence is one continuous process. This accounts for change between natural forms. There is also a substantial *intensification*, a motion from prime matter through natural, vegetative, and animal levels towards human actuality.

Second, a substance moving in its own substantial existence moves with all its accidents. For the existential actuality of an accident is a degree or mode of the substance's existence. The familiar motions under the accidental categories are therefore, in one respect, motions within a more fundamental motion. These may be called *second movements*, while the motion belonging to accidents by dependence on substance, rather than by unrelated external attribution, can be regarded as primary in the relevant derivative analysis.

Third, the corporeal world with its common matter forms a single flowing reality, moving through its substances and accidents as one procession towards a fixed end identified with pure actuality.

The central claim is not that an already complete, unchanging quiddity acquires a second accidental motion. Rather, substantial existence itself is successive, while quiddity provides an intelligible description abstracted from its limits.

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1. **editorial synthesis of lecture notes:** The teaching notes give arguments and objections concerning substantial motion; use them after distinguishing motion in accidents from motion of substantial existence itself. (Krishnan, printed p. 177; attribution to the lecturer as mediated by the note-taker.)
2. **Philosophical note:** The distinction between the changing substantial existence and the quiddity abstracted from its phases is crucial. ‘The changing is intrinsic to its essence’ in this argument should be read with care: the text locates the flow in existential actuality rather than treating quiddity as a second continuously changing physical object.
3. **Comparative note:** The answer to the immutable-cause objection does not identify a First Cause with a temporally changing agent. It denies the need to add renewal as an accident to a separate static substance.
4. **Source:** Bidayat al-Hikma, supplied bilingual PDF (Arabic original) · p. 229 https://lib.rafed.net/m/?b_id=1571&type=c_fbook

CHAPTER 12

The subject and agent of substantial motion

الفصل الثاني عشر في موضوع الحركة الجوهرية وفاعلها

The philosophers who accept substantial motion have described its subject as matter actualised by one of the successive forms united through continuity and flow. The unity and individual identity of matter are preserved through ‘some form’ from among those succeeding one another.

Although the description ‘some form’ is indeterminate, the unity of the changing form is itself grounded in a separate substance, the agent which produces matter and preserves its unity and individuality by means of successive forms. Some form or other is thus a co-principle of the cause of matter; matter as actualised by such a form is the subject of motion.

Even philosophers who accepted generation and corruption but denied substantial motion gave a similar account: a form of some kind, sustained by a separate substance that produces matter through it, preserves matter's actuality and unity. The form serves as a co-principle of the cause of matter.

The more precise analysis is as follows. Why does movement require an enduring subject?

If the reason is to preserve the *unity of the movement*, so that its successive portions do not destroy its identity merely because they are not present together, then the intrinsic continuity of the movement suffices. Its division is a potential or intellectual division, not an actual disjunction between disconnected parts.

If the reason is instead that motion is a qualifying determination requiring something existent in itself which it qualifies—just as accidents and material substantial forms have subjects—then in accidental motion the subject is a substance distinct from the accidental motion. In *substantial motion*, however, the subject is the movement itself.

For by ‘subject of motion’ we mean the substantial actuality to which motion belongs. Where motion is itself the flowing existence of a substance, it is self-subsistent in the relevant substantial sense: it is motion and moving subject in one substantial reality. Its subjectivity is not an underlying static substrate numerically separate from its motion.

We may still attribute the role of subject to the matter traversed by successive forms, in view of the unity of matter and form in the composite. But prime matter in itself is devoid of independent actuality and cannot serve as the full intrinsically actual subject of the movement.

Thus the continuity of flowing substance, not the immutability of a distinct underlying material thing, secures the identity of substantial motion.

1. **Translator's note:** The distinction between unity of motion and the subject as the being qualified by motion answers two different demands for a ‘persistent subject’. In the decisive case the subject of substantial motion is the moving substantial existence itself.
2. **Philosophical note:** This is the key locus for comparing the Sadrian unification of substantial actuality and motion with the Aristotelian hylomorphic analysis. It does not imply that prime matter has an independent act of existence.
3. **Source:** Bidayat al-Hikma, supplied bilingual PDF (Arabic original) · p. 233 https://lib.rafed.net/m/?b_id=1571&type=c_fbook

CHAPTER 13

Time

الفصل الثالث عشر في الزمان

We find events falling under motion divisible into successive portions, no one of which coexists in full actuality with another. The second portion becomes actual only after the first portion's actuality has passed away. Each supposed portion admits further division of the same kind, and so on without limit.

This requires an extension of quantity accompanying motion, through which motion is measured and divided. The quantitative extension is not identical with motion's own indeterminate flowing reality. It is a *determinate* extension, just as the mathematical body provides determinate three-dimensional magnitude to the indeterminate corporeal extension of natural body.

This extension determining the magnitude of motion is therefore a continuous quantity inhering in motion. Unlike mathematical bodily magnitude, however, it is not a coexisting quantity: its supposed parts cannot be present simultaneously.

This is *time* (zamān), the measure of motion. Each of its parts precedes another insofar as the latter depends upon the earlier part's passing, while it follows whatever earlier part it itself presupposes. The boundary obtained by dividing time is the *instant* (ān).

Several consequences follow. First, every motion has its own time, the measure of that motion. People nevertheless measure motions in common by a conventional general time based historically on the familiar daily revolution, dividing this common measure into centuries, years, months, weeks, days, hours, minutes, seconds, and other units. For philosophers who affirm substantial motion, the time fundamentally involved in temporal events is the time belonging to substantial motion.

Second, priority and posteriority are intrinsic to the parts of time. The very non-coexisting and flowing nature of time requires that the actuality of one supposed portion depends upon the passing of another. The portion whose passing is presupposed is prior, the dependent later portion posterior.

Third, the instant, as the boundary separating two supposed portions of time, has no independent positive existence as a portion of duration. Division of continuous time is conceptual or potential, not an actual separation of independently existing pieces.

Fourth, two or more instants cannot succeed one another with no intervening portion of time: that would require an adjacency of empty boundaries without duration. The same applies to instantaneous occurrences mapped onto such boundaries, including contact and separation.

Fifth, time has no first or last *indivisible temporal part*, for divisibility belongs to its nature. This does not by itself settle the separate cosmological question of a beginning of the temporal world in some other sense.

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1. **Terminology:** Time as a non-coexisting measure of motion must be distinguished from an instant as the boundary of its potential divisions. The historical measure of daily revolution is conventional, whereas the philosophical account ties time to the flowing existence of movement.
2. **Source:** Bidayat al-Hikma, supplied bilingual PDF (Arabic original) · p. 235 https://lib.rafed.net/m/?b_id=1571&type=c_fbook

CHAPTER 14

Speed and slowness

الفصل الرابع عشر في السرعة والبطؤ

Consider two movements in relation to one another. If they take equal amounts of time, the one traversing more distance is faster. If they traverse equal distances, the one taking less time is faster. Thus speed consists in traversing a greater distance in a shorter time; slowness is its opposite.

Slowness is not motion interrupted by intervals of rest, such that the more rests are interposed, the slower the motion. Motion is a continuous intermingling of potentiality and actuality, and its nature does not allow such resting intervals to become constituent parts of it.

Some philosophers hold that speed and slowness are *contraries*. Both are positive, and their opposition does not appear to be contradiction, privation and possession, or simple correlation; hence they are classified as contraries.

The author rejects this conclusion, since contraries must exhibit the maximal possible opposition within a genus. There is no final fastest motion or slowest motion in the required comparative order: for any supposed fast movement one can conceive a faster, and for a slow movement a slower.

Speed and slowness are therefore *relative descriptions*. A movement fast in relation to one may be slow in relation to a third. Motion as flowing or succession is the underlying reality; as different motions possess more or less intensity, their comparisons give rise to the relative descriptions ‘fast’

and ‘slow’.

1. **Translator's note:** The analysis concerns speed and slowness as comparative philosophical predicates and should not be confused with the empirical question of upper bounds on physical signal propagation.
2. **Source:** Bidayat al-Hikma, supplied bilingual PDF (Arabic original) · p. 239 https://lib.rafed.net/m/?b_id=1571&type=c_fbook

CHAPTER 15

Rest

الفصل الخامس عشر في السكون

The term *rest* (sukūn) may signify a body's absence of motion before or after movement, or the body's remaining fixed in its present condition. The first is what formally opposes motion, while the second follows from it.

Rest is privative: it is the absence of motion in a subject capable of moving, namely body. Its opposition to motion is therefore the opposition of possession and privation rather than strict contradiction.

In the author's account almost no corporeal thing is wholly without motion except what exists instantaneously, such as arriving at a particular limit of a trajectory, the separation of one thing from another, or the production of geometrical boundaries and comparable instantaneous determinations.

1. **Terminological note:** Rest is not defined as absolute immutability of being. It is privation of motion in a subject naturally receptive to motion.
2. **Source:** Bidayat al-Hikma, supplied bilingual PDF (Arabic original) · p. 241 https://lib.rafed.net/m/?b_id=1571&type=c_fbook

CHAPTER 16

Divisions of motion

الفصل السادس عشر في انقسامات الحركة

Motion is divided according to the six matters upon which its identity depends.

It differs by **origin and terminus**, as movement from one place to another, from one colour to another, or a plant's growth from one magnitude to another. It differs by **subject**, as movement of a plant, animal, or human. It differs by **category**, as qualitative, quantitative, or positional motion. It differs by **time**, as nocturnal or diurnal, summer or winter motion. It differs also by **agent**, as natural, forced, or voluntary motion; accidental motion is related to these divisions in another manner.

The agent may possess awareness and will concerning the activity, in which case it is a psychic agent and the motion voluntary, as with the movements of humans and animals. Otherwise, the motion may issue from the thing's own nature when unimpeded, in which case the agent and motion are *natural*; or it may occur through another agent's constraint contrary to the body's nature, in which case the motion is *forced*, as with a stone thrown upwards.

The philosophers maintain that the immediate agent in all three classes is the moving body's own nature: it may be subordinated to psychic direction, operate in accordance with its natural disposition, or be constrained by a forcing nature. Between the agent and the actual motion stands a principle of *inclination* (mayl) produced in the moving body's nature. The physical discussion of this is treated in natural philosophy.

A further clarification concerns the word *potency* or *power* (quwwa). As it can mean receptivity, it can also denote an intense capacity to act. It can name the receptive principle or the active principle, as when one speaks of psychic powers—sight, hearing, imagination, and the like—or natural powers producing physical effects.

When such an active power is accompanied by knowledge and will, it is called *animal power* or *capacity* (qudra). As an efficient causal principle, it requires additional conditions before becoming a complete cause: suitable receptive matter, operative instruments, and other necessities. When these conditions are present together, the complete cause determines the act.

Three consequences follow.

First, the familiar definition of power as ‘that with which either acting or refraining is possible’ is not adequate without qualification. Acting and refraining are alternatives for an agent insofar as its power is only one constituent of a complete cause. The agent's power alone does not necessitate action; the other conditions are still required. But an agent possessing complete and unrestricted causality, such as the Necessary Existent, does not stand in a state of undetermined possibility with respect to its action.

That the act is necessary when its complete cause is present does not mean that the agent is compelled or deprived of power. The necessity arises from the agent's own complete efficacy; it does not force the agent from outside or presuppose another agent acting upon it to constrain it.

Second, the claim that an action is possible only if preceded by temporal non-existence is false. It follows from the mistaken thesis that the ground of causal need is temporal origination rather than contingency, already refuted. The claim would also encounter the difficulty of time itself, for which a prior temporal absence cannot simply be posited without presupposing time.

Third, the claim that power arises only together with the action, so that there is no power to act before actually acting, is likewise rejected. If a person is able either to act or to refrain, and refrains for an interval before acting, that ability is truly attributable to the person during the preceding interval, even when the action does not yet occur.

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1. **Translator's note:** This final chapter distinguishes an active principle from a complete efficient cause. The rejection of ‘power means possible action or omission’ is directed against an unqualified definition of complete divine agency, not against the ordinary human capacity to act or refrain.
2. **Terminology:** Mayl in this classical analysis is the mediating inclination of the moving nature. It is not the same term as power (quwwa) or informed capacity (qudra).
3. **Source:** Bidayat al-Hikma, supplied bilingual PDF (Arabic original) · p. 243 https://lib.rafed.net/m/?b_id=1571&type=c_fbook

STAGE XI

Knowledge, the Knower, and the Known

العلم والعالم والمعلوم

CHAPTER 1

Knowledge: its definition and first division

الفصل الأول في تعريف العلم وانقسامه الأولى

That knowledge occurs in us is immediately evident, as is our general understanding of its meaning. The present inquiry therefore seeks the most characteristic properties of knowledge so that its instances and distinctions may be recognised.

As established in the discussion of mental existence, we have knowledge of things outside ourselves when their *quiddities* become present to us, not through the extramental existences by which their characteristic effects occur. This is one kind of knowledge, called *acquired knowledge* or knowledge by representation (ʿilm ḥuṣūlī).

Another kind is a person's knowledge of the very self indicated by ‘I’. One is not wholly unaware of oneself in any circumstance—whether in solitude or company, sleep or wakefulness, or other conditions of life. This knowledge is not the conceptual presence of the quiddity of the self as an acquired mental form. A concept, however determinate, is in itself capable of application to many instances, and becomes a particular only by individual existence. But the self immediately present as ‘I’ is individuated in itself and cannot be shared by many. Individuation is a feature of actuality. Our knowledge of our own selves must therefore be through their own existing actuality, which is the ground of individuality and effects. This is called *knowledge by presence* (ʿilm ḥuḍūrī).

These two kinds exhaust the modes of knowledge: the known becomes present to the knower either through its quiddity or through its own existence. The former is acquired knowledge, the latter knowledge by presence.

The occurrence of knowledge for a knower means the occurrence of the *immediately known* for it. For knowledge is identical with the immediately known, since we mean by knowledge nothing but the presence of what is known. A thing's presence is its mode of existence.

The presence of the known to the knower therefore entails a kind of *union* (ittiḥād) between them. If the known by presence is a self-subsisting substance, then its being for itself is also present for the knower, so that the knower is united with it in the relevant respect. If the known is a form or accident whose existence is for its subject, then its presence to the knower entails a relation of union between the knower and that subject, for an accident's existence is a mode of its subject's existence, not something independently severed from it. The same reasoning extends to acquired knowledge, whether the intelligible content signifies a substance or an accident: the form exists for the knower, and this entails its union with the knower. As will be argued later, acquired knowledge is in reality grounded in knowledge by presence.

Not every occurrence of something in something else is, however, cognitive presence. The known, as known, must be fully actual in the relevant respect, without unrealised potency: experience shows that what is immediately present as an object of knowledge is not, precisely as known, merely the potentiality to become another known object, nor is it changed in its very actuality as that cognitive content.

Such actuality requires freedom from matter, for matter and potency involve incompleteness with respect to unrealised perfections. The knower too must have sufficient actuality to receive the known's presence without being merely an unrealised material potential.

Knowledge is consequently the *presence of an immaterial existent to an immaterial existent*, whether the known is identical with the knower, as in self-knowledge, or distinct in some respect, as in the knowledge of other quiddities.

Two consequences follow: the immediately known must be immaterial in the relevant cognitive mode, and the knower receiving it must likewise be immaterial. How we know material things will be explained subsequently.

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1. **editorial synthesis of lecture notes:** Knowledge by presence (ʿilm ḥuḍūrī) is contrasted with acquired/representational knowledge (ʿilm ḥuṣūlī). ‘Acquired’ does not merely mean learnt in a classroom. (Krishnan, printed p. 194; attribution to the lecturer as mediated by the note-taker.)
2. **Terminology:** The distinction ʿilm ḥuṣūlī / ʿilm ḥuḍūrī is between knowledge through a quiddative form and knowledge through an existent's immediate presence. The text later argues that the former itself presupposes the latter.
3. **Philosophical note:** The union of knower and known is an existential thesis within this philosophical tradition; it should not be mistaken for an identity of every knowing person with every extramental object.
4. **Source:** Bidayat al-Hikma, supplied bilingual PDF (Arabic original) · p. 248 https://lib.rafed.net/m/?b_id=1571&type=c_fbook

CHAPTER 2

Universal and particular acquired knowledge

الفصل الثاني ينقسم العلم الحصولي إلى كلي وجزئي

Acquired knowledge is divided first into *universal* and *particular*.

Universal knowledge is that whose content does not prevent its application to many, as with knowledge of the quiddity ‘human’. This is called intellection (*taʿaqqul*).

Particular knowledge is that whose content is taken as inapplicable to many. It includes sensory awareness of this human being while the subject is connected through the sense organs with the corresponding material individual, and imaginative knowledge of that individual when the material thing is no longer present. These are sensory and imaginal cognition respectively.

Their status as particular is due to the connection of the sensory organs with an external object, and to imagination's dependence upon earlier sensory cognition. The mental form considered simply in itself does not, as a form, exclude application to more than one.

Both particular cognitive forms are immaterial in the relevant sense, for an intelligible form is actual as known and does not itself undergo material alteration. Moreover, mental contents, just insofar as they signify what they signify, admit predication of many, whereas a particular material existent is individuated and cannot be numerically shared.

Were sensory and imaginative forms merely impressed in bodily parts, they would be divisible with their physical substrates, confined to place and time, and altered with them. Yet a cognitive content as such is not divided into bodily segments or pointed to as a located object. The same sensible form may be recalled long afterwards without its content having changed simply because time has passed. The temporal circumstances associated with cognition therefore belong to its preparatory conditions, not to the known form under the aspect of knowledge.

The sense organs and imagination provide the dispositions by which the soul becomes capable of presenting these forms to itself; the detailed explanation belongs to psychology.

The customary description that intellection ‘strips’ the object of matter and individuating accidents while sensory knowledge retains both matter and individuating features, and imagination retains individuating features without the material subject, should be understood as a pedagogical illustration. Even the sensed form, as known, has an immaterial mode. Material presence and individuating features prepare the soul for sensation; retained features prepare it for imagination; comparing and retaining several individuals prepares the soul for the universal concept, customarily described as abstracting the universal from particulars.

From this there emerges a threefold division of existence with respect to freedom from matter.

First is the world of matter and potentiality. **Second** is the *imaginal world* (ʿālam al-mithāl), free from matter as receptive potency but retaining features associated with material reality—figure, magnitude, position, and the like—without a material substrate. This is the intermediate or *barzakh* world between intellect and matter. **Third** is the intellectual world, free both from matter and from the characteristics of material forms.

The imaginal world is further distinguished into the *greater imaginal realm*, subsisting in its own order, and the *lesser imaginal realm*, associated with the soul and subject to its imaginative activity. The soul may produce true and fitting images or arbitrary and fanciful images according to its motives.

These three worlds are hierarchically ordered. The highest, strongest in existence and nearest the First Principle, is the world of separate intellects, wholly actual and free from matter and potency. Below it is the imaginal world, free from matter but retaining its formal effects. Below that is the material world, the locus of privation and deficiency. Material things become objects of knowledge through their intelligible or imaginal correspondents.

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1. **Translator's note:** The distinction between sensory and imaginative particular cognition concerns how the object is encountered. The author denies that its immediately known form, precisely as known, is simply a physical imprint.
2. **Comparative note:** The ‘greater’ and ‘lesser’ imaginal realms should not be conflated with a psychological image alone. The ontology invoked is wider than a contemporary account of visual imagination.
3. **Source:** Bidayat al-Hikma, supplied bilingual PDF (Arabic original) · p. 252 https://lib.rafed.net/m/?b_id=1571&type=c_fbook

CHAPTER 3

A second division into universal and particular

الفصل الثالث ينقسم العلم انقساما آخر إلى كلي وجزئي

Another division into universal and particular knowledge is based not on possible predication of many but on whether the cognition changes as the thing known accidentally changes.

Here *universal knowledge* is a form that does not change when the externally known object changes. The architect's conception of a house, for example, may remain the same before the house is built, during construction, after completion, and even after it is demolished. This is knowledge *before multiplicity*. Knowledge reached through causes is universal in this sense: the astronomer's knowledge that an eclipse will occur at a specified time remains unchanged before, during, and after the event, insofar as its causal description is the same.

Particular knowledge is knowledge that changes with a change in the object known accidentally. When we see Zayd moving and then he stops, our sensory cognition shifts from motion to rest. This is knowledge *after multiplicity*.

An objection argues that any such change requires a prior potency borne by matter; therefore particular knowledge would be material rather than immaterial.

The answer distinguishes *knowledge of change* from *change of knowledge*. What is known as changing is apprehended under the stable aspect through which the changing object is present to the knower. The immediately known content is present as that cognitive actuality. Were it itself absent whenever the object changed, there would be no presence of something to something and thus no knowledge in the sense established.

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1. **Terminological note:** The present universal/particular distinction differs from the preceding one. ‘Universal’ here means invariant with respect to a known thing's externally changing phases, not simply predicable of multiple instances.
2. **Source:** Bidayat al-Hikma, supplied bilingual PDF (Arabic original) · p. 256 https://lib.rafed.net/m/?b_id=1571&type=c_fbook

CHAPTER 4

Types of intellection

الفصل الرابع في أنواع التعقل

Intellection is distinguished into three kinds.

First, intellect may be wholly potential: no intelligible is present in actuality, and the soul lacks acquired intelligibles.

Second, intellect may possess one or many intelligibles in actuality and distinguish them from one another in a definite order. This is *detailed intellection* (ʿaql tafṣīlī).

Third, intellect may possess many intelligibles in actuality without explicitly distinguishing and arranging each separately. This is a *simple general intellection* in which all the details are included, called *summary intellection* (ʿaql ijmālī).

An example is offered. Someone asks a series of questions about matters you already know. At the first instant of beginning to answer, you possess the answers together in a certain actual, confident knowledge, though you have not yet distinguished and unfolded each answer individually. The details become explicit through answering, as if flowing from a source that already contained them.

Thus a general intellectual actuality can be prior to its articulated, detailed expression without being merely a complete absence of knowledge.

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1. **Translator's note:** Ijmālī here does not mean vague ignorance. It is the intellect's actual but not separately articulated possession of the detailed contents.
2. **Source:** Bidayat al-Hikma, supplied bilingual PDF (Arabic original) · p. 258 https://lib.rafed.net/m/?b_id=1571&type=c_fbook

CHAPTER 5

Degrees of the intellect

الفصل الخامس في مراتب العقل

The philosophers enumerate four degrees of intellect.

First, the intellect as potential with respect to all intelligibles, called the *material intellect* (ʿaql hayūlānī). The name is an analogy: just as prime matter is potential for substantial forms, the intellect at this rank is not yet actualised by intelligible forms.

Second, the *intellect in habitu* or *intellect by disposition* (ʿaql bi-l-malaka). At this rank the intellect possesses the self-evident objects of conception and assent, which precede acquired theoretical judgments.

Third, the *actual intellect* (ʿaql bi-l-fiʿl), whose theoretical knowledge is obtained through the mediation of self-evident truths, even when its various demonstrations require further ordering.

Fourth, the intellect which actually calls to presence all the intelligibles it has acquired—immediate and discursive—and comprehends, through correct forms, the truths of the higher and lower world. It becomes, as it were, an intelligible world corresponding to the world of external being. This is called the *acquired intellect* (ʿaql mustafād).

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1. **Terminological note:** ‘Material intellect’ names an initial receptivity by analogy to hylē, not a claim that intellection is performed by a material organ.
2. **Source:** Bidayat al-Hikma, supplied bilingual PDF (Arabic original) · p. 260 https://lib.rafed.net/m/?b_id=1571&type=c_fbook

CHAPTER 6

The source of intelligible forms

الفصل السادس في مفيض هذه الصور العلمية

The source of universal intelligible forms that brings the human intellect from potentiality to actuality is a *separate intellect* free of matter, in which universal intelligibles are present.

The proof begins from the immateriality of intellectual cognition. These forms are free of matter as forms known, and their universality permits their being predicated of many. Anything inhering materially in a particular subject is an individual and cannot be numerically shared in this way. The intellectual form therefore possesses an immaterial mode of existence.

Its productive cause must accordingly be immaterial. A material existent has a weaker mode of existence and cannot, in the author's account, produce an effect more actual than itself. Moreover, material agency depends upon particular spatial dispositions, whereas an immaterial form as such

has no position.

The cause of these intelligibles cannot be the human soul precisely insofar as it remains potential towards them. In that state its role is receptive, not productive; what is potential cannot by that very potentiality actualise itself.

The cause is therefore a separate intellectual substance possessing intelligibles in the mode of the summary intellectual knowledge described above. The human soul, as it becomes suitably disposed, is united with that intellect to the degree of its preparedness, receiving the intelligible forms for which it is ready.

An analogous argument establishes a source for particular imaginal forms: a separate immaterial imaginal substance possessing these forms in an undifferentiated mode, with which the soul is united according to its degree of preparedness.

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1. **Philosophical note:** The separate intellect as source of intelligibles and the soul's graded union with it are theses of this post-Avicennian metaphysical psychology, not claims established directly by contemporary cognitive science.
2. **Source:** Bidayat al-Hikma, supplied bilingual PDF (Arabic original) · p. 262 https://lib.rafed.net/m/?b_id=1571&type=c_fbook

CHAPTER 7

Conception and assent

الفصل السابع ينقسم العلم الحصولي إلى تصور وتصديق

Acquired knowledge is divided into **conception** (*taṣawwur*) and **assent** (*taṣdīq*).

Conception is the cognitive form of one or several objects without affirmation or negation, as when we conceive human being, body, or substance. Assent is a cognition accompanied by affirming something of something or denying something of something, as in ‘The human is capable of laughter’ and ‘The human is not a stone’. Considered as making a judgment, assent is a *proposition* (*qaḍiyya*).

A proposition, insofar as it affirms or denies something, contains more than one intelligible element. The prevailing view counts four components of an affirmative composite proposition: subject, predicate, the predicative relation joining them, and the judgment that they are united. In a simple existential proposition such as ‘The human exists’, it counts three: subject, predicate, and judgment, because there is no meaning in introducing a further connective between a thing and its own existence.

The prevailing account of a negative proposition includes subject, predicate, and an affirmative predicative relation but no affirmative judgment. This does not mean that negation introduces a positive ‘negative judgment’ as a new entity. Judgment is a putting-together or identifying of the predicate with the subject; removing judgment is not equivalent to positively producing a thing called its absence.

The more accurate view is that the mind needs to *conceive* a predicative relation in performing the act of judging, not because this relation must occur as a separate constituent of every completed proposition. The proposition as proposition consists of subject, predicate, and judgment. A conceived relation assists the soul in making subject and predicate one in judgment, but the simple existential proposition shows that a proposition can be formed without a separate linking relation.

Thus the affirmative proposition has three constituents—subject, predicate, and judgment—while the negative proposition has subject and predicate without the act of affirmative predication. The relation conceived between them is required for the soul's act of judging, but is not an additional constituent of the proposition's completed signification in every case.

Judgment, moreover, is an **act of the soul** in cognitive experience; it is not merely a passive reception of a further mental picture. When we perceive Zayd standing, sensation presents one existent, Zayd-as-standing. The soul then distinguishes in thought the concepts ‘Zayd’ and ‘standing’ and retains them. To express the external state of affairs, it takes these two concepts and makes them one under a single existential predication. This synthesising activity is judgment; the soul thereby represents the external fact as it is.

Judgment is therefore an act of the soul while also bearing a cognitive significance referring beyond itself. If it were only another concept taken from the external world, an assertoric sentence would not yield the distinctive cognition that completes a judgment, just as merely entertaining the antecedent or consequent of a conditional does not assert either. If it were a concept produced by the soul without reference to external reality, it would not genuinely represent what is outside it.

Finally, assent presupposes conception of subject and predicate. There is no assent without the conceptual apprehension of what is affirmed or denied.

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1. **Translator's note:** The author distinguishes the completed proposition from the soul's cognitive act of synthesising subject and predicate. The account of negative judgment denies a separate positive entity called ‘a negative act of predication’.
2. **Source:** Bidayat al-Hikma, supplied bilingual PDF (Arabic original) · p. 264 https://lib.rafed.net/m/?b_id=1571&type=c_fbook

CHAPTER 8

Immediate and discursive knowledge

الفصل الثامن وينقسم العلم الحصولي إلى بديهي ونظري

Acquired cognition is also divided into **immediate or self-evident** (*badīhī*) and **discursive** (*naẓarī*).

An immediate conception or assent does not require study or an inferential process, as in the concepts ‘thing’ and ‘unity’ or the judgments that the whole is greater than its part and that four is even. Discursive cognition depends upon intellectual effort and inquiry, as with the conceptual account of the human being or the horse, or demonstrations that the angles of a triangle equal two right angles and that the human has an immaterial soul.

Discursive sciences ultimately depend upon immediate cognitions by which their conclusions are established. Otherwise the series of demonstrations would recede without end and could never yield knowledge, as explained in logic.

The self-evident truths are many. The most fundamental are **primary propositions**, for which conceiving the subject and predicate suffices for assent, such as ‘The whole is greater than its part’ and ‘A thing cannot be denied of itself’.

The most fundamental of all is that contradictories cannot both obtain nor both fail to obtain. It is a genuine exclusive alternative: either the affirmation or its negation is true. Every immediate or discursive assertion depends on it. ‘The whole is greater than its part’ conveys knowledge only if its contradictory, ‘The whole is not greater than its part’, is false. Hence the law of contradiction is called the *first of first principles*. If it were doubtful, doubt would spread to every judgment.

A **sophist** who denies all knowledge cannot concede this first principle, for admitting that one of a pair of contradictories is true would admit some knowledge. Consider one who claims to know nothing and to doubt everything.

If he acknowledges knowing that he doubts, he has admitted a piece of knowledge and thereby an instance of the first principle. One can then confront him with comparable cases of self-awareness: knowing that he sees, hears, touches, tastes, smells, or experiences hunger and thirst and seeks the means to satisfy them. Admitting these provides a starting point for further cognition, because theoretical knowledge is ultimately connected with sensory experience.

If, instead, he denies even knowing that he doubts and professes doubt about his doubting, argument with him has no shared premise and proof cannot gain a foothold. The author here uses unusually harsh polemical language: if this stems from a disorder of perception, he says the person should seek medical care; if it is wilful hostility to truth, he proposes painful physical treatment,

deprivation of desired things, and imposition of disliked things, on the assumption that the sceptic denies their reality. This is recorded as part of the historical text, not adopted as a legitimate method of philosophical discussion.

Other sceptics may have arrived at their position through encountering disagreements in philosophical studies without adequate training in logic or demonstration. Unable to distinguish sound from unsound arguments, they may have accepted contradictory positions and concluded that science is merely relative to each reasoner's perspective. The author recommends training in logical laws, explicit attention to indisputable primary propositions such as a thing's identity with itself, careful analysis of the meanings of propositions, and study of mathematics.

Two further sceptical positions are distinguished. Some accept human beings and their cognitions but doubt everything beyond them, saying ‘We and our perceptions are certain; what lies beyond is uncertain’. Others notice that this already affirms multiple external human beings and their perceptions and restrict the concession to ‘I and my perceptions’.

The author replies that our perceptions can be mistaken—as in errors of vision, touch, or thinking. The very distinction between veridical perception and error would be unintelligible if there were no realities outside our acts of awareness to which those acts could either correspond or fail to correspond.

A further response to the sceptic suggests that what seems sceptical might merely claim that the qualities presented by senses do not resemble external reality exactly. For example, what hearing presents as sound may correspond outside sensation to vibrations of a particular frequency, and light or colour may correspond to physical disturbances different from their sensible appearance. The senses therefore do not simply reveal the extra-mental nature of things as they appear, and other cognitions are said to depend on them.

The author responds that if cognition provided no disclosure of what lies beyond it, we could not know even that there is an external reality differing from appearances. How could someone discover that external sound corresponds to a certain pattern of vibration except by relying upon human cognition? How could sensory errors be corrected except through other cognitive operations?

To admit that *all* cognitions might fail to signify anything beyond themselves would therefore, he concludes, return to the universal scepticism under examination. Even the thesis ‘None of our cognitions may correspond to external reality’ would have no secure claim to express its own meaning if every conceptual and propositional act could fail to signify what it purports to mean.

1. **Historical-critical note:** The original includes a recommendation to strike or painfully coerce an incorrigible sceptic. It is reproduced here descriptively for textual fidelity; coercion is not a legitimate substitute for rational or clinical discussion.
2. **Epistemological note:** The argument against complete scepticism depends upon a distinction between ordinary fallible representation and the sweeping claim that no cognition can disclose any reality beyond itself. The author does not deny that science revises sensory appearances.
3. **Source:** Bidayat al-Hikma, supplied bilingual PDF (Arabic original) · p. 268 https://lib.rafed.net/m/?b_id=1571&type=c_fbook

CHAPTER 9

Real and considered knowledge

الفصل التاسع وينقسم العلم الحصولي إلى حقيقي واعتباري

Acquired knowledge can also be divided into **real** and **considered** concepts.

A *real* concept is the quiddity that exists at one time outside the mind, where its characteristic effects follow, and at another time mentally, where those effects do not follow.

A *considered* or *intellectually abstracted* concept is not of this kind. Such concepts fall into two broad groups. Some have instances whose proper mode is to exist outside the mind, such as existence and the real characteristics of existence, including unity and actuality. They do not enter the mind under that same mode of actuality without ceasing to be what they were. Others are concepts whose proper instances exist only in the mind, such as universal, genus, and species in their logical senses. They cannot exist outside the mind under that mode without a corresponding change of status.

The intellect forms these concepts through its own consideration and predicates them of appropriate instances. But they are not predicated in the same way as a quiddity that enters into the essential definition of its external individuals.

Three consequences follow. First, any concept predicated both of the Necessary Existent and of contingent beings—such as existence or life—must be considered in this broad philosophical manner. Otherwise the Necessary Existent would fall under a shared quiddity, whereas He has no quiddity in the relevant sense.

Second, a concept predicated across more than one of the ten categories, such as motion, is likewise considered rather than one categorial essence. Were it itself a shared quiddity, a thing would be classified under several highest genera.

Third, considered philosophical concepts do not possess essential definitions (*ḥudūd*) and are not inserted as constitutive parts of the definition of a quiddity.

The term *iʿtibārī* has further meanings outside this discussion. It may denote what is derivative rather than primary, as quiddity relative to existence. It may denote what lacks separate existence, such as relation whose being is in its terms, as opposed to substance. Or it may name practical concepts attributed to subjects by analogy for a useful purpose: a leader may be called ‘the head’ of a group because his organising role resembles that of a bodily head.

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1. **editorial synthesis of lecture notes:** The treatment of iʿtibārī is especially important: intellectual consideration, derivative ontological standing, and practical conventions should not all be translated as ‘imaginary’. (Krishnan, printed p. 217; attribution to the lecturer as mediated by the note-taker.)
2. **Terminology:** Iʿtibārī must be interpreted by context: derivative ontological status, intellectual abstraction, non-independent existence, and practical convention are not synonymous.
3. **Source:** Bidayat al-Hikma, supplied bilingual PDF (Arabic original) · p. 274 https://lib.rafed.net/m/?b_id=1571&type=c_fbook

CHAPTER 10

Additional properties of knowledge

الفصل العاشر في أحكام متفرقة

Several additional properties of knowledge should be noted.

First, what is known through acquired knowledge is divided into the **immediately known** (*maʿlūm bi-l-dhāt*) and the **known by attribution** (*maʿlūm bi-l-ʿaraḍ*). The first is the cognitive form present in itself to the knower. The second is the external object which that form represents, called known by attribution or figuratively because its quiddative significance is shared with the immediate form.

Second, both what intellect knows and the intellective knower are immaterial. The concepts which become present to the rational soul and actualise it are therefore immaterial existents. The author argues that, as such, they possess a mode of being more actual than the receptive soul which is perfected through them, and that their proper effects follow from their own actuality.

These forms are thus, in reality, immaterial existents becoming present to the knowing soul in their proper being. The soul is united with them when the cognised forms signify substantial realities, or with the substances qualified by them when they are accidents.

But because our cognition is ordinarily connected with matter through sense instruments, we imagine these forms merely as shapes abstracted from the material objects, stripped of the effects they have within material existence and thus reduced to mental existents without those effects.

It follows, in the author's system, that acquired knowledge is ultimately a form of **knowledge by presence**: an immaterial form is present to an immaterial knower.

It also follows that intellects wholly separate from matter in both essence and activity do not possess acquired knowledge in the ordinary representational sense. Their cognition is by presence, not through a material acquisition of forms.

1. **Philosophical note:** The claim that knowledge by representation is grounded in knowledge by presence belongs to the author's ontology of intelligible forms and union; it should not be paraphrased as a simple denial of cognition through representation.
2. **Source:** Bidayat al-Hikma, supplied bilingual PDF (Arabic original) · p. 276 https://lib.rafed.net/m/?b_id=1571&type=c_fbook

CHAPTER 11

Every immaterial being is intellective

الفصل الحادي عشر كل مجرد فهو عاقل

Every immaterial substance is intellective. For an immaterial existent is complete in its own actuality and not constituted through potentiality. Its complete essence is present to itself and exists for itself. Knowledge has been defined as the presence of one existent to another in the specified sense; the immaterial therefore knows itself by presence.

As for its knowledge of others, because it is fully actual it can apprehend every complete intelligible nature capable of being known by it. Whatever belongs to such a completely immaterial being in the relevant order as possible is, in that order, already actual. It is thus an actual knower of fully actual immaterial existents. Correspondingly, every immaterial existent is actually intelligible and, as an intellectual reality, intellective.

An objection arises: if the human soul is immaterial, this would make it an actual knower of every intelligible, contrary to experience.

The author concedes the conclusion in a qualified sense. The human soul is immaterial *in essence* but not wholly immaterial *in operation*. Its essential immateriality allows it to know itself immediately, but its involvement with bodily activity means that other cognitions are attained by successive transitions from potentiality to actuality, according to differing dispositions.

When the soul is wholly separate from bodily administration and fully immaterial in its operation, all intelligibles become present to it in summary intellectual knowledge. It reaches the rank of actual acquired intellect.

This demonstration concerns immaterial **substantial** existents whose being is for themselves. It does not apply indiscriminately to their accidents, whose existence is for another; the knowing subjects of those accidents are the substances in which they inhere.

1. **Translator's note:** The qualification ‘substantial’ is essential: it prevents the argument from making an accidental immaterial quality an independent self-knowing subject.

2. **Source:** Bidayat al-Hikma, supplied bilingual PDF (Arabic original) · p. 278 https://lib.rafed.net/m/?b_id=1571&type=c_fbook

CHAPTER 12

Knowledge by presence beyond self-knowledge

الفصل الثاني عشر في العلم الحضوري وأنه لا يختص بعلم الشيء بنفسه

We have established that immaterial substances, by reason of their complete actuality, are present to themselves and know themselves by presence.

Does knowledge by presence concern only a thing's self-knowledge, or does it also include a cause's knowledge of its effect and an effect's knowledge of its cause, when both are immaterial? The Peripatetics are reported as holding the former view and the Illuminationists the latter. The author adopts the broader Illuminationist view.

For the effect's existence is, as explained earlier, linking existence: it is established through its cause and not independent of it. When both cause and effect are immaterial, the effect is present by its entire actuality to the cause, with no material impediment between them. The cause knows the effect by presence through the effect's very existence.

Likewise, the cause is present in its actuality to an immaterial effect that exists through and depends upon it, without a material barrier. The cause is therefore known by presence to the effect. The scope of knowledge by presence extends beyond self-knowledge in both directions of immaterial causal dependence.

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1. **Philosophical note:** The bidirectional knowledge-by-presence claim is grounded in immaterial causal dependence, not in a mere formal relation between two arbitrary concepts. It is explicitly attributed here to the broader Illuminationist position.
2. **Source:** Bidayat al-Hikma, supplied bilingual PDF (Arabic original) · p. 280 https://lib.rafed.net/m/?b_id=1571&type=c_fbook

STAGE XII

The Necessary Existent

ما يتعلق بالواجب تعالى

CHAPTER 1

Demonstrating the existence of the Necessary Existent

الفصل الأول في إثبات ذاته تعالى

The reality of existence is primary: nothing other than it possesses independent originality. It is pure, with no alien reality mixed into it, for any alleged independent ‘other’ was shown to be without actuality. It has no second alongside it, as established in the first stage.

This pure reality of existence is necessary. A thing necessarily possesses its own actuality, and its contradictory, non-existence, cannot be predicated of it in the same respect. Its necessity must be either in itself or through another. But to suppose that it receives necessity through another contradicts the purity of existence, for there is no independently actual other beside it. Therefore the pure reality of existence is the Necessary Existent in Himself.

There is also a proof from contingent beings. Contingent quiddities are found actually existing; by the principle that a thing does not exist until its existence is necessary, they are necessary through another. Were they necessary in themselves they would not require causes. Their determining causes likewise exist and are either necessary through themselves or through another. Because causal circularity and an infinite regress of existentially dependent causes are impossible, the series must terminate in an intrinsically Necessary Existent.

1. **editorial synthesis of lecture notes:** The final theological discussion should be read as depending on the earlier treatments of contingency, necessity and causation; do not present it as independent of the metaphysical demonstrations. (Krishnan, printed p. 224; attribution to the lecturer as mediated by the note-taker.)
2. **Translator's note:** The two arguments are distinct: one begins with the primacy and purity of existential reality, the other with the causal dependence of contingent existents.
3. **Source:** Bidayat al-Hikma, supplied bilingual PDF (Arabic original) · p. 283 https://lib.rafed.net/m/?b_id=1571&type=c_fbook

CHAPTER 2

The unity of the Necessary Existent

الفصل الثاني في إثبات وحدانيته تعالى

The Necessary Existent, exalted is He, is the pure reality of existence, which has no second. This establishes His unity as *true unity* (al-waḥda al-ḥaqqa), in which multiplicity cannot even be supposed. Anything posited as a second instance of this pure reality returns to the first, because no basis of distinction remains. Numerical unity differs: when a second unit is posited alongside the first, there are now two, and further units can be added.

Another proof begins by supposing two or more Necessary Existents. They must be distinct in some respect while sharing the necessity of existence. What distinguishes them cannot be identical with what they share; their realities would therefore be composed of a common element and a distinguishing element. Composition entails dependence upon constituents, contradicting intrinsic necessity, which is pure independence.

Ibn Kammūna's objection asks why there could not be two simple individual realities whose essences are wholly different and unknowable to us, each necessary through itself. The single concept ‘Necessary Existent’ could be abstracted from them and predicated of both accidentally, without their sharing one constitutive quiddity.

The author replies that a truly one concept cannot be derived from entirely disparate instances *insofar as* they are disparate, for the reasons established earlier. Moreover, the objection attributes quiddities to the Necessary Existent, whereas His quiddity was shown to be identical with His existence. It would also make a quiddity necessitate existence although quiddity is derivative and existence original; a derivative principle cannot bestow existential originality.

Two further conclusions follow from this unity. First, the divine existence is not bounded by any privative limit excluding something beyond it. Second, the divine essence is simple in every possible respect. Any composition depends upon constituent parts whose being is required for the whole, and dependence contradicts necessity in itself.

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1. **Philosophical note:** Ibn Kammūna's objection concerns two utterly distinct simple necessary realities with the common concept ‘necessary existent’ predicated accidentally, not two instances of a shared genus.
2. **Source:** Bidayat al-Hikma, supplied bilingual PDF (Arabic original) · p. 285 https://lib.rafed.net/m/?b_id=1571&type=c_fbook

CHAPTER 3

The Necessary Existent as the source of all existence and perfection

الفصل الثالث في أن الواجب تعالى هو المبدأ المفيض لكل وجود وكمال وجودي

Every existent other than the Necessary Existent is contingent in itself, since intrinsic necessity belongs to Him alone. Every contingent existent has a quiddity equally related to existence and non-existence and needs a cause which determines its existence. If that cause is necessary in itself, we have reached the First. If it is necessary only through another, its existence must ultimately depend upon an intrinsically Necessary Existent. Therefore the Necessary Existent is the source that bestows existence upon every contingent quiddity.

There is another route to this conclusion. All contingent existences are intrinsically poor: their very actuality is dependent, and they are linking existences without independence either in origination or continuance. Their dependence must terminate in an existence independent in itself, wholly free of dependence upon another. This is the Necessary Existent, exalted is He.

He is therefore the bestower of existence upon everything else. And since He is the cause of their actualities, He is also the cause of their characteristic effects and the relations connecting them: the cause of a thing's being is the cause, in the relevant derivative order, of the effects and relations grounded in that being.

He alone is thus the original source of what is other than Himself, their possessor and governor, the Lord of the worlds without a rival.

An appendix addresses **dualism**. Dualists argued that good and evil are contraries and could not flow from one principle; therefore there must be two principles, one of good and another of evil.

A reply attributed to Plato treats evil as privation. Non-being does not require a positive cause that bestows it; its ‘cause’ is the lack of the corresponding good. In killing, for example, the evil is not the killer's power, which is a positive perfection in its own respect, nor the sword's sharpness or capacity to cut, nor the body's undergoing a physical effect considered simply as such. The evil lies in the destruction of the victim's life, which is privative. Other examples are analysed similarly.

Another reply, attributed to Aristotle, divides possible things into five: what is pure good; what contains much good and little evil; what contains equal good and evil; what contains much evil and little good; and what is pure evil. The first kind exists, as with wholly separate intellectual beings. The second also exists, as with material existents whose place within the overall order involves a greater good despite lesser evils; withholding their existence would entail the loss of that greater good.

The other three kinds do not exist in the proposed causal order. Producing equal good and evil would have no sufficient reason to favour its production; producing a preponderance of evil would favour the lesser good over the greater; and producing pure evil is plainly excluded. Thus the positive causal source acts directly for pure or predominant good. Lesser evil follows only incidentally upon the more extensive good with which it is connected.

The conclusion is that evil, insofar as it is privation, does not require a second positive creative principle opposed to the source of being.

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1. **Historical note:** The positions attributed to Plato, Aristotle, and the dualists are reported as they appear in this later philosophical source. Their historical accuracy requires separate primary-text investigation.
2. **Philosophical note:** That a negative condition lacks an independently productive cause does not remove the need to evaluate moral responsibility for harmful acts. The passage analyses the ontology of privation, not an excuse for deliberate injury.
3. **Source:** Bidayat al-Hikma, supplied bilingual PDF (Arabic original) · p. 287 https://lib.rafed.net/m/?b_id=1571&type=c_fbook

CHAPTER 4

The divine attributes and their predication

الفصل الرابع في صفات الواجب الوجود تعالى ومعنى اتصافه بها

The attributes of the Necessary Existent are first divided into two kinds. Some are established solely by the transcendent essence, without reference to anything external, such as His life and His knowledge of Himself. These are **essential attributes** (ṣifāt dhātiyya). Others are attributed only with a reference to something beyond the essence, such as creating, sustaining, and giving life. These are **attributes of action** (ṣifāt fiʿliyya). The latter are numerous and are abstracted from the domain of divine effects, not additional constituents of the essence. The present discussion concerns the essential attributes.

We have established that God is the source bestowing every existence and existential perfection. A cause giving a perfection must possess that perfection in a higher and nobler mode: what gives something does not lack it absolutely. God must therefore be qualified by the perfections of knowledge, power, and life.

Attributes are divided into **affirmative** and **negative**. Yet since the transcendent source of every perfection cannot be deprived of a true perfection, negative divine attributes deny deficiency or dependence, as in ‘not ignorant’, ‘not powerless’, or ‘not a substance’. Deficiency itself is the privation of perfection, so denying deficiency is, in meaning, the denial of a denial of perfection and thus an affirmation of perfection. ‘Not ignorant’ negates absence of knowledge and thereby affirms knowledge.

Affirmative attributes are further distinguished into **real** and **relational**, such as knowledge itself and the relation of knowing something. Real attributes may be purely real, as life, or real with a relational consideration, as knowledge of another.

Relational attributes are certainly not additional constituents of the transcendent essence; their meanings are intellectually considered and the essence cannot become the subject of a newly added categorial component. Negative attributes return, in the manner described, to the positive perfections.

Four theories concerning real affirmative attributes are discussed. **First**, the attributes are identical with the divine essence, and each attribute is identical in reality with the others. **Second**, they are distinct additional entities, necessarily accompanying the essence and eternal with it. **Third**, they are additional and originated. **Fourth**, the essence is said to act *in place of* attributes without possessing their realities: for example, to call God knowing would mean only that His action resembles the well-ordered and precise action of a knower.

The author adopts the first view, attributed to the philosophers. Since God is the source of every existential perfection and a giver of perfection cannot lack it, all perfections that proceed from Him must be present in the divine essence. But the pure necessary essence cannot be composed of distinct actual attributes. Therefore every perfection is identical with the essence and, by that identity, with every other perfection. Knowledge, power, and life differ in the concepts we employ, yet their real referent is the one transcendent existence.

An objection sometimes attributes creation to divine will rather than to the essence itself. But if will is an essential attribute identical with the essence, attributing causation to will rather than essence adds nothing to the explanation. If will is an attribute of action abstracted from produced effects, those effects are logically prior to the relation abstracted from them; they cannot themselves be explained by the derived relation as by a prior cause. Moreover, the proposal risks making divine creation only figuratively attributable to God.

The second view, attributed here to the Ashʿarīs, treats life, power, knowledge, hearing, sight, will, and speech as eternal attributes distinct from the essence. If these seven attributes subsisted independently without causes and were each necessary in itself, there would be eight intrinsically necessary existents—the essence and seven attributes—contradicting the proof of divine unity.

If the attributes are effects, their cause must be either another reality or the divine essence. If another were their source, their existence would ultimately depend upon an intrinsically necessary cause distinct from the Necessary Existent so qualified, or the divine essence would depend upon another to possess its perfections. Both are impossible on the preceding principles. If the essence

produced the attributes, it would be causally prior to perfections it did not already possess, yet a cause of perfection cannot lack what it bestows. The doctrine would make the pure necessary essence intrinsically bereft of knowledge, power, and life, contrary to the thesis that every existential perfection belongs to it.

The third view, attributed here to the Karrāmiyya, treats the attributes as additional and temporally originated. This would make the divine essence a receptive subject analogous to matter, capable of receiving new perfections. It would entail composition and prior deficiency, both incompatible with necessary existence.

The fourth view, associated here with the Muʿtazila, holds that the essence acts in the place of the attributes without itself possessing the perfections signified. The author objects that this again deprives the pure reality of existence of actual perfections, contrary to its definition and to its being the source of all such perfections.

Thus the author concludes that the real essential attributes are conceptually distinct but are, in existential actuality, identical with the simple necessary essence.

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1. **Historical-critical note:** The doxography of Ashʿarī, Muʿtazilī, and Karrāmī attributes is a polemical philosophical presentation, not a complete or neutral account of each school's technical distinctions between subsistence, accidents, realities, and divine predicates. Cross-check against primary kalām texts.
2. **Terminological note:** Essential attributes (ṣifāt dhātiyya) and attributes of action (ṣifāt fiʿliyya) are divided by dependence upon reference to effects. Identity in external reality does not eliminate conceptual differentiation between knowledge, power, and life.
3. **Source:** Bidayat al-Hikma, supplied bilingual PDF (Arabic original) · p. 291 https://lib.rafed.net/m/?b_id=1571&type=c_fbook

CHAPTER 5

Divine knowledge

الفصل الخامس في علمه تعالى

It has been established that every immaterial existent knows itself, since its essence is present to itself. This presence constitutes its self-knowledge.

It has also been established that the transcendent essence is pure existence, limited by nothing and lacking no existence or existential perfection. Consequently, whatever existence or perfection occurs throughout the detailed order of creation is possessed by Him in a higher and more excellent mode. These perfections are not distinguished in His essence as separate components. They are thus known through a *summary knowledge that is at the same time detailed disclosure* (ʿilm ijmālī fī ʿayn al-kashf al-tafṣīlī).

Furthermore, since other existents are His effects, their very being depends upon Him as linking existence depends upon an independent principle. Their actualities are present to Him, and He therefore knows them by presence at the rank of their own existence: immaterial beings through themselves, material beings through their immaterial forms.

The Necessary Existent consequently has knowledge by presence of Himself; detailed knowledge of things at the rank of His essence, prior to producing them, which is identical with that essence; and detailed knowledge of things at their own created ranks, which is not an additional constituent of the divine essence. Knowledge of His effects also includes knowledge of the cognition those effects possess.

Since hearing and seeing, considered according to their essential cognitive meaning, are knowledge of audible and visible things, these perfections belong under knowledge. God is therefore Hearing and Seeing, just as He is Knowing and Aware.

Other accounts of divine knowledge. The author reviews ten positions and objections, distinguishing each from his preceding conclusion.

1. Knowledge of self alone. Some hold that the divine essence knows itself but not its effects, because the essence is eternal whereas its effects are originated. The reply is that an eternal cognition of an effect does not require that the effect already possess its own distinctive existence from eternity.

2. Established non-existent quiddities. A position attributed to certain Muʿtazilīs says that quiddities possess a kind of objective establishment while non-existent, and that divine knowledge is related to them before their production. The author rejects this because he has already denied a positive establishment belonging to non-existents simply as non-existent.

3. Intellectual establishment through names and attributes. A position attributed to the Sufis holds that contingent quiddities subsist in knowledge as dependent upon divine names and attributes, and are known before their external production. The author objects that the primacy of existence and derivative status of quiddities exclude the supposed establishment of quiddity prior to its own particular external existence.

4. Separate luminous Forms. A position attributed to Plato locates detailed divine knowledge in separate luminous exemplars or divine Forms gathering the perfections of species. Even granting such Forms, the author argues, they would explain detailed knowledge at the rank of those Forms, not detailed knowledge identical with the divine essence. The essence would otherwise lack a perfection of knowledge, contrary to its being pure existence without privation.

5. The presence of all existents. A position attributed to the master of Illumination and later thinkers says that all things, material and immaterial, are present to God by their own existences, and this constitutes His detailed knowledge. The author objects that materiality as such does not admit cognitive presence in the manner established in his theory of knowledge. Moreover, the explanation reaches only the rank of things themselves, not detailed knowledge at the rank of the divine essence; it therefore inherits the deficiency of the previous proposal.

6. Knowledge mediated by the First Intellect. A position attributed to Thales of Miletus says that God knows the First Intellect, His first effect, through that intellect's presence to Him, while the forms of other things are impressed upon the First Intellect and thereby become known. The earlier objection still applies: knowledge mediated in that way would not secure detailed knowledge at the rank of the divine essence.

7. Successive graded knowledge. Another account identifies the divine essence with detailed knowledge of the first effect but only summary knowledge of everything below it. The first effect is then detailed knowledge of the second and summary knowledge of what follows, and so on. This inherits the same difficulty concerning comprehensive detailed knowledge in the First Principle.

8. Union with the intelligible. A position attributed to Porphyry explains divine knowing through union with the intelligible. The author replies that this may describe *how* knowledge obtains—by union rather than by an accidental form inhering in a subject—but does not by itself explain detailed divine knowledge of things before their production. The earlier objection remains.

9. Summary before, detailed after production. A position ascribed to many later thinkers says that God's self-knowledge includes all things only in summary, while detailed knowledge of them arises after their existence, since cognition follows what is known and there is no known object before an object exists. This again fails to provide detailed knowledge at the rank of the divine essence. Moreover, the presupposition that divine knowledge consists in the impression or acquisition of forms is rejected.

10. Peripatetic knowledge through universal forms. A position attributed to the Peripatetics holds that, before producing things, God knows their quiddities in their ordered relations as forms present to His essence. These do not enter His essence as constitutive parts or unite with it; rather, they subsist for it in a mental mode. The knowledge is *universal* in the sense that it does not vary as the external thing changes. It is a providential knowledge (ʿilm ʿināʾī) in which the cognitive order is followed by its external actualisation.

According to the author, many theologians adopt something analogous to this theory's assumption of acquired knowledge before creation, despite rejecting and criticising the application of ‘universal’ to divine knowledge. They still posit forms of acquired knowledge remaining the same before and after the things exist.

The theory has the deficiencies already noted. In addition, it attributes acquired or representational cognition to a being wholly free of matter in essence and action, whereas the author's earlier account denies that such a being has acquired knowledge. It also posits mental existence without an extramental existence relative to which that mental mode is defined. The supposed mental forms would thereby become another order of actual existence of the things before their individual external existence, separate from the divine essence, returning in substance to the theory of separate Forms.

The author's own solution is therefore neither bare self-knowledge excluding effects, nor separately subsisting exemplars, nor additional acquired forms in the divine essence. It is the presence of every existential perfection in pure necessary existence in an undivided but fully disclosive mode, together with each produced effect's presence to its first cause at its own created rank.

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1. **Historical-critical note:** All ten doctrines are reported and critiqued from al-Ṭabāṭabāʾī's philosophical standpoint. His attributions to the Muʿtazila, Sufis, Plato, Illuminationists, Thales, Porphyry, Peripatetics, and later theologians require checking against each school's primary sources before use as a doctrinal history.
2. **Terminological note:** ʿIlm ijmālī fī ʿayn al-kashf al-tafṣīlī is not a merely vague or deficient summary: the author means an undivided essential knowledge with full disclosure of differentiated perfections. He distinguishes knowledge at the rank of the essence from knowledge of effects at their own ranks.
3. **Source:** Bidayat al-Hikma, supplied bilingual PDF (Arabic original) · p. 297 https://lib.rafed.net/m/?b_id=1571&type=c_fbook

CHAPTER 6

Divine power

الفصل السادس في قدرته تعالى

Power (*qudra*) has been defined as being a source of action through knowledge. Every contingent existence ultimately proceeds from the transcendent divine essence, for beyond contingent being there is only necessary existence, without restriction or condition. God is therefore the source of everything. His knowledge is identical with His essence, which is the principle from which contingent effects proceed. Consequently He possesses power, and that power is identical with His essence.

First objection: voluntary human actions. A human's chosen acts are attributed to the human soul, for a person acts if he wills and refrains if he does not. If these acts were produced by God and came under His power, the person would seem to be compelled rather than free. Accordingly,

the objector concludes, human voluntary actions must fall outside divine power, and that power cannot extend to everything.

Reply. To call an action voluntary does not mean that it remains equally related to occurrence and non-occurrence at the very moment it actually occurs. A contingent thing cannot come into existence without one alternative being determined over the other. A voluntary action, like every other contingent effect, requires a complete cause from which it cannot fail to follow; relative to this complete cause it is necessary *through another*.

But relative to the human being, considered as one constituent of that complete causal complex, the action remains possible. The same is true of other incomplete causal conditions, such as receptive matter and the temporal, spatial, and other circumstances of action. Thus there is no contradiction between a voluntary act's possibility relative to one constituent of its cause and its necessity relative to the complete cause.

Every necessity through another ultimately terminates in intrinsic necessity, and there is no intrinsically Necessary Existent but God. Therefore divine power extends even to voluntary human acts.

A second argument starts from the dependent character of effects. Human actions, like other contingent things, have causes; the existence of any effect is linking existence in relation to its cause. Such a dependent existent cannot obtain without an independent principle sustaining it. Ultimately all such dependence rests upon the one intrinsically independent Necessary Existent. God is therefore the first principle of every effect and has power over everything.

Second objection: divine willing and foreknowledge entail compulsion. If divine power extends to voluntary actions, the divine will must concern those actions, and what God wills cannot fail to occur. The actions then occur necessarily, apparently eliminating human choice. Likewise, a future action known infallibly to God must occur, or divine knowledge would become ignorance. Does this not make the action compelled?

Reply. Divine will concerns the act *as it is*. In itself the voluntary human action proceeds through a human chooser who is a constituent of the complete causal explanation. The fact that the act is possible relative to that human agent does not change merely because divine will concerns it. God wills the occurrence of the particular action **through the person's choice**: He wills that the person should perform it voluntarily. The infallibility of the divine will therefore does not turn the act into something performed without choice.

The reply concerning eternal knowledge is parallel. Divine knowledge apprehends the act under its own true character—as a voluntary action that the human being is able to perform or to omit under the corresponding circumstances. Knowledge does not alter its object's nature. If the action did not occur as voluntary, the purported knowledge of it as voluntary would be false, which is impossible.

Third objection: necessary action seems to restrict divine power. If the contingency of an effect is overcome by necessity through its cause, and that cause ultimately terminates in God, the divine act itself seems necessary. God would then be an agent *necessitated* to act, unable to refrain, so universal divine power would lose its meaning.

Reply. Necessity is abstracted from existence. Just as the effect receives existence from its cause, it receives necessity through that cause. But an attribute that follows upon the effect's existence cannot turn back and become the cause of the very cause from which it follows. The necessity that proceeds from divine efficacy towards the effect does not impose necessity upon God from outside or deprive His essence of power.

God is, consequently, free by His very essence. Compulsion would require another principle beyond the agent imposing something contrary to the agent's own tendency or determining what the agent does not intrinsically determine. There is nothing beyond the Necessary Existent that could impose such a compulsion; His effects accord with His causality. The acts proceeding from Him are those His essence itself determines and chooses.

The reconciliation proposed here therefore rests on three different explanatory orders: the human act as possible relative to its human participant; its necessity relative to the complete causal complex; and divine power and choice as the unrestricted originating principle of that complex.

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1. **Philosophical note:** The text's reconciliation of human choice and the necessity of a complete cause is the author's account of agency, not a neutral summary of all Ashʿarī, Māturīdī, Muʿtazilī, or philosophical theories of free will. The distinction between relative possibility and necessity through a complete cause carries the argument.
2. **Terminological note:** ‘Necessitating’ in the pejorative sense of an externally compelled agent (mūjab) is distinguished from an effect's necessity through its cause (wujūb bi-l-ghayr). The latter is said to follow from the agent's efficacy rather than to constrain it.
3. **Source:** Bidayat al-Hikma, supplied bilingual PDF (Arabic original) · p. 303 https://lib.rafed.net/m/?b_id=1571&type=c_fbook

CHAPTER 7

Divine life

الفصل السابع في حياته تعالى

Among us, a living being is one that perceives and acts. Life is therefore the principle of perception and activity, or the principle of knowledge and power; alternatively, it is that which inseparably accompanies knowledge and power.

We predicate life of ourselves even though, in our case, knowledge and power are additional perfections distinct from our essential reality. It is still more appropriate to predicate life of a reality in which knowledge and power exist as identical with the essence itself, as they do in the intrinsically Necessary Existent.

God is therefore life and living through His own essence. Moreover, He bestows life upon every living being, and what bestows a perfection cannot be wholly deprived of that perfection.

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1. **Terminological note:** The predicate ‘living’ is applied by reference to the perfections of knowledge and power, without implying that divine life is a biological or composite form.
2. **Source:** Bidayat al-Hikma, supplied bilingual PDF (Arabic original) · p. 307 https://lib.rafed.net/m/?b_id=1571&type=c_fbook

CHAPTER 8

Divine will and speech

الفصل الثامن في إرادته تعالى وكلامه

Some philosophers have said that the divine will is God's knowledge of the best possible order, or, expressed another way, His knowing that a given act is good. Under this interpretation will is an aspect of divine knowledge, just as hearing understood as knowledge of audible things and sight understood as knowledge of visible things are aspects of knowledge. Thus divine will would be identical with the divine essence.

These philosophers also offer an account of *speech*. In ordinary usage speech is an articulated expression that signifies and discloses a meaning present in the speaker's mind. There is therefore a conventional entity, the expression, whose instituted or customary signification points to another entity, the meaning understood.

But suppose there were a real existent that naturally signified another real existent, such as an effect making its cause known or a perfection in an effect revealing a fuller perfection in its cause. Such a real and natural signification would possess a stronger claim to the name *speech* than a merely conventional linguistic sign.

Suppose further that there were a reality absolutely one in essence, possessing perfections within itself, whose manifold perfections and the effects proceeding from it disclose its one existence. The Necessary Existent would have an even stronger claim to the designation *speech*. In this sense the divine essence reveals itself by its own existence, and God is described as speaking through the existence of His essence for Himself.

The author's assessment. These explanations analytically reduce the meanings of will and speech to certain aspects of knowledge and power. On this account there is no philosophical necessity for establishing them as separate essential perfections distinct from knowledge and power.

The author adds, however, that the will and speech attributed to God in the Qurʾān and Sunnah are intended as **attributes of action** under the account of such attributes to be given, God willing. One must therefore distinguish the preceding philosophical analyses of the concepts from their attribution in revealed discourse.

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1. **Translator's note:** The paragraph about real signification of an effect is an analogy proposed in a philosophical account of divine kalām. The author then distinguishes attributes of action from separately asserted attributes of essence. This should not be conflated with the detailed kalām disputes about created or eternal divine speech.
2. **Source:** Bidayat al-Hikma, supplied bilingual PDF (Arabic original) · p. 309 https://lib.rafed.net/m/?b_id=1571&type=c_fbook

CHAPTER 9

Divine action and its divisions

الفصل التاسع في فعله تعالى وانقساماته

Divine action, taken to mean the *produced effect*—the existence that proceeds from God—admits the divisions established earlier: immaterial and material, fixed and flowing, and others. The present chapter recalls the three universal worlds: the world of intellect, the imaginal world, and the material world.

The **intellectual world** is free both from matter and from the effects or characteristics of matter.

The **imaginal world** is separate from matter but not from its characteristics, including dimensions, figures, and positions. It contains corporeal likenesses represented under forms resembling bodies in the material world, with an order corresponding to the order of material forms. Yet the succession of imaginal forms is an order of existence, not a passage of one material form into another through the actualisation of potency, as occurs in material motion. The succession of imaginal forms resembles the ordered forms of imagination representing movement and change: the cognitive form is immaterial, without potency or alteration in itself. It is *knowledge of change*, not a changing act of knowledge under the same respect.

The **material world** comprises material substances and the accidents accompanying them.

These three worlds are ordered in existence. The intellectual world is prior to the imaginal, and the imaginal prior to the material. Pure actuality, unmixed with potency, is more intense in existence than what is potential or mixed with potency, so the separate existent precedes what is conjoined with matter.

Moreover, the separate intellect is less bounded and restricted, more extensive and simpler in being, than the imaginal existent. The stronger and more expansive a degree of existence, the higher its place in the graded order and the closer it is to the First Principle, pure existence without limitation or deficient perfection. Thus intellect has the highest existential rank of the three, followed by the imaginal and then the material.

This order is also an order of **causality**: the intellectual world is a cause bestowing existence upon the imaginal, and the imaginal upon the material.

Since a cause contains the effect's perfection in a higher and more excellent mode, the worlds correspond to one another. The imaginal world has an order resembling that of the material world but more perfect than it. The intellectual world contains a corresponding order in a simpler, more comprehensive mode. Both correspond ultimately to the providential order present in the Necessary Existent's knowledge.

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1. **Terminological note:** The order of intellect, imaginal existence, and matter is ontological and causal here; ‘prior’ must not be read simply as earlier in physical time.
2. **Philosophical note:** Imaginal representation of change and material change differ in the actual succession of their forms. The author is not denying that material time has genuine motion.
3. **Source:** Bidayat al-Hikma, supplied bilingual PDF (Arabic original) · p. 311 https://lib.rafed.net/m/?b_id=1571&type=c_fbook

CHAPTER 10

Separate intellect and the problem of multiplicity

الفصل العاشر في العقل المفارق وكيفية حصول الكثرة فيه لو كانت فيه كثرة

A quiddity is multiplied into numerous **individuals of one species** only through an association with matter. The proof considers what numerical plurality could be in relation to the species. It would have to be the entire essence, an essential constituent, an inseparable concomitant, or a separable determination outside the essence.

The first three possibilities make the existence of even one individual impossible. Whenever an individual of the quiddity occurred, numerical plurality would be required because plurality would belong inseparably to the quiddity. Yet every plurality comprises units; each unit, because it exemplifies the same quiddity, would itself have to be plural, and each of its units likewise. No true unit could ever be reached, and without units no plurality could exist. This is absurd.

Individual multiplication must therefore arise from an additional, **separable** determination of the species, something whose reception is possible for its individuals. This receptivity requires matter. Hence every species with many individuals is material, and by contraposition a wholly immaterial species cannot possess multiple individuals of that same specific quiddity.

A qualification is necessary. Distinct individual intellective souls can attain complete immateriality if individuals of an originally material species, such as humanity, are perfected through substantial motion from material potency into immaterial actuality. They can preserve the individual distinction acquired while their existence was material. Thus individual plurality can *persist into* immaterial actuality even though it is not first originated as multiplication within a species originally and wholly separate from matter.

If there is plurality among separate intellects not arising in that way, it must be **specific plurality**: distinct intellectual species, each with a single individual.

Such a plurality admits two arrangements. In a **vertical order**, one intellect causes another, and this one another, through a determinate series; successive intellects are distinct in species and earlier members are efficient causes of later ones. In a **horizontal order**, several distinct intellectual species are neither causes nor effects of one another, but all proceed from one intellect above them.

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1. **Translator's note:** The exception for human intellective souls is important. The argument excludes original numerical plurality within one wholly separate species, not the continued individuality of souls whose histories begin in material existence.
2. **Source:** Bidayat al-Hikma, supplied bilingual PDF (Arabic original) · p. 314 https://lib.rafed.net/m/?b_id=1571&type=c_fbook

CHAPTER 11

Hierarchical intellects and their first effects

الفصل الحادي عشر في العقول الطولية وأول ما يصدر منها

Since the Necessary Existent is absolutely one and simple in every respect, a multiplicity of effects, precisely as a multiplicity, cannot proceed directly from Him—whether those effects are immaterial, like the horizontally arranged intellects, or material, like material species. The principle is that from the one, insofar as it is one, only one proceeds.

The first effect proceeding directly from God is therefore **one intellect**, whose single derivative or shadow-like existence reflects, in a dependent mode, the unity of necessary existence.

Its being *first* means that it precedes other contingent existents in the order of existence and causality. It is thus an intermediary cause through which what lies beneath it proceeds from the First Principle.

This does not limit divine power, which was shown to be identical with the unrestricted necessary essence. The production of multiple disconnected effects *as many* directly from what is purely one *as one* has been argued to be intrinsically impossible. Power concerns what is possible. Intrinsic impossibilities—denying a thing of itself, conjoining contradictories or excluding both—have no possible essence upon which power could operate. Their lack of actuality therefore does not constitute a limitation on divine power.

Although the First Intellect is one and its procession is simple, it is contingent. It therefore has a derivative, intellectually considered quiddity, since possibility is considered with reference to quiddity. It also knows itself and knows the Necessary Existent. In these respects there is an intelligible multiplicity of aspects within it, sufficient to make it capable of being the source of more than one effect.

The imaginal world below the intellectual world, however, contains a multiplicity far exceeding what can issue from the small number of distinguishable aspects in the First Intellect. A **second intellect**, then a **third**, and further intellects must proceed, until the plurality of principles is sufficient for the emergence of the imaginal world beneath them.

There must accordingly be a vertical multiplicity of separate intellects, although the author acknowledges that we have no means of determining their total number.

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1. **Philosophical note:** This passage is a metaphysical derivation of a hierarchical procession, not an observation of a specified number of separate intellects. The author expressly leaves their number unknown.
2. **Terminology:** ‘The one produces only one’ has a restricted causal sense (‘the one qua one’), not an indiscriminate rule against every variety of indirect multiplicity or mediated causation.
3. **Source:** Bidayat al-Hikma, supplied bilingual PDF (Arabic original) · p. 316 https://lib.rafed.net/m/?b_id=1571&type=c_fbook

CHAPTER 12

Intellects at the same level

الفصل الثاني عشر في العقول العرضية

The Illuminationists affirm the existence of **horizontal intellects**, neither causes nor effects of one another, corresponding to the material species of our world. Each governs the material species corresponding to it. They are called the **Lords of the Species** (arbāb al-anwāʿ) and **Platonic Forms**, since Plato is said to have defended their existence.

The Peripatetics reject these horizontal intellects. They attribute the governing operations ascribed to them to the last of the vertically ordered intellects, which they call the **Active Intellect**.

Advocates of horizontal intellects differ in their accounts of what they are. According to a position regarded as especially sound by some, every material species has an immaterial individual at the first rank of existence, possessing in actuality all the perfections possible for that species. It attends to the material individuals corresponding to it and governs them through their specific substantial forms, bringing their potentialities into actuality by substantial motion and by the associated accidental motions.

Several arguments have been offered to establish these Lords of the Species.

First argument: the ordering of living forms. The vegetative powers of nutrition, growth, and generation are accidents inhering in the plant's body; they vary as the body varies, and dissolve as it dissolves. They possess no conscious awareness or intellectual knowledge. They cannot therefore, it is argued, be the sufficient principles producing the diverse organised activities, intricate structures, elegant forms, and exact arrangements that inspire astonishment in those examining natural living beings. An immaterial intellectual substance must govern the plant and direct it towards its perfection.

Reply. Even if an intellectual cause is needed, there is no reason why the actions attributed to a special Lord of each species could not be assigned to another cause. The actions of each species depend upon its specific form, and above it lies the final intellect acknowledged by the Peripatetics, the Active Intellect. The argument has not demonstrated the existence of an additional distinct horizontal intellect.

Second argument: the stable order of natural species. The specific kinds encountered in this world display characteristic orders that persist rather than arising by mere accident. Such enduring order must have real causes. Its explanation cannot simply be deferred to temperament or similar material conditions without proof, the argument maintains. Each species must have a universal exemplar governing its operations. ‘Universal’ here does not mean a concept predicable of many, but a separate principle whose relation to all individuals of its species is equal because it is immaterial.

Reply. The distinctive operations and effects of a species are attributed to its specific substantial form; without this form the thing would not constitute that species. Its special accidents are evidence of a substantial principle that is their proximate cause, just as accidents common to material things are evidence of an underlying common subject.

The agent of the order found in the species is therefore its specific substantial form. The cause of that form is an immaterial substance that bestows it upon prepared matter. Specific forms differ according to the dispositions of the matter prepared for them.

But whether the immaterial source is a horizontal intellect uniquely devoted to the species, or one of the vertical intellects from which the various material species proceed, is not settled by this argument. The stated observations therefore do not demonstrate a distinct Lord of each species.

Third argument: the possibility of a nobler being. According to the principle of the possibility of the nobler (*qāʿidat imkān al-ashraf*), when an inferior possible existent is actual, a nobler possible existent must exist prior to it. The principle is regarded as demonstrable. An immaterial human already actual in every human perfection would be nobler than a material human still potential in many of its perfections. Therefore, the presence of material human beings seems to prove the existence of a separate intellectual exemplar or Lord of the human species.

Reply. The principle's use here requires that the nobler and inferior share the *same specific quiddity*. Only then would the actual existence of an inferior individual establish the possibility of a nobler individual of that very species.

But the fact that a **concept** applies to something does not establish that the thing is a specific individual of the corresponding quiddity. The concept ‘knowledge’, for example, may be applied to knowledge by presence without implying that knowledge by presence is a psychical quality under the ordinary categorial account.

Likewise, it is possible that what fulfils the concept of the universal human understood by the intellect is in fact one of the vertical intellects possessing the existential perfections of material kinds in an elevated mode. The concept ‘human’ would apply to that intellect because it contains human existential perfections, not because it is a separate individual of the human species in the same specific quiddity.

Consequently, the fact that the universal concept ‘human’ applies to a separate intellectual reality does not prove that this reality is an individual of the specific human quiddity, or that a separate Platonic exemplar of human beings exists.

The author therefore does not regard these three arguments as establishing the particular ontology of horizontal Lords of Species, even where they successfully point to immaterial causes and the intelligibility of natural order.

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1. **Philosophical note:** The author distinguishes a genus/species claim (‘this entity instantiates the same quiddity’) from an analogical or existential attribution of shared perfection. This distinction is essential to his rejection of the third proof.
2. **Historical-critical note:** ‘Platonic Forms’, ‘Lords of Species’, ‘Active Intellect’, and the principle of possibility of the nobler are reported within the text's later Illuminationist–Peripatetic debate. They should not be flattened into a claim that Plato and Suhrawardī used identical technical doctrines.
3. **Source:** Bidayat al-Hikma, supplied bilingual PDF (Arabic original) · p. 318 https://lib.rafed.net/m/?b_id=1571&type=c_fbook

The imaginal realm

الفصل الثالث عشر في المثال

The **imaginal world** is called *barzakh*, because it occupies the intermediate rank between separate intellect and material substance. It is also called **separate imagination** (al-khayāl al-munfaṣil), because it is independent of animal imagination, which is connected to the individual soul.

As explained earlier, it is a rank of existence separated from matter but not from the characteristics of material things, such as extension, figure, and position.

It contains particular substantial forms proceeding from the last of the vertically ordered intellects —the Active Intellect in the Peripatetic account—or from the horizontal intellects according to the Illuminationists.

These imaginal forms are multiple according to the plurality of aspects in the intellect that bestows them. They are represented under diverse shapes, without that diversity destroying the one individual identity of each of their relevant substantial grounds.

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1. **Terminological note:** The separate imaginal realm (*khayāl munfaṣil*) is ontologically distinguished from a person's connected or psychological imagination (*khayāl muttaṣil*).
2. **Source:** Bidayat al-Hikma, supplied bilingual PDF (Arabic original) · p. 322 https://lib.rafed.net/m/?b_id=1571&type=c_fbook

CHAPTER 14

The material world

الفصل الرابع عشر في العالم المادي

The **material world** is the world immediately witnessed through the senses, the lowest and least perfect rank of existence. It differs from the higher realms because its forms are joined to matter and are subject to potency and preparedness.

Every material existent begins with many of its perfections in potentiality, and attains them through some gradual process of change or motion. Its development may also be obstructed. Thus this world is a domain of interference and mutual impediment among causes and tendencies.

Natural and mathematical investigation has established much about the constituents of this world, their configurations and relationships, and the order governing them. It may nevertheless be that what remains unknown is greater than what is known.

In virtue of the existential connection of its parts, the material world is **one flowing reality**, moving in its substantial existence with its accidents following upon that movement. Within this general motion there are more specific substantial developments of vegetative, animal, and human forms. As argued in the stage on potentiality and actuality, the terminus towards which such motion tends is the moving being's complete immaterial perfection.

Because this world moves in substance and flows in its very actuality, its mode of existence is itself renewal and change. This makes its dependence upon a fixed or unchanging cause intelligible. The immutable producer produces **a renewed being**. He does not produce an already separate static thing and then add renewal to it. Hence the supposed difficulty of attributing what changes to an unchanging cause, or linking what is originated to what is beginningless, does not arise in the form alleged.

The book is complete. Praise belongs to God. The author records that he finished composing it on the seventh day of Rajab in the lunar Hijrī year 1390, at the sacred sanctuary of al-Riḍā, upon whom be the best peace and greetings.

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1. **Translator's note:** ‘The fixed agent produces the renewed’ is the conclusion of the author's argument concerning substantial motion and the unchanging First Cause. It concerns the actual mode of being produced, not an arbitrary causal addition of motion to a static substance.
2. **Colophon:** Authorial colophon: 7 Rajab 1390 AH, at the sanctuary of Imam al-Riḍā. The date follows the Arabic text as transmitted in the present source; no Gregorian conversion is imposed.
3. **Source:** Bidayat al-Hikma, supplied bilingual PDF (Arabic original) · p. 324 https://lib.rafed.net/m/?b_id=1571&type=c_fbook

111 original passages; 111 with working English. Not a specialist-certified critical edition.